



UNIVERSITÀ DEGLI STUDI DI ROMA LA SAPIENZA

PART I

Philosophical Foundations of Cyber and Computer Law



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Lecture of 03/03/2026

1.1 Fusion of Horizons

Definition 1.1 (Fusion of Horizons). *The integration of different intellectual perspectives, in particular those of technicians and philosophers, in order to better understand the meaning, implications, and functioning of technological systems.*

Today, collaboration between **technicians** and **jurists** has become almost unavoidable. Modern technological systems raise legal questions that require continuous interaction between those who design technologies and those who regulate them.

The collaboration between **technicians** and **philosophers**, however, is often more difficult. Philosophers tend to raise questions and highlight conceptual problems rather than providing immediate solutions. For this reason, in corporate environments their role may sometimes be perceived as problematic, since companies are typically oriented toward efficiency and practical outcomes.

Nevertheless, the idea of a *fusion of horizons* suggests that both sides can benefit from engaging with the perspective of the other.

On the one hand, it is useful for the **philosopher** to look inside technical procedures and try to understand how technological systems actually work.

On the other hand, it is equally important for the **technician** to raise their gaze and reflect **philosophically** on the meaning, implications, and responsibilities connected to their technical work.

The objective of this interaction is to create a dialogue in which technical expertise and philosophical reflection mutually enrich each other.

1.2 Cyber and Computer Law: Method and Object

In this course we will focus on two central aspects: the **how**, namely the **methodology**, and the **what**, that is the **object of study**. To make the discussion more stimulating, these two aspects will be presented together, using the methodology adopted in the course itself to explain its subject.

Let us start from the title of the course: **Cyber and Computer Law**. The three key terms are therefore **cyber**, **computer**, and **law**. These are words that most students have already encountered, but it is still useful to clarify their meaning.

1.2.1 Cyber

We begin with the term **cyber**, which today has a well-known meaning.

Definition 1.2 (Cyber). *Commonly, anything related to digital technologies, including algorithms, digital infrastructures, and digital information systems.*

In contemporary language, therefore, the prefix **cyber-** broadly refers to phenomena connected with the digital environment.

Historically, however, the term derives from **cybernetics**.

Definition 1.3 (Cybernetics). *The discipline concerned with control and communication in machines and systems.*

This word itself originates from the Greek term κυβερνήτης (*kybernētēs*), which literally means *helmsman*, namely the person who pilots and steers a ship.

By extension, the term was also used to indicate someone who **guides or governs** a city or a state. The original meaning of the word therefore already contains the idea of **guidance, control, and governance**.

For this reason, the common modern definition of **cyber** as something simply related to digital infrastructures or digital information is only partially accurate. Looking at the **etymological root** of the term reveals a much more precise meaning.

Within the concept of **cybernetics** there is already a clear intention: the idea of **governing, guiding, and managing** systems. In other words, cybernetics implies a form of **dominion or control** over processes and mechanisms.

This also highlights an important conceptual distinction. The perspective of cybernetics is not merely oriented toward the **contemplation of reality**, but toward its **manipulation**. The objective is therefore not simply to observe how systems function, but to **intervene in them**, steer them, and regulate their behavior.

In 1965, **Martin Heidegger** delivered a lecture entitled *The End of Philosophy and the Task of Thinking*. From the title it is already clear that Heidegger does not claim that

thinking itself comes to an end; rather, what comes to an end is **thinking in its philosophical form**.

In 1966, during a famous interview with the German magazine *Der Spiegel* (“The Mirror”), Heidegger was asked: *Who will take the place of philosophy?* His answer was striking: **cybernetics**.

This answer must be understood in the context of Heidegger’s critical view of modern technology. Heidegger did not consider cybernetics to be merely a **neutral scientific or technical tool** that can be used for different purposes. Instead, he interpreted it as the **science of control**.

According to Heidegger, modern technological thinking tends to replace philosophical reflection with an **operational approach**, in which science and technology aim to reduce the complexity and richness of reality to a set of **manipulable data**. Heidegger describes this perspective through the idea that the world is treated as a kind of **storehouse of resources**. In his terminology, reality becomes a *Bestand* (a “pantry” or standing reserve): something that is no longer encountered for what it is in itself, but is instead viewed as a collection of resources that are always available to be calculated, ordered, optimized, controlled, and exploited.

This technological way of understanding reality also affects the **human being**. Instead of being regarded as a free, unique, and fundamentally unpredictable subject, the human being risks being reduced to a **component of the system**: a data point among many others, a numerical sequence, or a digital profile.

In this sense, the concept of **cyber** expresses not only a technological domain, but also a broader paradigm centered on **control**, **calculation**, and the transformation of reality into data that can be processed and governed.

1.2.2 Computer

Computer derives from the Latin expression *cum putare*. The prefix *cum* means *together* or *along with*, while the verb *putare* has several meanings that converge around a common conceptual core.

The first group of meanings of *putare* refers to intellectual activities such as *believing*, *thinking*, *considering*, *judging*, *supposing*, or *estimating*.

The second meaning, which is the one most closely related to the modern idea of a **computer**, refers to *calculating*, *doing mathematics*, *evaluating*, or *estimating* in a numerical or economic sense.

The third meaning is the most original one and has an **agricultural origin**. The verb *putare* originally meant *to prune*, that is, to cut the branches of a tree in order to clean it and create space. In Italian this meaning survives in the verb *potare*.

This etymology allows us to reflect on the relationship between **thinking** and **calculat-**

ing. Although both meanings are contained in the same Latin root, they are not identical activities. Calculating thought is typically **deterministic**, oriented toward producing a precise result through operations and procedures, whereas thinking in a broader sense is not necessarily directed toward an immediate output.

Following Heidegger's terminology, we can distinguish between **calculating thinking** and **meditative thinking**. These two forms of thought are both essential components of human reason. Throughout history they have alternated, sometimes one prevailing over the other, but always in a temporary and dynamic balance.

With the rise of **cybernetics**, however, this balance appears to be broken. Calculating thinking tends to dominate because it is faster, more efficient, more performative, and more easily integrated into technological systems. It is oriented toward productivity, optimization, and measurable results.

Meditative thinking, by contrast, does not necessarily aim at producing an immediate practical result. It is a form of thought that **contemplates reality** without the immediate intention of using or manipulating it. According to Heidegger, this form of thinking also has its own dignity and necessity for human beings.

However, within a cybernetic and technologically oriented society there is a tendency toward the disappearance of every form of **"useless" thought**. Here the word *useless* does not mean *without value*; rather, it refers to forms of thinking that are not primarily aimed at being used for a practical purpose.

In such a context, human existence risks being reduced to a mode of life dominated exclusively by **efficiency**. Within this framework there is little space for **art, poetry, leisure, boredom, or contemplation**.

At the same time, thinking and calculating still share a common element that reflects the original agricultural meaning of *putare*. Both activities require a process of **selection and elimination**: in order to think or to calculate, it is necessary to remove what is not relevant and to **clear the scene** from what is unnecessary.

1.2.3 Law

Before defining what **law** is, it is useful to ask a preliminary question: **where does this word come from?**

Commonly, law is described as a **norm**, a **regulation**, or a **set of rules** that governs behavior within a society. While this definition is correct, it only captures the functional aspect of the concept.

From a methodological perspective, it is important to investigate the **origin of the word itself**. This introduces one of the key methodological tools used in the course: the **analysis of words through their etymology**.

This method consists in questioning words and exploring the multiple layers of meaning

they contain. By doing so, it becomes possible to uncover elements related to their **history**, their **original meaning**, and the **cultural context** in which they emerged. Moreover, this approach also allows meaningful **comparisons between different languages**, revealing how the same concept may be expressed and understood differently across linguistic and cultural traditions.

Hermeneutics. The first methodological tool we introduce is **hermeneutics**. The term derives from the Greek word ἐρμηνευτική (*hermeneutikē*) and refers to the **art of interpretation**.

Hermeneutics is not merely a technical activity. Interpretation involves dimensions of human intelligence that cannot be fully reduced to procedures or algorithms. It requires judgment, contextual understanding, and the ability to grasp meanings that are not immediately explicit.

The word *hermeneutics* is connected to the Greek god **Hermes**. In Greek mythology, Hermes was the **messenger of the gods** and the protector of **travelers, merchants**, and also **thieves**. These seemingly different figures share an important common element: they are all involved in situations of **exchange** or **transaction**.

A messenger translates and conveys a message from one context to another. In this process, the original meaning cannot always be preserved entirely: translation requires adapting the content to a different language or context. Something of the original meaning may be lost, but what is gained is the **possibility of understanding**.

Similarly, travelers exchange **security for discovery**, leaving familiar environments in order to encounter new places and experiences. Merchants engage in exchanges of goods and value, while thieves risk punishment or imprisonment in exchange for potential profit. In all these activities there is therefore a form of **transaction**, where something is given up in order to obtain something else. Hermeneutics reflects this same dynamic: interpretation always involves a process of **transformation and exchange of meaning**.

Initially, **hermeneutics**, as an art, was intended to explain complex and sacred texts, such as **scriptures** or **laws**, in order to make them understandable to a wider audience. Over time, however, hermeneutics evolved into a **universal theory of understanding**. It studies how human beings interpret the world, how they orient themselves within it, and how their actions are guided by **beliefs, values, and purposes**.

In this sense, **interpretation** becomes an **existential tool**: it is the activity through which human beings make sense of their lives. One could say that life itself can be understood as a continuous process of interpretation.

Some important characteristics of interpretation can be highlighted.

First, every interpretation is **situated**. It is impossible to interpret a word independently from its **context**. A text is always embedded in a **context**, namely the environment of meaning within which the text is produced and understood.

Second, every interpretation is **inherited**. Our understanding is always embedded in a **tradition** that influences how we read and interpret things. We never approach a text or a concept with a completely neutral perspective.

This is also evident in the case of **language**. Language is not something we create from scratch when we come into the world; rather, we **find it already existing**. We enter a linguistic and cultural system that precedes us and shapes our way of understanding reality.

Words themselves can be understood as **meanings linked to signs**. However, unlike numbers, the meaning of words is **not stable**. A number such as 1, 4, or 7 has essentially the same meaning across cultures and historical periods. Words, instead, change their meaning depending on the historical and cultural context.

For example, the word *family* does not necessarily carry the same meaning in different contexts. The meaning of “family” in **16th century China** would differ significantly from the meaning of the same word in **Italy in 2026**. In order to grasp the full meaning of a word, it is therefore necessary to understand the **context** in which it is used.

Interpretation is often understood as the attempt to identify the **true meaning** of something, the **correct or orthodox interpretation**. However, according to **Heidegger**, interpretation is not limited to this task. It also involves the effort to **unveil the different layers of meaning** that are contained in words and concepts.

Words can be understood as **storages of experience**. Over time, words are used in different contexts and disciplines, and through this continuous use they accumulate new nuances and meanings. As a result, their meaning becomes richer and more complex.

For this reason, interpretation requires a process of **gradual unveiling**: the interpreter must explore the different layers of meaning embedded in words in order to bring to light what is often hidden or implicit.

Phenomenology. This activity of bringing phenomena to light, including what is not immediately visible, is precisely the purpose of **phenomenology**. The **phenomenological method** therefore constitutes the second philosophical tool used in this course.

In summary, the two main methodological tools are:

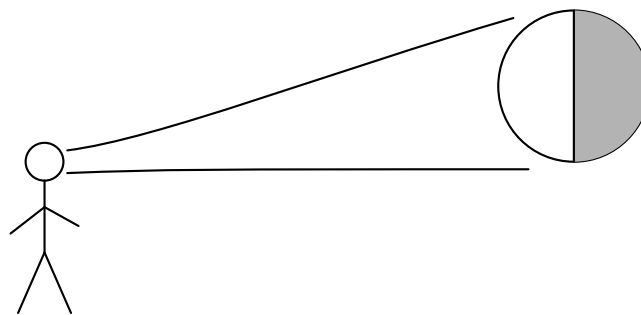
- **Hermeneutics**: the art of interpretation.
- **Phenomenology**: the method aimed at bringing phenomena and their hidden layers to light.

Phenomenology is concerned with describing **phenomena as they appear to us**. It starts from our perspective and relies on the tools available to us: **perception, thought, and language**. The aim is not to explain reality in abstract terms, but to describe how things **manifest themselves in experience**.

The word **phenomenology** derives from the Greek terms *phenomenon* and *logos*. The term *phenomenon* comes from the Greek verb φαίνομαι (*phainomai*), which means *to show oneself, to appear, or to seem*.

What is important in this notion is that appearing or showing oneself is never a purely autonomous act. Something **appears to someone**. In other words, every phenomenon presupposes a **relation**: there must be someone to whom something shows itself, someone to whom it appears, and someone who can say that it **seems** in a certain way.

For this reason, the concept of *phainomai* already implies a relational dimension between the **phenomenon** and the **subject who experiences it**.



When we observe a **phenomenon**, for example the **moon**, we always do so from a specific **perspective**. The observer is situated in a particular position that is not only geographical but also **historical and cultural**. Our interpretation is influenced by the time in which we live, our education, our beliefs, our family traditions, and the broader cultural context to which we belong.

Because of this situated perspective, we are only able to see **one side** of the phenomenon. Just as when we look at the moon we can only see the illuminated side while the other side remains hidden, our understanding of phenomena is always **partial**.

For this reason, phenomenology recognizes an important limitation: it does not claim that the observer possesses the **complete truth**. A phenomenologist is aware that any description of reality is always based on a **limited viewpoint**. To claim to possess the entire truth would therefore be misleading, because every perspective reveals only a portion of the phenomenon.

The task of phenomenology is therefore to **describe what appears**, that is, what can be directly experienced. At the same time, it also requires the awareness that there are aspects of the phenomenon that remain **hidden**.

To approach what is hidden, we make use of the other methodological tool introduced earlier: **hermeneutics**. Through hermeneutics we attempt to interpret and uncover the **historical layers and meanings** that lie beneath what immediately appears.

Together, **phenomenology** and **hermeneutics** form the small philosophical toolkit that allows us to analyze and understand the phenomena we encounter.

Law and Community. Law derives from the Latin term *lex*, which in turn is connected to the verb *legere*. The verb *legere* has multiple meanings, among which two are particularly relevant: **to read** and **to gather or tie together**. These meanings are closely related. When we read, in fact, we collect individual letters and words and connect them within a **context**, creating meaning from elements that are initially separate.

When applied to **law**, the idea of *legere* takes on a specific meaning: what is gathered together is a **community**. A society becomes a community because its members agree to live under a common set of rules. Law therefore connects individuals within a shared framework of norms.

This allows us to distinguish between **natural laws** and **human laws**. In nature, animals, plants, and physical systems follow laws such as **physical or biological laws**. These laws are not chosen and cannot be violated; natural entities do not decide whether to follow them. In a sense, they **are** the laws that govern them.

Human beings, however, cannot rely solely on instinct to regulate their collective life. For this reason, they must **establish laws**. Unlike natural laws, human laws can be violated because they are the result of **agreements** within a community.

Another important aspect is that human laws are expressed through **language**. Because laws are written in words, their meaning can change over time as language and society evolve. When social conditions change, it often becomes necessary to reinterpret or modify the **words of the law**.

The root *legere* also appears in the word **intelligence**. The Latin expression *inter-legere* can be understood as *to read between*, that is, to connect elements that initially appear unrelated. Intelligent behavior therefore consists in the ability to **connect different elements and generate new meaning**. Another related form is *intus-legere*, which suggests the idea of **reading within**, that is, grasping something at a deeper level.

It is also important to distinguish between **law** and **justice**. If the two concepts were identical, we would only need a single word. Laws are intended to promote justice, but they are not the same thing. Justice refers to the idea of treating people **fairly**, taking into account their differences. Equality in this sense does not mean that people are identical, but that individuals who are different are still recognized as **equal in dignity and consideration**.

For this reason, the study of law cannot be limited to learning the current legal rules. Laws constantly change, especially in fields affected by rapid technological development. In the context of **digital disruption**, technological innovation evolves much faster than legal regulation.

Jurists must first understand what is happening in society and technology, then reinterpret existing principles, and finally transform these principles into legal norms. This process requires time, and by the time a law is adopted, technology may already have advanced further.

Therefore, rather than focusing only on specific laws that may soon change, it is essential to understand the **principles and concepts underlying the law**. These conceptual tools allow us to orient ourselves within a legal landscape that is continuously evolving.

2

Lecture of 09/03/2026

2.1 Phenomenon

When we say that a **phenomenon appears**, the verb *to appear* has two different meanings at the same time.

First, appearing means **showing itself**. Something shows itself to someone who observes it and then speaks about it. This implies that phenomena never present themselves completely on their own: there must always be an **observer**. For this reason, when people say that we should “let the facts speak for themselves”, this is not entirely accurate. Facts cannot speak autonomously; someone must **interpret and describe** them.

Second, appearing also means **seeming**. When something appears in a certain way, it may not necessarily be exactly what it seems to be. In this sense, **appearing** is different from **being**. Something may appear to be one thing while in reality it may turn out to be something else.

This distinction becomes clearer through some examples.

If a single drop of rain falls, we cannot yet say that it is **raining**. However, if the drops multiply, thunder begins, and people start opening their umbrellas, then we can speak about the **phenomenon of rain**.

A similar situation occurs with illness. If someone sneezes or coughs once, it does not necessarily mean that they have the **flu**. It may simply be a temporary symptom, perhaps caused by tiredness or lack of sleep. Only when several symptoms appear together and persist over time can we identify the phenomenon of the flu.

The same reasoning can also be applied to **human or social phenomena**. For example, if we think about the early development of the **Internet**, the first email exchanged between two institutions in the 1990s did not yet constitute the phenomenon of the Internet. It was only an initial appearance that later expanded and developed into the global network we know today.

From these examples we can infer that, in order for something to truly qualify as a **phenomenon**, it must present both **qualitative** and **quantitative** consistency.

Qualitative consistency means that the phenomenon must manifest itself through recognizable **characteristics or qualities**. Quantitative consistency means that these manifestations must occur with sufficient **intensity** and over a certain **duration of time**.

In other words, a phenomenon unfolds through repeated manifestations and develops its effects over time: not a single raindrop, not a single sneeze, and not a single email are sufficient to constitute a phenomenon.

2.2 Phenomenology

What can we conclude so far? **Phenomenology** is a way of observing phenomena that is **consciously limited**. For this reason, it always takes into account the possibility of being **fallible**. Phenomenology does not aim to tell us what a thing **is in itself**, but rather **how it appears to us**.

This attitude is therefore very different, and in a sense more **humble**, than the posture typically adopted by the natural sciences. Science generally aims to determine **what entities truly are**, whereas phenomenology focuses on the way in which they **manifest themselves to an observer**.

Phenomenology therefore always recognizes that the one who observes and describes phenomena is **someone**: a subject, a person. As such, the observer always has a **partial perspective**, conditioned by purposes, beliefs, expectations, and goals. In this sense, there is no completely **neutral observer**. Likewise, there are no purely neutral facts, but only **facts that are interpreted**. A fact cannot speak for itself; it always requires someone who interprets it.

However, encountering a phenomenon and observing it is not sufficient in order to describe it. In order to speak about a phenomenon, there must be a subject capable of **understanding** the experience and of **reworking it through language**. This brings us to an important concept: **logos**.

Logos. The term *logos* has a very wide **semantic field**, that is, a broad range of meanings associated with it. Among its possible meanings we find:

- **thought**,
- **word or speech**,
- **reasoning or a line of reasoning**,
- **study or discipline**.

Although these meanings may seem different, they share a common element. The core ideas contained in *logos* can be summarized in three fundamental dimensions:

- **thinking**,
- **speaking** (or the **word**),
- and, in the Christian tradition, **God**.

These meanings are closely related, since thinking finds expression through words, and words allow reasoning to be communicated and shared. **Thinking** can be understood as a form of **inner discourse**. Human beings think through language: thought unfolds internally in the form of words and linguistic structures. In this sense, thinking always takes place **within a language**.

Words, in turn, are the tangible manifestation of thought. They express not only individual ideas, but also the broader **heritage of culture, tradition, family, and community**. Words therefore carry within them the traces of the many forms of knowledge that have shaped our perspective.

In the Christian tradition, the concept of **logos** acquires an even deeper meaning. In the Gospel of John we find the expression “*kai ho logos sarx egeneto*”, which means: “*and the Logos became flesh*”. The term *logos* here can be understood as **word, reason, or thinking**. The expression indicates that the divine Logos becomes **incarnate**, that is, takes on flesh. This highlights how central the concept of *logos* is in shaping the cultural and philosophical foundations of Western thought.

Because interpretation always takes place through language and perspective, it follows that different observers may produce **different interpretations of the same phenomenon**.

Multiple Interpretations of the Same Phenomenon. Consider, for example, a **forest fire**. If we ask different witnesses to describe the event, each of them may present a different account depending on their role and perspective. A **firefighter**, a **lumberjack**, a **poet**, or even someone responsible for starting the fire would all describe the same phenomenon in different ways.

This raises an important question: **are all these perspectives valid?** In many cases, each perspective can be considered valid within its own framework. None of them necessarily represents the absolute truth; rather, each one reflects a different **set of tools, language, and viewpoint** through which the phenomenon is interpreted.

The role of **hermeneutics**, the first methodological tool introduced in the course, is precisely to examine these different interpretations and attempt to understand and explain them.

2.3 The Role of an Interpreter

The main task of an **interpreter** is to **explain**. The term *explain* comes from the Latin *explanare*, which means *to make plain*, that is, to clarify something that is initially complex or obscure.

A **text** can be understood metaphorically as a **fabric**. The word *text* itself derives from the Latin *textus*, meaning *woven*. Just like a fabric is made of threads intertwined together, a text is composed of different **threads of meaning** that are often tangled. The role of the interpreter is therefore to **untangle and realign these threads** according to certain criteria, rules, and methodologies in order to reach a coherent interpretation. However, this immediately raises an important question: **who decides which interpretation is the correct one?** Different interpreters may claim different interpretations of the same phenomenon.

Consider again the example of a **forest fire**. A firefighter, a lumberjack, or a poet may all describe the same event differently. Each perspective highlights different aspects of the phenomenon and therefore produces a different interpretation.

This issue becomes even clearer in the interpretation of **sacred texts**. For example, in the Book of **Leviticus** there is a commandment stating that when harvesting a field one should **not reap the very edges**. The idea behind this rule is that the remaining crops should be left for the **poor**, allowing them to gather food without the need to beg.

However, in certain traditions of interpretation, particularly among some **Orthodox and Hasidic Jewish communities**, this commandment has also been interpreted symbolically as a rule not to **cut the corners of one's hair**. This interpretation explains the presence of the characteristic **side curls** worn by some Orthodox Jews.

This example illustrates how the same text can generate **different interpretations**. The problem of interpretation can therefore be understood as a tension between two fundamental values: **truth** and **freedom**.

A political system can often be characterized by how it balances these two elements. A **totalitarian state** tends to claim possession of the **one true interpretation** and imposes it on society. In doing so, it prioritizes the assertion of truth over the freedom of interpretation.

A **democratic state**, by contrast, tends to value **freedom of interpretation**. Democracy can be compared to a **chorus** rather than a solitary voice: many perspectives coexist, and the collective dialogue among them contributes to the ongoing search for truth.

For this reason, the interpreter must adopt a **humble posture**. An interpreter should recognize that their interpretation is **one among many possible interpretations**. Claiming to possess the only true interpretation often risks becoming a form of **imposition of power** rather than a genuine search for understanding.

2.4 Science as The Holder of Truth

In contemporary society, **science** is often considered the most authoritative holder of truth. The word of science is frequently regarded as the most reliable reference for rational decision-making. For instance, during the COVID-19 pandemic many social and political decisions were justified with the argument that “**science says so**”. In this context, the scientific paradigm is often treated not simply as one possible interpretation of reality, but as the **primary and most reliable criterion** for determining truth.

If we examine this more closely, we notice that when we ask a question such as “*What is it?*” (*che cos'è?*), we already assume a certain way of understanding reality. We tend to understand what surrounds us primarily as **things**.

This assumption can also be seen in the word **reality**. The term derives from the Latin *res*, which means **thing**. In this sense, reality is implicitly understood as the collection of things that exist.

A similar reflection can be made about the concept of an **entity**. An entity (in Italian, *ente*) refers to something that **is**, something that exists or is in the process of being. It indicates a form of presence or existence.

This perspective helps explain the current dominance of **scientific knowledge** over other forms of understanding. As discussed earlier, this dominance can be linked to the prevalence of **instrumental thinking** over **contemplative thinking**.

Instrumental thinking is characteristic of disciplines such as science, technology, medicine, and engineering. It directs inquiry toward specific **objectives and purposes**. Knowledge is pursued with the intention of achieving results, improving efficiency, and producing measurable outcomes.

Contemplative thinking, on the other hand, is more typical of domains such as philosophy, poetry, or spiritual reflection. The term *contemplative* derives from the Latin *cum templum*, where *templum* is connected to *tempus* (time), suggesting a form of attentive observation that requires time and presence. Contemplation does not seek to control or manipulate reality. Instead, it simply **observes** and allows things to be what they are. In contemplation there is no pressure for **efficiency, productivity, or practical results**. This form of observation does not aim to possess or exploit what it sees; rather, it allows entities to **manifest themselves freely**.

However, in contemporary society contemplative thinking is increasingly marginalized. Time is often expected to be optimized and directed toward productive activities, experiments, and measurable outcomes.

Experience and Experiment. This also allows us to distinguish between **experience** and **experiment**. Both concepts derive from the idea of experience, but they are not identical. An **experience** (from the Latin *experiri*, meaning *to try* or *to test*) is

broader and open-ended; it does not necessarily pursue a predetermined objective. An **experiment**, by contrast, is carefully structured and controlled in order to test specific hypotheses and produce repeatable results from which laws or general principles can be derived.

Science tends to approach reality as something that must first be **known** and then **used** for human purposes. For example, science defines water as H_2O . If we ask a scientist what water is, the answer might describe it as a **colorless and odorless liquid** with certain physical properties such as density, hardness, or pH. Alternatively, the explanation may refer to its molecular structure: every molecule of water is composed of **two atoms of hydrogen and one atom of oxygen**.

However, this raises a deeper philosophical question: **what does “is” mean?** Science can describe the properties and composition of things, but it often struggles to explain the meaning of **being itself**. When science says that water *is* H_2O , it uses the verb “to be” while relying on a concept that is rarely examined in depth.

This point was emphasized by **Martin Heidegger**, who observed that what is **closest to us** is often what remains the most **obscure**. We constantly use the verb “to be” in everyday language and scientific descriptions, yet we rarely question its meaning.

Over time, the concept of **being** has often been equated with **concrete entities** or observable things. Science generally assumes that reality consists of entities whose properties can be measured and described.

Yet even seemingly objective descriptions can vary depending on perspective. For instance, science may describe a flame as having a specific color based on physical properties. However, someone who is **colorblind** may perceive that color differently. Likewise, animals or other forms of life may perceive the same phenomenon in ways that differ from human perception.

This suggests that what we call **reality** may depend, at least in part, on the **perspective of the observer**. Scientific descriptions often reflect the dominant human viewpoint, but they are not necessarily the only possible ways of experiencing phenomena.

For this reason, the idea that **being is identical with objective reality** was not entirely convincing for Heidegger. About a century ago, he returned to what he called the *Seinsfrage*, the **question of Being**. In German, *Sein* means *being*, and *Frage* means *question*. Heidegger argued that philosophy must once again confront this fundamental question in order to better understand the nature of existence.

2.5 Martin Heidegger

2.5.1 Biography and Intellectual Context

Martin Heidegger was a German philosopher, born in **1889** in the small rural village of **Messkirch**, in the region of Baden in southwestern Germany. He spent most of his life connected to this region and was eventually buried in Messkirch as well.

Although his philosophy addressed extremely broad and fundamental questions, Heidegger himself was not a great traveler. Geographically, most of his life unfolded within a sort of triangle whose vertices were **Messkirch**, where he was born; **Freiburg**, where he studied and later taught; and **Todtnauberg**, a small village in the **Black Forest**. In Todtnauberg Heidegger built a small **hut** (*Hütte*) where he spent long periods in isolation studying and writing. It was there that he conceived and worked on his most famous work, *Being and Time* (*Sein und Zeit*), which however remained unfinished.

If we do not consider traveling only as geographical movement but also as a **change of perspective**, one of Heidegger's most significant "journeys" may have taken place during his childhood. Heidegger was the son of the **church bell ringer** of Messkirch, and as a child he often accompanied his father to the top of the church bell tower. From that elevated position he experienced **time** in a very concrete way: not only as an abstract concept, but as something that structured daily life. From the bell tower he could observe the world at the same hour every day, appearing **always the same and yet always different**.

Heidegger's family was not poor, but they were not wealthy enough to easily support higher education. Initially, the **Church financed his studies**. Although he was an excellent student, Heidegger remained a country boy who suddenly found himself studying in prestigious institutions alongside the sons of wealthy and influential families. He tended to distance himself from social life and dedicated himself almost entirely to study.

At a certain point, however, his intellectual honesty led him to continue his studies independently. He informed the bishop who had supported his education that his research was not **theological**, but **ontological**. Theology is based on **dogma**, meaning beliefs that must be accepted without questioning. Heidegger's research, instead, aimed to question the very foundations of existence.

2.5.2 Ontology: Ontic and Ontological

The term **ontology** derives from the Greek words *ontos* (ὄντος), meaning *being*, and *logos*, meaning *discourse*, *reasoning*, or *study*. Ontology therefore refers to the **study of being**.

Heidegger also introduced an important distinction between the **ontic** and the **ontological**. The **ontic** refers to **entities**, that is, to things that exist. The **ontological**, instead,

concerns the **being of those entities**, the deeper question of what it means for something to exist. In simplified terms, science generally focuses on **ontic investigations**, while philosophy is primarily concerned with **ontological questions**.

Heidegger was not alone in addressing these themes. Along with thinkers such as **Søren Kierkegaard**, **Jean-Paul Sartre**, **Albert Camus**, and in some respects **Friedrich Nietzsche**, he is often associated with the philosophical current known as **existentialism**. Although these thinkers differ significantly from one another, existentialism broadly focuses on questions concerning **existence**, **being**, and the search for meaning in human life.

Existentialist thought emerged at the end of the **19th century** and developed strongly throughout the **20th century**. Its development was deeply influenced by the historical context of the **World Wars**. The enormous suffering and destruction produced by these conflicts, often amplified by scientific and technological progress, challenged the optimistic vision of **rationalism** and **positivism**, which had previously celebrated science and technology as unquestioned sources of progress.

In this context, existentialist philosophers began to question whether scientific and technological advancement alone could provide answers to fundamental human concerns such as **suffering**, **disorientation**, **injustice**, and **death**.

Before its large-scale military applications, **technology** had appeared mainly in its bright and efficient **industrial form**, promising wealth, development, and progress. It was the period in which large industrial companies such as **Ford Motor Company** and **Fiat** were founded and rapidly expanding. The **assembly line** (*catena di montaggio*) was introduced, and a new model of social organization based on **efficiency** and **productivity** began to take shape.

At the same time, society was increasingly structured through systems of **mass production**, **mass political ideologies**, and large political parties. In such contexts, the existence of individuals risked being reduced to predefined **roles**, **tasks**, and **functions** within highly organized systems.

Faced with this situation, many thinkers began once again to reflect on fundamental **existential questions**: questions concerning **freedom**, **mortality**, and the meaning of the **human condition**.

2.5.3 Existence and the Question of Being

Heidegger begins his reflection on **being** from precisely this point: from the being that raises the question of being itself. The human being is part of the world like other entities, but unlike other entities that simply exist, the human being is capable of **questioning its own existence**. Humans ask, investigate, and search for the meaning of their own being.

In this sense, human beings are unique: we are the only creatures that **ask questions about our existence**. Asking a question already implies a form of **dissatisfaction** with what is given. Because of this capacity, human beings are described as **existents**.

The term *existence* derives from the Latin *ex-sistere*. The prefix *ex* means *out*, while *sistere* means *to stand* or *to remain*. To exist therefore literally means **to stand out** or **to step outside**. Human beings stand out from mere presence in the world because they seek **meaning**.

The word **meaning** is related to the Latin term *sensus*, which can indicate both **meaning** and **direction**. This etymology suggests an interesting image: many entities in nature follow a kind of **instinctive path**, like a highway along which they proceed from a starting point toward an end.

Trees, animals, stars, and other natural entities follow this path without questioning it. They do not create a distance between the way they live and the way they ought to live. Human beings, however, are different. They create a **distance** between what they are and what they seek to become. This distance generates the continuous search for **meaning** that characterizes human existence.

Animals and other natural entities seem not to need to search for new paths beyond their **instinctual behavior**. They do not step outside their biological life in order to explore alternative possibilities. They simply follow the course determined by instinct. For this reason, they do not experience existential questions: they do not feel injustice, they do not perceive life as a problem to be solved, they do not go to psychologists, they do not pray, they do not bury their dead, and they do not produce art, music, or literature. All these activities are specifically **human**.

2.5.4 Dasein

Because of this unique condition, Heidegger does not refer to the human being simply as “man” or “human”. Instead, he introduces the term **Dasein**. In German, *Da* means **there** or **here**, and *sein* means **to be**. **Dasein** therefore literally means “**being there**” or “**being here**” (*esserci*).

This concept expresses the idea that the human being is not merely present in the world, but is **aware of being present**. Human beings are conscious of their own existence, and at the same time they are aware of the possibility of **no longer being**. In other words, human beings are conscious of their own **mortality**. Every human being, in Heidegger’s terminology, is a **Dasein**.

For this reason, Heidegger approaches the **question of Being** starting from Dasein, the entity that is capable of raising the question of being itself.

From a **phenomenological perspective**, the central question is not **who** Dasein is, but **how** Dasein is. In other words, the task is to understand **how Dasein presents itself**

in experience.

Heidegger identifies several recurring characteristics of Dasein. These characteristics are called **existentials**, because they pertain to the structure of human **existence**.

3

Lecture of 10/03/2026

3.1 The Question of Being

Martin Heidegger returns to the **question of being** because, in the scientific perspective, being is usually understood simply as **entity**, that is, as **reality composed of things**. As discussed previously, reality is commonly interpreted as a collection of **things**. Whatever is not a thing is considered **nothing**. The word *nothing* literally means **no-thing**, that is, the absence of entities.

When science defines something, for example when it says that **water is H_2O** , it describes the structure and properties of an entity. However, this type of explanation does not address the deeper question of **what it means for something to be**.

Heidegger observes that the question of being had already been considered resolved in the thought of the early Greek philosophers such as **Parmenides, Plato, and Aristotle**. For these thinkers, **being** was largely identified with **reality** or with the presence of things. Since then, much of the Western philosophical tradition has continued to assume this equivalence without fundamentally questioning it.

As a result, most forms of knowledge, including modern scientific disciplines, focus primarily on **entities**. All scientific *logoi* (that is, scientific discourses or studies) investigate particular entities and their properties. However, in doing so they often overlook the deeper question concerning the **being of those entities**.

In Heidegger's view, philosophy has the task of **bringing the question of being back to life**. To do this, he does not adopt the method of the natural sciences. Instead of constructing a laboratory experiment, Heidegger begins with a **phenomenological observation**. He starts from what is immediately available: **himself**, the human being who asks the question of being.

This perspective is connected to the concept of **sensus**, the search for meaning. Although meaning may appear to be something abstract, Heidegger suggests that it is actually grounded in our **senses**. Human understanding arises through **embodied experience**: sight, hearing, touch, and feeling all contribute to the formation of meaning.

For this reason, even the most abstract concepts are ultimately constructed through a form of **embodied intelligence**, in which understanding emerges from the interaction between the mind and the sensory experience of the world.

3.2 Introduction to Intelligence

Human **intelligence** is not located only in the brain. The brain is connected to the world through the **peripheral branches of the senses**. Because we are living and mortal beings, our condition shapes and structures our intelligence from within.

For this reason, Heidegger proposes to approach the question of **being** starting from our own **being-there**. The question of being is extremely vast, and therefore we must begin from somewhere. The most immediate starting point is **ourselves**, since this is the only point of access that we truly possess.

Other forms of knowledge, such as building laboratories, designing microscopes, or writing computer programs, are certainly powerful tools for investigation. However, they are able to address only **particular entities**. They cannot reach the **totality of being**.

According to Heidegger, only **philosophy** can open access to the question of being. Philosophy has the task of awakening us from what Heidegger calls our **ontic sleep**. As discussed earlier, the **ontic** concerns entities, while the **ontological** concerns being itself. Human beings tend to become absorbed in the world of entities and gradually begin to think of themselves as merely **things among things**. Philosophy challenges this illusion and reminds us that our existence cannot be reduced to the status of a simple entity.

In order to describe how the human being (**Dasein**) appears, Heidegger seeks to identify the **recurring conditions** that structure human existence. These conditions are not abstract definitions but structures that we can also recognize in our own experience.

In this sense, Heidegger's philosophy does not aim simply to be **understood** in a purely technical or conceptual way. Even the word "to understand" suggests the idea of placing something **under** our control, as if knowledge were something we dominate. Similarly, the Italian word *capire* derives from the Latin *capere*, meaning *to seize* or *to grasp*.

Heidegger's philosophy instead invites us to **recognize** structures that resonate with our own experience. The fundamental structures of human existence that he identifies are called **existentials**, because they belong to the way in which human existence unfolds.

3.3 The Existentials of Dasein

3.3.1 Being-in-the-World

Let us consider the first one. Heidegger states that Dasein is ***In-der-Welt-sein***, that is, **being-in-the-world**.

To understand this concept, it is important to clarify that the word “**in**” does not refer simply to a spatial position. The world is not merely a container in which Dasein is placed. Rather, being-in-the-world means that human beings are always already **immersed in a network of meanings and practical relations** that they did not create but have inherited.

In this sense, being-in-the-world refers to the idea of **dwelling** (*habitare*). Human dwelling is very different from the way other living beings inhabit their environment. Human beings live in a world that is **technically arranged**. The human environment is shaped by tools, instruments, and technologies that allow us to live and organize our existence.

Here, **technique** should not be understood only as modern technology. Technique refers more broadly to the use of **instruments** that enable human beings to inhabit the world. These instruments may take many forms: from a simple stick to complex algorithms. Human beings cannot live their lives without some form of technique.

The world we inhabit is therefore a **technically prepared environment**, and it is also a world that we **share with others**. This raises an important question for the present time: **what kind of world do we inhabit today?** Is it still primarily a physical world, or are we gradually shifting toward another dimension shaped by digital technologies? For instance, digital platforms sometimes draw our attention away from physical spaces, leaving them empty while our gaze remains directed toward our devices. This transformation raises new questions about the meaning of being-in-the-world.

3.3.2 Being-with

Although Heidegger speaks of **Dasein** as a singular entity, he also emphasizes that human existence is always characterized by the presence of others. This leads to the second existential: *Mitsein*, meaning **being-with**.

Relationships with others are not something that we acquire later in life. The presence of others is already there from the very beginning of our existence. Indeed, the very reason we are alive is that others took care of us when we were not able to survive on our own. Our existence is therefore always **co-originated with others**.

However, this original condition of being-with can also have problematic consequences. According to Heidegger, others may become a kind of **refuge** that allows us to escape from our own existential questions and from the anxiety that accompanies them. By conforming to the opinions, behaviors, and expectations of others, we may feel protected and integrated into a community. At the same time, this tendency can reduce our individuality, pushing us to shape our identity according to what others expect from us.

Being-in-the-world therefore means inhabiting an environment while simultaneously entering into relationships with **others**, both human and non-human, and with the **things**

that we encounter in the world.

3.3.3 Thrownness

Before being **in the world**, Dasein was not yet there. The fact that, at a certain moment, Dasein appears in the world is explained by what Heidegger calls *Geworfenheit*, usually translated as **thrownness** (*gettatezza*). This is the third existential.

Thrownness refers to the inescapable condition in which each of us finds ourselves: we are **thrown into existence** without having asked for it or chosen it. The fact that we come to life is not the result of a decision we made. Nevertheless, once we are here, we must live a life that we did not choose in advance.

At the beginning of life there is therefore a kind of **astonishment** or bewilderment when the human being first encounters reality. At first, this reality is unfamiliar, but gradually we become accustomed to it and learn to navigate within it.

It is important to remember that Heidegger's inquiry is **ontological**, not **theological**. His investigation concerns **being**, not divine creation. For this reason, the idea of thrownness carries a somewhat **tragic** dimension. It differs from the notion of creation in the Christian tradition, which interprets existence as the result of divine grace.

We are alive, but not by our own decision. We did not choose when or where to be born. We did not choose our family, our body, whether we would be male or female, healthy or ill, poor or wealthy. **Thrownness** therefore describes the **initial condition** that characterizes every human life.

3.3.4 Possibility and Project

However, thrownness does not completely determine us. Heidegger emphasizes that Dasein cannot be understood as something **static or fixed**. Instead, Dasein is characterized by openness to possibilities. Heidegger expresses this idea with the notion of *Sein-können* (the **ability-to-be**).

Dasein is therefore an entity whose fundamental characteristic is precisely the **absence of fixed characteristics**. Human existence is always open to **possibilities**. For this reason, it is oriented toward the search for **sensus**, both in the sense of **meaning** and **direction**, going beyond what instinct alone would determine.

Beside the passive condition of **Dasein**, rooted in the past through its **thrownness** (*Geworfenheit*), Heidegger introduces another dimension: a **dynamic condition** oriented toward the future. Being is not only what already is, but also what **is not yet** and **may become**.

Dasein exists in such a way that, in the act of understanding and interpreting what it encounters, it constantly **surpasses what it has been**. Its mode of being is therefore not that of a fixed reality, but that of **possibility**.

For Heidegger, each of us is thrown into the world, but at the same time each of us has the task of **being a project**. Heidegger expresses this idea with the expression *geworfener Entwurf* (a **thrown project**). The term *geworfen* is the past participle of “to throw”, while *Entwurf* (project) shares the same root (*Wurf*, throw). In this expression we can grasp the dynamic movement that characterizes Dasein: starting from its past, from what it has already become through thrownness, Dasein **projects itself toward the future**, opening itself to possibilities.

The idea of a **project** must be distinguished from that of a **program**. The prefix *pro* in “project” means **forward**: something thrown in front of us. A project indicates a direction we wish to pursue, but the path toward it is not fully predetermined. A **program**, on the contrary, derives from *gramma* (from Greek *graphein*, to write). A program is something **already written**, where the sequence of steps is fixed and cannot easily be modified. A project can evolve and be reshaped along the way.

However, Dasein’s projection toward possibilities is always accompanied by a fundamental awareness: all possibilities will eventually be canceled by the realization of the **final and most certain possibility**, which is **death**. In this sense, human existence is marked by **finitude**, and this finitude gives urgency and significance to our projects.

3.3.5 Affective Situatedness

Dasein is not only thrown into the world; it also **feels** its thrownness. Heidegger describes this condition with the term *Befindlichkeit*. The root *finden* means “to find”, and the term refers to the way in which Dasein **finds itself situated** in the world. The suffixes *-heit* or *-keit* correspond roughly to the Italian ending *-ità*, indicating a condition or state. Contrary to what many philosophers had previously believed, **affectivity** is not something accidental or secondary. It is an **existential structure**. Emotions are fundamental ways through which human beings experience existence. They are the **colours of being**, revealing how the world appears to us. Every experience is always accompanied by a certain **emotional attunement**: fear, anxiety, joy, boredom, and other moods shape the way reality is disclosed.

Understanding itself therefore takes place from within this **situated emotional condition**. Dasein never approaches the world from a position of complete neutrality. In everyday life, we interpret and understand things while already being immersed in feelings, concerns, and moods.

3.4 Critique of the Metaphysical Subject

The model of the **scientific subject**, however, tends to suppress this dimension. In scientific experimentation, the personal condition of the researcher, whether they are

sad, joyful, or anxious, is considered irrelevant. The subject of science is expected to suspend affectivity in order to produce objective knowledge.

For Heidegger, this image of the purely neutral subject is problematic. He argues that the traditional philosophical idea of the subject is in many ways a **chimera**, an illusion created by **metaphysics**. Metaphysics (from Greek *meta*, beyond, and *physis*, nature) traditionally sought to study being beyond the domain of direct experience. Heidegger challenges this tradition by bringing philosophical inquiry back to the concrete and lived experience of **Dasein**.

In the philosophical tradition, especially since **Kant**, the concept of the **subject** has been understood in two main ways. Heidegger criticizes both of them.

Subject as *subjectum*. The first interpretation understands the subject as *subjectum*, that is, something **thrown or placed underneath** as a foundation. In Greek philosophy this idea corresponds to the notion of *hypokeimenon*, meaning the **underlying substrate** that supports and guarantees the structure of metaphysical thought. In this sense, the subject is conceived as the **stable foundation** upon which knowledge and reality are grounded.

Subject as autonomous rational center. The second interpretation conceives the subject as an **autonomous and self-sufficient being**, a sovereign center of rationality capable of grounding knowledge independently.

Heidegger challenges both interpretations by asking a simple question: **where is this autonomous and independent subject?** Is this supposedly solid and permanent foundation truly present in our experience?

According to Heidegger, the idea of such a subject is largely a **metaphysical construction**. It represents the attempt of metaphysics to eliminate the dimension of **temporality** from human existence. The metaphysical subject is imagined as something static and unchanging, like a picture rather than a film.

However, this idea becomes problematic when we consider the condition of **Dasein**. Dasein does not even control its own **“Da”** (its “there” or place of existence). Human beings are always already **thrown** into conditions they did not choose. We do not choose where or when we are born, the historical era in which we live, or many of the circumstances that shape our existence. If someone is born in Rome rather than Shanghai, or in the twenty-first century rather than in the Middle Ages, this situation is not the result of a decision. It is part of the structure of **thrownness**.

For this reason, Heidegger’s break with traditional philosophy is radical. Dasein is not a detached subject that observes the world from outside. Instead, it is a **temporal being** that moves within the world, guided by emotions, concerns, and the attempt to understand its own condition.

3.5 Understanding Before Knowledge

The traditional philosophical subject is often associated with the activity of **knowing**: observing entities, experimenting, and producing knowledge in a quantitative and scientific way. Heidegger argues that this dimension of knowing actually comes **after** a more fundamental one: **understanding**.

Heidegger calls this primary mode of engagement *Verstehen* (understanding). Understanding is an **existential structure** through which Dasein interprets what it encounters in the world and projects possibilities for its own existence. In this sense, understanding is closely connected to **hermeneutics**, the activity of interpreting and giving meaning to experience.

Scientific **knowledge** is therefore a **secondary mode**. It emerges only when Dasein adopts the posture of a detached subject and attempts to observe entities with a supposedly disinterested gaze. Before this stage, however, there is always the more fundamental process of **interpretive understanding** through which Dasein already relates to the world.

Heidegger argues that considering our relation to things as primarily **cognitive** is a metaphysical mistake. Our relation to things is first of all **interpretative** and **practical**. We do not initially encounter things by analyzing them scientifically; instead, we encounter them through **use**.

Practical Encounter with Things. A simple example can be seen in the behavior of **children**. When children encounter objects, they do not immediately ask what the object weighs or what it is chemically composed of. Instead, they explore it: they manipulate it, try different uses, and interact with it until they gradually acquire familiarity and mastery.

For Heidegger, human beings always move within a world that is already **pre-understood**. Entities never present themselves to us in complete neutrality or in what could be called their “pure” or “naked” form. The idea that objects appear to us without any prior interpretation is, according to Heidegger, another **metaphysical abstraction**.

Because we are always already **thrown** into a particular historical time and situation, we approach things with a **prior understanding**. When we encounter an object, we already have an implicit sense of what it is and how it can be used. Our understanding of entities therefore emerges within a network of **practical relations**.

In this sense, the relationship between Dasein and the world is strongly connected to the use of the **hands**. Human beings engage with the world through manipulation, handling, and practical activity.

This reflection leads to a final question: **what is happening to our world today**, when many manual activities are disappearing? In contemporary life, much of our interaction

with technology is reduced to the use of a **single finger**. The word *finger* in Latin is *digitus*, from which the term **digital** is derived.

This observation introduces a transition toward the theme of the **digital world**, which will be further explored in the discussion of cyber technologies.

Lecture of 16/03/2026

4.1 Dasein, Entities, and the World

To live in the world means to **encounter** things and people and to **relate** to them. What we encounter can be either an **entity** (a thing) or another **Dasein**.

When it comes to things, objects and entities in our environment, our first approach is typically **practical**. We do not initially see them as neutral objects, but as **tools**, that is, as something that may serve a purpose and be used.

Heidegger introduces two key concepts to describe this relation:

- *Vorhandenheit*: something that is **present-at-hand**, available as an object.
- *Zuhandenheit*: something that is **ready-to-hand**, immediately usable as a tool.

The suffix *-heit* corresponds to *-icity*, while *handen* refers to the **hand**. The distinction highlights two different ways in which entities can appear to us.

Ready-to-Hand and Present-at-Hand. *Zuhandenheit* (ready-to-hand) refers to objects in their **practical usability**. When we use a tool, we do not focus on it as an object, but on what we can do **through it**. The tool becomes almost transparent in use. *Vorhandenheit* (present-at-hand), instead, refers to objects considered in a more **theoretical or detached way**, as things simply present and available for observation.

The concept of **disposition** (from Latin *dispositio*) helps clarify this. To dispose something means not only to place it, but to **organize and arrange it according to a purpose**. For example, goods in a supermarket are arranged in a way that makes them easily accessible and usable. They are placed so as to be **at our disposal**.

Heidegger connects these ideas to broader concepts describing the modern world. One of these is *Gestell* (enframing), which can be understood as a system that **orders, categorizes, and organizes** reality—like shelves in a supermarket that classify and separate objects according to their function and use.

Another related concept is *Bestand*, meaning **standing-reserve** or stock. In this perspective, entities are seen as resources stored and ready to be used, like items in a pantry. These notions are closely connected to **Vorhandenheit** and **Zuhandenheit**, as they all describe different ways in which reality is structured and made available for human use.

The World as a Horizon of Meaning. The **world** should not be understood simply as a spatial or geographical place, but as a **horizon of meanings** that forms the background of our everyday life. Within this horizon, the entities we encounter immediately appear to us as **tools**, that is, as something usable.

Heidegger calls this practical way of looking at things *Umsicht* (circumspection). Through this gaze, entities are not isolated objects, but are connected within a **network of references**. Heidegger describes this as a **chain of reference**.

For example:

- a **nail** refers to a **hammer**,
- hammer and nail are used to **hang a painting**,
- hanging a painting serves to **make a house more pleasant**,
- making a house more pleasant ultimately serves the **Dasein**.

This chain of references can be extended to all the objects we encounter: doors, chairs, tools, and everyday items. Each of them is inserted into a system of purposes that ultimately refer back to **Dasein**. In this sense, Dasein represents the **endpoint** of the chain.

However, this raises a further question: **to what does Dasein refer?** Unlike other entities, Dasein is not referred to something else. It is, in a sense, **self-referential**. For Heidegger, once we have identified this central point where all references converge, we must examine it closely.

Dasein is the **being that asks the question of being**. The very act of questioning already reveals something essential about its nature. Philosophy, in this sense, does not simply provide answers, but keeps the **question open** and explores its meaning.

4.2 Dasein and the Presence of Others

When we ask “*who am I?*”, we must also question what we mean by “**I**”. Heidegger challenges traditional interpretations of the self.

On the one hand, he criticizes the idea of the **subject** as a stable and underlying foundation (*subjectum* or *hypokeimenon*) that guarantees identity despite change. On the other hand, he questions the Cartesian idea expressed in *cogito ergo sum*. According to

Heidegger, this approach risks assuming a form of subject that is abstract and detached from the concrete conditions of existence.

Heidegger reverses the problem: instead of forcing human existence into a fixed and immutable structure, he starts from its **instability**, its **temporality**, and its **situated nature**. Human existence is not a static substance, but a dynamic process.

Furthermore, every act of thinking is shaped by a **pre-understanding**, a pre-existing horizon of meaning that influences how we interpret the world.

For this reason, Heidegger does not define Dasein through a fixed concept. Instead, he describes the **phenomenon of existence**, which is always characterized by the presence of **things** and **others**.

These two dimensions cannot be separated. When Dasein encounters tools, it also encounters the presence of **other Daseins**. This presence is revealed through the **traces of human activity**: objects, structures, and environments shaped by others.

The world of Dasein is therefore, from the very beginning, a **shared world**. Human existence is always already **being-with others**. If we reflect on it, even before birth we are already in relation with another being, sharing for nine months the body of another person.

4.2.1 Who Are the Others?

Heidegger asks: **who are the others?** Are they really something completely different from me?

He answers with a fundamental clarification:

"The others are not those who remain after I remove myself. Rather, the others are those from whom one generally is not distinguished by, and among whom one also is."

"Gli altri non sono coloro che restano dopo che io mi sono tolto. Gli altri sono piuttosto quelli dai quali per lo più non ci si distingue e fra i quali, quindi, si è anche."

In other words, the others are not external to me, but are part of the very structure of my existence.

One might object that Dasein can also be **alone**. However, Heidegger replies that Dasein is always **being-with** (*Mitsein*), even when others are not physically present or perceived. Even **being alone** is a **mode of being-with**.

The absence of others is therefore only relative: it is always understood in relation to the possibility of being with others. Heidegger calls this a **deficient mode** of being-with, characterized by **indifference** and **estrangement**. Even in solitude, Dasein remains structurally related to others.

Moreover, the presence of others does not necessarily eliminate loneliness. A human being may feel **alone even in a crowd**. In such cases, we are not truly **with others**, but merely **among others**. This situation corresponds to a form of simple **co-presence**, where individuals are physically close but existentially distant.

4.3 Care for Things and Care for Others

This distinction is important because the way Dasein relates to **entities** (things) is different from how it relates to **other Daseins**.

4.3.1 Besorgen

When Dasein encounters entities, it engages with them in a practical way: it **uses**, **manipulates**, and transforms them into instruments. Heidegger describes this relation with the term *Besorgen* (**taking care of** things). In this mode, Dasein actively intervenes in the world, shaping and organizing what it encounters for its own purposes.

4.3.2 Fürsorge

When Dasein encounters other human beings, however, the relation is different. It is not a matter of using or manipulating, but of **caring for**. Heidegger calls this relation *Fürsorge* (**care for others**).

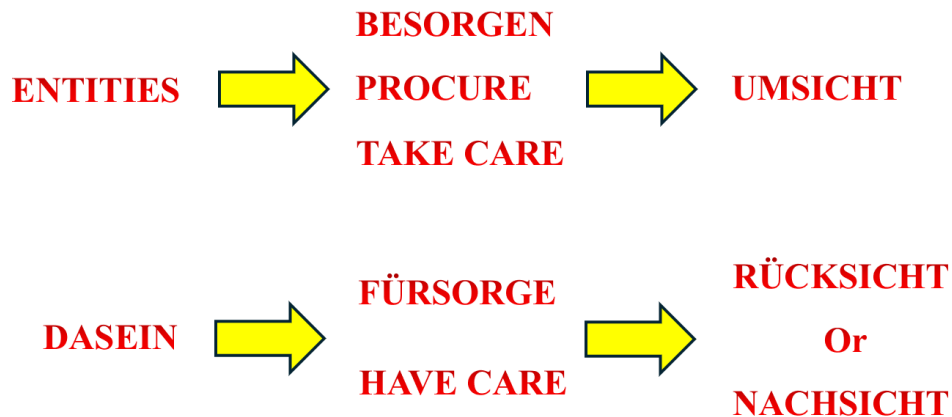
Just as being-with has a deficient mode, care also has a negative form. The deficient mode of *Fürsorge* is **neglect**, that is, **not caring** about others (*trascurare*). In this case, the relation to others is not one of genuine care, but of indifference.

Beside the deficient mode of care, Heidegger also describes **positive modes of care** (*Fürsorge*) toward others. Among these, he identifies two **extreme possibilities**.

Substitutive Care. The first occurs when, instead of **having care for others**, we **take care of them** by **replacing them**. In this case, we treat the other as if they were an **entity**, stepping into their place and making decisions for them. This form of care can relieve the other from difficulty, but it does so at a cost: it **removes their freedom**, their responsibility, and their ability to pursue their own **project**.

In this situation, the other's existence is no longer guided by their own possibilities, but by a sort of **program** imposed by someone else. While this may appear helpful, it creates dynamics of **dependence** and even **domination**. The other is reduced to someone who must be managed, rather than someone who can act freely.

Of course, there are situations in which taking care of others is necessary, for example when someone is **very young**, **very old**, or **ill**. In these cases, the substitution of care



is part of the temporal structure of human life. Dasein is not a stable entity, but passes through different **phases** in which it may require the support of others.

Authentic Care. The second mode of care represents the **authentic form of caring**. In this case, caring for others does not mean replacing them, but rather **restoring their possibilities**. The aim is to support the other in becoming **themselves**, not in becoming like us.

In authentic care, we do not remove the other's difficulties or responsibilities. Instead, we allow them to confront their own existence, preserving their **freedom** and their **capacity to choose**. To take away these challenges would ultimately deprive them of their life as a project.

Heidegger identifies two key characteristics of authentic care:

- **Rücksicht** (respect): a form of attention that involves **stepping back**, allowing the other space to be themselves.
- **Nachsicht** (indulgence or consideration): a form of attention that involves **coming closer**, showing understanding and support.

The term *Sicht* means “**sight**”. These two modes of care express a balance between **distance** and **proximity**. Authentic care requires knowing when to step back and when to come closer, maintaining a dynamic equilibrium between these two attitudes.

In authentic care, the presence of Dasein is not aimed at **substitution** (*substitutio*), but at **restoration** (*restitutio*). What is restored is the other's **possibility of being**: their capacity to be **free** and **transparent** in projecting their own existence.

However, in everyday life, care for others often remains in a **deficient or indifferent mode**. Most of the time, when we are among others, we do not truly care for them. Instead, we tend to **ignore** them or remain indifferent. This corresponds to a form of **mutual neglect** (*trascurare*).

For Heidegger, a genuine relation with others requires more than simply knowing that they exist. It requires that we **get to know them** (*fare conoscenza*), that is, to engage with them in a more meaningful way.

Often, however, our relations are characterized by forms of **dissimulation**¹, **simulation**², and **reticence**³.

In these conditions, being with others becomes more difficult and may require artificial or mediated approaches, such as those offered by disciplines like **psychology**.

4.3.3 Interest and the Limits of Empathy

Heidegger also criticizes the concept of **empathy**. He argues that understanding another person does not derive from the ability to project ourselves into their inner psychological life. Instead, it is grounded in what he calls **interest**.

The word **interest** derives from the Latin *inter esse*, meaning “**to be among**” or “**to be within**”. This suggests that we are connected to others because we share the same **existential condition**. We are, so to speak, **in the same boat**.

We are interested in others not merely to share their feelings, but because observing them helps us to **shape our own project of existence**. Others become a source of **inspiration** for our own possibilities.

For this reason, Heidegger claims that it makes little sense to speak of empathy as a special capacity. Dasein already possesses a basic, even if vague, **understanding of its own being**, and it is from this starting point that it can understand others.

Nevertheless, the relation to others remains complex. Understanding another person is not simply a matter of projecting ourselves into them. While we interpret others starting from our own perspective, we can never fully grasp them. The other always retains a dimension of **mystery**.

This leads to a fundamental philosophical question: **how is it possible that the other, who is different from me, can still be understandable to me, given that I am myself and not the other?**

¹Pretending not to feel something (e.g., hiding boredom or discomfort).

²Pretending to feel something that we do not actually feel.

³Withholding what should be expressed.

4.4 Being-With Others and Everyday Conformity

Dasein is always **singular**. Even though it is essentially **being-with others** (*Mitsein*), there is no true **plural** of Dasein. Each Dasein remains irreducibly individual.

When Dasein is treated as a plurality in a quantitative sense, others risk being reduced to **numbers**. In this condition, others can be **counted**, but they cannot be **counted on**. This form of being-together becomes impersonal and indifferent: individuals are present, but there is no genuine relation. This insight can also be extended to contemporary contexts, such as digital environments, where connections may be numerous but not necessarily meaningful.

Heidegger acknowledges that Dasein is originally **being-with others**, and that others play a fundamental role in shaping our world. From the very beginning of our existence, others provide us with care, meanings, values, knowledge, and interpretations. However, the presence of others also introduces a fundamental **tension**.

This tension takes the form of a **concern to distinguish oneself from others**. On the one hand, we may fear distinguishing ourselves, because this can lead to a feeling of **not belonging**. The notion of **belonging** itself is ambiguous: it can mean being part of a community, but it can also imply being **owned** or defined by others.

On the other hand, we also strive to **affirm our uniqueness**, resisting the idea of being reduced to something that belongs to others. This creates a constant oscillation between the desire to **belong** and the desire to **be distinct**.

Heidegger describes this dynamic as a condition of **comparative measurement** (*comparazione commisurante*). In everyday life, we tend to compare ourselves with others, measuring ourselves according to various criteria: success, recognition, wealth, or social approval. This process introduces a logic of **quantification**, where value is increasingly understood in terms of numbers rather than qualities.

As a result, Dasein risks falling into a state of **subjection to others**. In this condition, individuals allow others to determine their choices and responsibilities. Instead of projecting their own possibilities, they conform to external expectations and standards, delegating their existence to what others consider appropriate.

One might think that it is possible to escape this condition simply by **changing the others**, for example by moving to a different place or entering a different social context. However, Heidegger argues that this does not fundamentally change the situation.

When others are not specific individuals, they become **interchangeable**. They are simply those who are present in our everyday existence, but they could easily be replaced by others without altering our condition. What remains unchanged is the **structure of subjection** to others.

4.4.1 The Dictatorship of *das Man*

In this indistinct plurality, where others exist in a state of **indifference** and **inter-changeability**, Heidegger introduces the concept of *das Man*. This can be translated as the impersonal “**one**” (as in “one says”, “one does”, “one thinks”). It does not refer to any specific individual, but to an anonymous and collective way of being.

Heidegger describes this condition as a kind of **dictatorship of the *das Man***. In everyday life, we tend to conform to what “one” does:

- we enjoy things as *one* enjoys them,
- we read, judge, and interpret as *one* does,
- we avoid what *one* avoids,
- we consider scandalous what *one* considers scandalous.

This condition can also be described as **averageness** (*mediality*). It produces a leveling effect on existence. The *das Man* establishes what is normal, acceptable, and appropriate, and in doing so it **suppresses differences**.

Every form of **exception** or **originality** tends to be neutralized. What stands out is brought back to the average level. Every form of **superiority** is silenced or reduced. Every attempt to affirm one’s uniqueness is absorbed into what is already known and familiar. Even great achievements, when circulated in common discourse, risk becoming **banalized**.

In this way, the dictatorship of the *das Man* regulates the possible interpretations of the world. It appears to be always “right”, not because it possesses a deeper understanding, but because it operates through a **lack of depth** and an **insensitivity to distinctions**. Everything is leveled, and differences are progressively erased.

What becomes **public** and **average**, even if it appears to be well-known and accessible to everyone, is in fact **obscured in its essence**. The voice of common opinion, the anonymous “*one*” (*das Man*), seems to be everywhere. Yet there is a decisive moment in which it disappears: the **moment of decision**, when Dasein is alone with itself.

However, even if the *das Man* is absent in this decisive moment, it has already **anticipated** judgments and choices in advance. In this way, it relieves Dasein of the burden of deciding, allowing the individual to say that “*one did what had to be done*”.

Responsibility and Relief from Decision. **Responsibility** means the capacity to **respond** and to **justify** one’s actions. The *das Man* removes this burden, making life easier and more agreeable. It satisfies the human tendency to take things lightly and avoid difficulty. For this reason, it is **welcomed** by Dasein, and through this acceptance it strengthens and deepens its domination.

Moreover, the more this **dictatorship of the *das Man*** operates in a massive and pervasive way, the more it becomes **elusive** and difficult to detect.

4.4.2 Authenticity and Inauthenticity

Nevertheless, Heidegger does not consider this condition as fixed or permanent. Since Dasein is not a stable subject but a **dynamic existence**, the influence of the *das Man* can vary depending on historical and existential conditions.

In this context, Heidegger distinguishes between different ways of being oneself:

- the “*si stesso*” (the self that conforms to the *das Man*), which belongs to others and is shaped by average opinion,
- the “*proprio sé stesso*” (the authentic self), which belongs to itself and is not determined by others.

This distinction is expressed through the concepts of:

- *Eigentlichkeit* (authenticity),
- *Uneigentlichkeit* (inauthenticity).

The term *eigen* is related to the idea of **property** or what is **proper to oneself**. Authenticity therefore refers to a way of being that is truly **one's own**, not shared or dictated by others. Inauthenticity, on the other hand, corresponds to the condition in which Dasein is absorbed into the anonymous logic of the *das Man*.

The question of how Dasein can move from **inauthenticity** to **authenticity** remains open and will be addressed subsequently.

Lecture of 17/03/2026

5.1 Everydayness and the Rule of *das Man*

In everyday life, Dasein exists as **being-with others**. As we have seen, others contribute to shaping the **background of meanings** that we inherit from the moment we are born. This shared dimension is both **necessary** and **inescapable**.

However, this condition also has a **darker side**. The presence of others can become **intrusive**, to the point of replacing us in matters that should belong to us. In this case, interaction with others, through conversation, exchange of opinions, and shared interpretations, can shift from **co-forming** our identity to **con-forming** it.

The risk is that of **conformity**: instead of developing our own possibilities, we adapt ourselves to the **average interpretations** imposed by others. This process leads to a **leveling** of existence, produced by the dominance of what Heidegger calls the **dictatorship of the *das Man***.

To better understand how this domination takes place in everyday life, Heidegger identifies three main forms in which it manifests itself:

- **Chatter** (*Gerede, chiacchiera*),
- **Curiosity** (*Neugier, curiosità*),
- **Ambiguity** (*Zweideutigkeit, equivoco*).

These three phenomena represent concrete ways in which the influence of the *das Man* operates within our everyday existence. They can be understood as **interpretative tools** that allow us to analyze not only Heidegger's philosophy, but also many aspects of **contemporary reality**.

5.1.1 Chatter

The first manifestation of the dictatorship of the *das Man* is **chatter** (*Gerede, chiacchiera*). With this term, Heidegger identifies a specific mode of **understanding** and **interpretation** characteristic of everyday life.

Human beings express themselves through **language**, attempting to convey meanings that are, initially, their own. However, once words are spoken, they are entrusted to others. Hearing (*sentire*) is not merely a passive act: it already involves a form of **understanding and interpretation**.

This becomes clearer if we consider the notion of **interpretation** through a musical example. The same musical piece can be performed in very different ways depending on the interpreter. Listening to *The Four Seasons* by Vivaldi performed by a full orchestra in a concert hall is very different from hearing the same composition as a phone ringtone. The notes are the same, but the **interpretation** changes the meaning, intensity, and experience.

Language works in a similar way. It contains multiple **layers of meaning**, revealing some aspects while concealing others. Through **hermeneutics**, we become aware of this **plasticity of meaning**.

However, within the horizon of the *das Man*, this dynamic is transformed. The exchange of meanings is reduced to a form of **averageness**. Instead of engaging in deep understanding, individuals rely on **ready-made interpretations**, which are immediately available and require no effort. In this sense, meanings become **ready-to-hand** (*zuhandenheit*) and **present-at-hand** (*vorhandenheit*).

Language, therefore, no longer preserves a rich horizon of possible meanings. Instead, it tends to preserve **sameness** and **conformity**. What is said is expected to be understood in the same way by everyone.

In this condition, discourse no longer seeks the **original meaning** of what is being discussed. Its primary aim becomes **dissemination**: spreading, repeating, and circulating statements in ever wider contexts. In contemporary terms, we might say that discourse aims to become **“viral”**.

Statements gain authority simply because **“that is what is said”**. Through repetition and diffusion, chatter acquires a form of **legitimacy**, even when it lacks depth or truth. This phenomenon is clearly visible in contemporary contexts such as **social media**, where information spreads rapidly and often without verification. Examples include **fake news**, **clickbait**, and forms of communication oriented more toward visibility and engagement than toward understanding.

In this way, **chatter** becomes a dominant mode of communication, shaping how reality is perceived and interpreted in everyday life.

Groundlessness and Superficial Understanding. The authority of chatter is primarily **quantitative**, not qualitative. It appears authoritative because it is widely shared and repeated, not because it is well-founded. As discourse spreads and grows, its original lack of foundation does not diminish; on the contrary, it becomes amplified, until it turns into **groundlessness**.

Even though this average discourse dominates everyday interpretation, it is not rooted in a solid foundation. Nevertheless, this **groundlessness** does not hinder its diffusion; rather, it **facilitates** it.

Chatter allows for discourse about everything without requiring any genuine effort of understanding. The work of interpretation is already presumed to have been done by someone else. In this way, chatter provides an **immediate and accessible understanding** that relieves individuals from the burden of engaging deeply with what is being discussed.

As a result, chatter spreads a form of **indifferent understanding**, in which everything appears accessible, but nothing is truly understood in depth.

It is important to note that, for Heidegger, chatter does not necessarily have a purely negative or deceptive intention. It is not simply the result of deliberate falsification. However, it differs fundamentally from **genuine discourse**.

In authentic dialogue, there is a process of:

- questioning and answering,
- analyzing and confronting perspectives,
- proposing and evaluating interpretations.

These activities aim to **open up** meaning and clarify what is being discussed.

Chatter, instead, does not aim to trace what is said back to its **foundation**. It does not seek to deepen understanding, but rather to **repeat and circulate** discourse. In this sense, it represents a form of **closure**.

This closure is further reinforced by the illusion that everything has already been understood. Once a topic is absorbed into chatter, it tends to **prevent further questioning or reexamination**, treating new inquiries as unnecessary or irrelevant.

Heidegger observes that this mode of understanding is deeply rooted in Dasein. Much of what we know is acquired in this way, and many things remain at this level indefinitely. Only rarely do we engage in a truly **deep understanding** of things. In most cases, we rely on the **average interpretations** provided by chatter, because they are easier and more immediately available.

Chatter and Everyday Suspension. A Dasein that remains within **chatter** exists, so to speak, in a state of **suspension**. In this condition, Dasein still relates to the world, to others, and to itself, but always and only on a **superficial level**.

This superficiality is sustained by the apparent **obviousness** and **security** of the shared, public interpretation. What is commonly accepted appears self-evident: *the more people agree, the more it seems to be true*.

In this state, Dasein remains suspended between:

- **understanding and non-understanding,**
- **openness and closure.**

As a consequence, Dasein does not experience the **uncanniness** (*Spaesatezza*) and **disorientation** that should arise from recognizing the **groundlessness** of its own convictions. The lack of foundation in its discourse does not disturb it, because it is protected by the **comfort of public interpretation**.

In this way, Dasein avoids confronting the instability of its own understanding. It remains within a **comfort zone**, where everything appears already explained and justified.

Heidegger describes this condition as one in which Dasein neither **sinks deeper** nor **risers higher**. Instead, it simply **floats** within the level of **averageness**.

This mode of existence belongs to what Heidegger calls *Alltäglichkeit* (**everydayness**), from *Alltag* (day) and *-keit* (condition). It designates the ordinary, habitual way in which Dasein lives and understands the world in its everyday life.

5.1.2 Curiosity

The second mode of everydayness is what Heidegger calls **curiosity** (*Neugier*). The term itself contains a reference to **care** (*cura*), but in a **degenerated** or **distorted** form.

As we have seen, Dasein is essentially characterized by **care**: it takes care of things and cares for others. This implies engagement, involvement, and activity. However, when this engagement temporarily ceases, when there is no immediate task or responsibility, care does not disappear. Instead, it is **redirected** into curiosity.

Curiosity can therefore be understood as a **transformation of care**. It emerges when care is no longer directed toward meaningful engagement, but seeks new objects without commitment.

What curiosity seeks is not **true knowledge**, but rather a form of **escape**. It allows Dasein to move away from the pressures of engagement and responsibility. It does not aim to see in order to understand, but simply **to see**.

Curiosity is driven by the search for **novelty**. Each new object is not valued in itself, but only as a **transition** toward another new object. In this way, curiosity continuously moves from one thing to another, avoiding boredom but also avoiding depth.

For this reason, curiosity is characterized by an **inability to dwell**. To truly know something, one must stop, observe, and establish a relationship with it. Curiosity, instead, refuses to remain with what is present. It is restless and constantly seeking new stimuli. This condition can be described through two fundamental traits:

- **inability to dwell**: the incapacity to remain with something and understand it,
- **constant distraction**: the continuous shift of attention toward something new.

The terms **distraction** and **diversion** both express this movement: to be distracted means to be **drawn away** (*trahere*) toward something else; diversion similarly indicates a turning away from what is at hand.

Curiosity is therefore not grounded in **wonder** or genuine amazement. It does not arise from a desire to understand what is not yet known, but from the desire to be able to say that **one has seen** or **one has known**.

From these elements emerges a third fundamental characteristic of curiosity: **restlessness**. Curiosity is always in motion, never settled. It is, as Heidegger suggests, **everywhere and nowhere at the same time**. For this reason, it is essentially **rootless**.

What is the **mechanism** that sets in motion the three phenomena of everydayness—**chatter**, **curiosity**, and **ambiguity**?

Heidegger shows that these phenomena are **interconnected**. **Chatter** guides curiosity by indicating what *one must have seen or known*. Curiosity, in turn, being **everywhere and nowhere**, relies on chatter to orient itself.

Thus, these two modes:

- **chatter** (related to discourse),
- **curiosity** (related to vision),

must be understood in their **unity**. Both are characterized by a fundamental **rootlessness**.

Curiosity gives the impression that nothing remains hidden, while chatter makes it seem that everything is already understood. Together, they induce Dasein to believe that it is living in a **fully understood world**.

5.1.3 Ambiguity

This illusion leads to a third phenomenon: **ambiguity** (*Zweideutigkeit, equivoco*).

Ambiguity is the condition in which everything appears to be understood and accessible, while in reality nothing is grasped in a genuine way.

If everything is open to everyone, and anyone can speak about anything, it becomes impossible to distinguish between what is **truly understood** and what is only **apparently understood**. Everything seems clear, but this clarity is superficial.

In this condition, individuals speak competently even about what they have not experienced. Knowledge becomes a matter of **appearance** rather than genuine understanding. This reveals two essential traits of averageness:

- a form of **laziness**, which avoids deep understanding,
- a lack of **interest** in the actual content of what is discussed.

Heidegger even observes that chatter can become **irritated** when what it anticipates actually happens. Why? Because the realization of events removes the possibility of **endless anticipation**, which is what chatter thrives on.

Ambiguity thus elevates **anticipation** and superficial discourse as if they were reality, while discrediting deeper and more demanding forms of **knowledge and understanding**. This creates the illusion that everything has already been decided and understood. In this everyday condition of **inauthentic being-with others**, individuals constantly observe one another. Heidegger describes this as a form of **mutual surveillance**: everyone watches others to see how they behave and what they say.

Being-together, under the influence of the *das Man*, is therefore not a simple coexistence of independent individuals. It is rather a **nervous, ambiguous interaction**, characterized by:

- hidden mutual observation,
- implicit comparison,
- subtle forms of judgment.

In this way, **chatter**, **curiosity**, and **ambiguity** define the structure of **everydayness** (*Alltäglichkeit*), shaping how Dasein exists within the average interpretation of the world.

5.2 Fallenness

In this situation emerges a fundamental mode of Dasein that Heidegger calls **dejection** (*Verfallen, deiezione*), which literally means **falling**.

Here we encounter again the root *iacere* (to throw), already seen in:

- **thrownness** (*Geworfenheit*),
- **project** (*Entwurf*).

However, in this case, we are not dealing with being thrown into the world or projecting ourselves toward possibilities. Instead, **fallenness** describes the condition in which Dasein **falls into** the world of everydayness, becoming absorbed in it.

Fallenness is the state in which Dasein is absorbed in being-with others under the domination of **chatter**, **curiosity**, and **ambiguity**, that is, in **inauthenticity**.

In this condition, Dasein is **immersed** and almost **stunned** by the world and by others. Instead of seeking its own possibilities, it tends to **conform** to the average interpretations of the *das Man*.

Chatter, curiosity, and ambiguity create the illusion that everything has already been seen and understood. As a result, Dasein believes that its condition offers **certainty**,

fullness, and **security**. This produces a state of apparent **tranquility**, in which life seems complete and all possibilities appear open.

However, this tranquility is **illusory**. Beneath it lies a subtle and often unnoticed **uneasiness**. This uneasiness prevents Dasein from truly feeling fulfilled and may manifest as **restlessness**, **frenzy**, or **hyperactivity**.

Temptation, Tranquilization, and Alienation Heidegger describes fallenness as the falling of Dasein into the **groundlessness of everyday inauthenticity**. This condition is characterized by several interrelated modalities:

- **Temptation**: Dasein is drawn toward inauthenticity, finding it easier and more reassuring.
- **Tranquilization**: this inauthentic condition provides comfort and a sense of security.
- **Alienation**: Dasein feels estranged from itself, sensing that something is not fully authentic.

Because Dasein relies on the interpretations provided by the *das Man*, it loses sight of what is **properly its own**. In this way, it enters a condition that can be described as a form of **self-imprisonment**, where its authentic possibilities remain concealed.

5.3 Fear and Anguish

How can Dasein emerge from this vortex of **inauthenticity**? Heidegger identifies a fundamental possibility: **Angst** (**anguish**, *angoscia*).

To understand this, it is essential to distinguish between **fear** and **anguish**.

- **Fear** (*Furcht*) is always directed toward **something**: an entity, a threat, a specific object (e.g., a fire, an animal, a danger). In fear, we can identify what threatens us, and we respond by trying to **move away** from it.
- **Anguish** (*Angst*), instead, has no specific object. It is a **diffuse and indeterminate feeling** that something is not right, without being able to locate its source.

In anguish, what is at stake is not a particular entity, but **being-in-the-world as such**, together with the awareness of the possibility of **no longer being**.

While in fear we escape from something, in anguish we are confronted with ourselves. In this sense, anguish is a form of **self-confrontation**. We cannot direct our escape toward a specific object, because there is nothing determinate to escape from.

The distinctive feature of anguish is therefore its **indeterminacy**. The fact that we cannot identify its source does not mean that it is unreal. On the contrary, it makes it even more unsettling, because we do not know where to turn.

In this state, all entities lose their usual significance. Things that normally appear meaningful or useful no longer provide any orientation or comfort. Heidegger describes this condition as the “**impertinence of nothing**” (*impertinenza del nulla*), meaning that nothing appears **relevant** or **useful** anymore.

The term *pertinere* refers to something that is relevant or serves a purpose. In anguish, this structure collapses: nothing pertains to anything. The network of meanings that usually sustains our everyday life dissolves.

Through this experience, Dasein is detached from the familiar world of **averageness** and confronted with the groundlessness of its existence. For this reason, anguish opens up the possibility of moving beyond inauthenticity.

5.3.1 Nothingness and the Abyss

Returning to the critique of the **subject**, Heidegger shows that not only are we not the stable **ground** upon which reality is founded, but we also discover that **beneath us there is no ground**.

This condition is expressed by the term **Abgrund** (*ab* = without, *Grund* = ground). Abgrund is the **abyss**, the groundless depth of **nothingness**.

Dasein experiences this abyss through its own structure as **possibility**. Every choice we make actualizes one possibility, but at the same time it excludes all the other possibilities that we will **never realize**. Around what we are, there opens the abyss of what we **could have been but are not**.

This becomes even more radical when we consider that all possibilities are ultimately **taken away** by the most certain and extreme possibility: **death**.

In **anguish**, Dasein experiences a form of **dispossession**: a “*robbery of nothingness*” (*rapina del nulla*). The threat that emerges in anguish does not come from a specific entity. It comes from **nowhere**, and yet it is **already here**. It does not approach from outside, because it belongs to the very structure of existence.

5.3.2 Anguish and the Recovery of the Authentic Self

It is important to clarify that, in anguish, the world does not **disappear**. Things, others, and situations are still present, but they become **insignificant**. What collapses is not the existence of the world, but its **meaning as a whole**.

When anguish fades, the discourse of the *das Man* tends to trivialize the experience by saying: “*it was nothing*”. Paradoxically, this expression is correct in an **ontological sense**: it was indeed a confrontation with **nothingness**.

In anguish, everything that usually gives meaning to our life, such as things, others, roles, **withdraws**. What remains is Dasein alone with itself. **Anguish** is a fundamental experience that removes the mediation of averageness and exposes Dasein to its **authentic self**.

It acts as a form of **subtraction**: it removes the layer of **mediality** (the *das Man*) that stands between Dasein and its authentic possibilities.

In everyday life, Dasein is immersed in a condition of **tranquil familiarity**. It feels “at home” in the world, surrounded by things and others, and remains in a kind of **ontic sleep**, absorbed in entities.

However, this tranquility is **illusory**. It conceals a deeper instability.

Anguish interrupts this state. It is not merely a negative or oppressive feeling, but a **revealing experience**. Heidegger describes it metaphorically as something that **lifts** Dasein out of its fallenness, like an **eagle** that takes it away from its immersion in the world, and brings it back to itself.

Through anguish, Dasein is called back from dispersion and confronted with its own **authentic existence**.

6

Lecture of 30/03/2026

6.1 Death as the Extreme Possibility of Dasein

The topic addressed in this lecture is one of the most fundamental in Heidegger's thought: **death**.

Why is it so important to reflect on death? Because it is the only **certain and universal experience** shared by all human beings. Everyone must die.

To approach this question, we can distinguish between:

- **organisms**: all living beings, governed by **natural intelligence** (*bios*),
- **mechanisms**: artificial systems, governed by **artificial intelligence** and **programs**.

Dasein shares something with both:

- with organisms, it shares **biological life** (birth and death),
- with mechanisms, it shares **language** and **logos**.

However, Dasein cannot be reduced neither to a biological organism governed by instinct, nor to a mechanism functioning through predetermined algorithms.

What distinguishes Dasein is that it is a **Können-sein**: a **being-able-to-be**. It exists in the dimension of **possibility**, not necessity.

While organisms follow fixed biological programs and mechanisms operate through pre-defined rules, Dasein has the burden (and the freedom) of **projecting itself**. It must, so to speak, **write its own existence**.

Dasein always starts from what it already is, but it is constantly oriented toward what it **can become**. As long as Dasein exists, it is always engaged with this openness of possibilities.

This means that throughout its life, Dasein must constantly confront its own **freedom**, understood as the necessity to choose among possibilities and to project itself toward the future.

Philosophy, law, and society offer many different definitions of **freedom**. Here, we can approach it through the idea of “**spazio di gioco**” (space for play).

We say that something has **play** when it is not rigidly fixed. For example, a door has play when it moves slightly within its frame, when it does not fit perfectly, when there is a **margin of movement**.

In the same way, human beings are not rigidly determined by necessity. Unlike other living beings, governed by fixed instincts, Dasein exists within a **margin of openness**. It is precisely within this **space of movement** that freedom resides. Freedom is not absolute arbitrariness, but the **possibility of moving within a range of possibilities**.

However, if Dasein is a being of possibilities, then the totality of its possibilities must also include the **extreme possibility**: the possibility of **no longer being**, that is, **death**.

No matter how many possibilities Dasein realizes during its life, as long as it exists, there is always one possibility that remains unrealized: the **last one**. When this final possibility is realized, all other possibilities are **simultaneously canceled**. In this sense, death completes Dasein, but at the same time **annihilates** it.

This leads to a paradox: death is something we **must undergo**, but we cannot truly **experience** it. There is no such thing as an “expert of death”, because one dies only once, and in dying, one can no longer reflect upon it.

6.1.1 The Death of Others

For this reason, death is in a sense **inaccessible** to the individual Dasein. What we encounter instead is the **death of others**.

Since Dasein is always **being-with** (*Mitsein*), our relation to others becomes the way through which death appears to us. The death of another shows us, in a concrete and undeniable way, the end of a Dasein: *prima ci era un esserci che ora non ci è più* (there was a being-there that is no longer there).

What remains is no longer a Dasein, but a **mere presence**, a body among other things in the world. This is a **deficient mode of being**: what was once a living existence becomes an entity.

And yet, the deceased is not treated simply as a thing. The dead are approached differently: through **mourning**, **memory**, and **care**. Those who remain continue to relate to the deceased, but they cannot truly **experience** the other’s death.

Heidegger emphasizes this saying that we can only **attend** it.

The term **attending** (*ad-sistere*) has a double meaning:

- it means to **be present**, to accompany, to care,
- but also to **be a spectator**, like attending a concert or a lecture.

Thus, in the face of death, we are involved but not fully participants: we are present, but as **witnesses**, not as those who undergo the experience.

Despite the closeness we may feel toward the deceased, we remain **external observers**. The loss experienced by those who attend a death is not comparable to the loss undergone by the one who dies.

In some cases, within being-with others, there exists the possibility of **substitution**: one Dasein may take the place of another, for example in acts of heroism or sacrifice. However, even in these cases, substitution does not eliminate death; it merely **postpones** it. Death remains an **irreducibly individual** experience.

6.1.2 The Not-Yet and the End

What has been said about death can be summarized in three key points:

- As long as Dasein lives, it is characterized by a **not-yet**: a set of possibilities that are still open and unrealized.
- Death represents the **end of being-in-the-world**, that is, the complete loss of these possibilities.
- Death is a mode of being in which **substitution is impossible**: no one can die in place of another.

Dasein is therefore marked by a constant **non-totality**. Only death completes this totality, but it does so by **eliminating** the very existence it completes.

Like all living beings, humans are thrown into **time**, and their existence unfolds through different stages. However, Heidegger introduces an important distinction when comparing Dasein to other forms of life.

Maturation and Death. Consider the example of a **fruit**: a seed becomes a sprout, then a plant, and finally a mature fruit. This process follows a **predetermined path**. The fruit does not choose what it will become; its development is guided by nature. Heidegger asks whether the “**not-yet**” of a fruit can be compared to the “**not-yet**” of Dasein. His answer is **no**.

In the fruit, everything is already implicitly contained. Its development is a process of **actualization** of what is already given. There is no freedom, no decision, no uncertainty. In Dasein, instead, the **not-yet** is fundamentally different. It is not simply something that will be realized according to a fixed plan. It is **open**, **uncertain**, and sometimes even **inaccessible** to Dasein itself. Human beings do not fully know what they will become.

Thus, while both living beings and humans are in a process of becoming, the nature of this process is different. The **maturation** of a fruit (its *fine* as fulfillment) is not comparable to **death** (the *fine* as termination) of Dasein.

In other words, for the fruit, the end is the **completion of its development**; for Dasein, the end is the **cessation of its possibilities**.

With **maturation**, a fruit reaches its fulfillment: it becomes what it was meant to be. But can we say the same about **death** for Dasein?

Although death completes the course of life, it does not **fulfill** Dasein in the same way. Rather than completing its possibilities, death **takes them away**. It is, as we have seen, a “**robbery of nothingness**”.

For this reason, Heidegger distinguishes between: **coming to an end** (fulfillment) and **ending** (cessation).

In everyday language, these expressions have different meanings:

- something can end as a **completion** (a finished work),
- as a **termination** (rain stopping),
- as a **consumption** (bread being eaten),
- or as an **interruption**.

However, none of these meanings adequately describe the **death of Dasein**. These notions apply to **entities**, not to a being that exists as possibility.

Dasein is always projected toward a **not-yet**, but at the same time it is also exposed to its **no-more**. Human existence unfolds between these two poles:

$$\text{not-yet} \quad \longleftrightarrow \quad \text{no-more}$$

The possibility that all possibilities may cease is present **from the very beginning**. As Heidegger states, as soon as a human being is born, he is already **old enough to die**. Death is not something that arrives only at the end; it is a **structural possibility** that accompanies Dasein throughout its entire existence.

6.2 Death as a Phenomenon of Life

This analysis is not intended to produce despair or to explain what happens after death. From a **phenomenological** perspective, the question of what comes after death lies outside the field of inquiry. Phenomenology deals only with what **appears** and how it appears.

Similarly, science can analyze death through data and statistics, but it cannot address its **ultimate meaning**. Questions about injustice, evil, or what follows death belong to other domains, such as ethics or religion.

What can be observed phenomenologically is that death is a **phenomenon of life**. It is not external to existence, but deeply **rooted within** Dasein.

Death is not merely a distant or abstract possibility. It is an **imminence** that accompanies Dasein at every moment. While many events can threaten us in life, none of them has the same character as death. Other events concern particular situations; death concerns **Dasein as a whole**.

Death is the possibility of no longer being able to be. It is the possibility that ends all possibilities.

This fundamental possibility reveals itself most clearly in **anguish** (*Angst*), where Dasein is confronted with its own finite existence.

6.3 Everyday Evasion of Death

Heidegger observes that **authentic anguish**, the one that brings Dasein back to itself, like the image of the eagle that lifts it out of mediocrity, is a **rare** experience.

In everyday life, Dasein tends to **flee** from this anguish. Most people avoid thinking about death and remove it from both their thoughts and their conversations. Instead of confronting it, Dasein takes refuge in **distraction**, **entertainment**, and everyday activities, attempting to escape the disorientation that death provokes.

6.3.1 The Interpretation of Death in *das Man*

In this process, the *das Man* (the impersonal “one”) plays a decisive role. It offers ready-made interpretations and constant opportunities to divert attention away from the anxiety of death. Through **chatter** and **ambiguity**, death is covered over and neutralized, preventing Dasein from facing it authentically.

Within this everyday perspective, death is understood as something that **happens to others**: to a stranger, a friend, a public figure. Death becomes a **common, repetitive event**, something ordinary that no longer provokes astonishment. The typical discourse says: “*sooner or later, one dies, but for now we are still alive*”.

In this way, death is pushed into an **indeterminate future**. It is acknowledged as certain, but not as **imminent**. The expression “one dies” creates an ambiguity: my own death, which is singular and irreplaceable, is transformed into something that happens to others.

Even in situations of proximity to death, this mechanism persists. Those who accompany the dying often try to reassure them, suggesting that everything will be fine, that they

will recover. This attempt to comfort, however, reveals a **hidden fear** that cannot be openly acknowledged.

Within the everyday logic of *das Man*, thinking about death is discouraged. It is seen as a sign of weakness, insecurity, or pessimism. Dasein is expected to maintain an **indifferent calm** in the face of death. Yet this cultivated indifference does not truly reassure; rather, it **alienates** Dasein from its most authentic possibilities.

In this average interpretation, death is indeed recognized as certain, but no one is **authentically certain** of their own death. Its certainty is weakened by the indeterminacy of *when*. By postponing the thought of death to a future that is never present, Dasein escapes into everyday concerns and urgent tasks.

6.4 Anticipation and Authentic Being-toward-Death

Death cannot be understood through **calculation** or **statistics**. It does not belong to the domain of scientific knowledge. The only way to relate to death authentically is through **anticipation**.

To **attend** death means two things at once:

- to **await** it, projecting oneself toward it,
- to be **attentive** to it, keeping it present in thought.

Through this anticipation, Dasein restores to death its proper weight. Death is no longer a distant eventuality, but becomes a **present possibility** that concerns Dasein directly. In this authentic relation, death reveals itself as the **possibility of the impossibility of existence**. It is the ultimate possibility that requires Dasein to confront the necessity of **renouncing itself**.

We have defined Dasein as a *Geworfen Entwurf*, a **thrown project**. This expression captures the dual movement that characterizes human existence: on one side, we are **thrown** into the world; on the other, we are called to **project** ourselves within it.

This dynamic of becoming, this continuous projection toward possibilities, comes to an end with **death**. Death is a possibility that offers no further horizon, no possibility beyond itself. It is the point at which every projection is **interrupted**.

6.4.1 The Liberating Function of Angst

However, opening ourselves to this possibility, accepting in **anguish** the threat that arises from our very being, has a **liberating effect**. By confronting death, Dasein is able to free itself from all those possibilities that are not truly its own: those imposed by others, inherited uncritically, or followed merely out of conformity.

In this sense, **Angst** plays a decisive role. It withdraws Dasein from the domination of others and places the world itself in a kind of **suspension**. What previously appeared obvious, necessary, or unquestionable loses its hold.

In this condition, Dasein ceases to flee from itself. It is no longer absorbed in the distractions of everyday life, but begins to **project itself authentically**. This projection is grounded in the recognition of its most certain possibility: that it is a being **toward an end**.

Thus, anguish does not simply reveal finitude as a limitation, but as the very condition that allows Dasein to recover its **authentic possibilities** and to take ownership of its existence.

Lecture of 31/03/2026

7.1 Truth and Interpretation

Let us go deeper into the concept of **logos** by reflecting on the idea of **truth**.

When we ask “what is truth?”, we often give answers such as: a set of facts, something everyone agrees on, or an average interpretation of reality. However, there is already something problematic in the question itself, because it assumes that truth is something already given, something that stands in front of us.

We can ask what is true in a specific situation (“is it raining?”, “am I standing or sitting?”), but asking what truth *is* in general is an unfounded question.

In the Bible, we read that **the truth will set you free**. This may be one of the most meaningful ways to understand truth, because it suggests that truth is not merely a fact, but an **experience**, something that transforms us and changes our perspective on reality. Truth is therefore something **dynamic**, not a fixed set of objective data. The modern tendency to equate truth with scientific certainty arises from the human need to **dominate** and **control** the world, organizing it as a *Gestell* and using it as a *Bestand*.

Most of what we call truth today are **secondary truths**: we agree to adopt certain criteria, such as the scientific method, instead of others. But this raises a question: are there absolute criteria to determine truth?

The answer is no. There are no universal and definitive criteria, because truth is always connected to the **historical context**, to the **questions we ask**, to the **purposes we pursue**, and to the way those questions are formulated.

Every Dasein, through its **thrownness**, is already equipped with inherited criteria that shape its thinking and define the horizon of meaning within which it interprets reality. For example, in the 16th century, **witch trials** were based on precise and accepted criteria. This shows that what is considered true can change radically depending on the historical horizon.

We can certainly speak of truth in a limited sense (for example, $2 + 2 = 4$), but we cannot use such criteria to decide the **meaning of our existence** or to determine concepts like justice once and for all.

Consider practical situations: in a hospital during a pandemic or a war, who should be treated first? Children? The elderly? Pregnant women? Soldiers? There are no absolute criteria that can definitively answer such questions.

If we increasingly delegate decisions to machines, how can we program these **unprogrammable choices**? The truths that matter most to us cannot be reduced to scientific demonstration.

7.1.1 Truth as Recognition and Interpretation

From a hermeneutic perspective, truth is not something we simply **know**, but something we **recognize**. Like seeing ourselves in a mirror, we cannot access truth directly; we encounter it through **reflection**.

This leads to the idea that there are no pure facts independent of interpretation. Facts must always be stated and interpreted by someone. Every interpretation takes place within a perspective that does not depend entirely on us, but is shaped by our existential condition.

This can be disturbing, because objectivity, what we can touch and measure, seems more reliable. Yet even science has undergone multiple **paradigm shifts**, showing that its truths are not immutable.

Truth, therefore, is deeply connected to **intersubjectivity**. Even scientific experiments depend on agreement: they must be repeatable, and their validity relies on the convergence of multiple observers.

In everyday life, this becomes clear. If I hang a painting on the wall, I need someone else to confirm whether it is straight. I cannot fully determine it by myself.

Truth is not only a matter of complete and objective description. If someone asks me where I am, telling the truth does not mean listing every detail (Europe, Italy, Rome, etc.), but giving a **relevant answer** based on the situation.

A map provides a final example: it cannot reproduce reality in its entirety. If it did, it would be useless. A map must select, simplify, and interpret reality according to a purpose.

Thus, truth is always linked to **perspective**, **context**, and **relation**. It is not the total possession of reality, but a **meaningful interpretation** of it or a **meaningful orientation** within it.

A first important point has been clarified: **truth and interpretation are not opposed**. Truth is not something that stands against interpretation; rather, it is **made of interpretations**.

Just like justice, truth is not something that already exists in nature as a ready-made object. It must pass through the **human effort** of searching for meaning, a process that necessarily involves **language** and **dialogue**.

7.1.2 The Myth of Truth and Lie

However, truth is not only linked to interpretation. From the very beginning, it is also connected to its counterpart: the **lie**.

To introduce this relation, we can consider the **myth of truth and lie**.

In this myth, Truth and Lie meet and begin to walk together. While talking, they arrive at a well. Lie convinces Truth to take a bath. As soon as Truth undresses, Lie steals her clothes and runs away, presenting itself to the people as Truth.

When Truth comes out of the well, she is **naked** (*Veritas* is the naked truth). The people, scandalized by her nudity, reject her and force her back into the well, where she remains hidden.

This simple myth contains several important insights.

First, anyone who seeks truth must be willing to **descend into the well**, to go deep, to abandon the surface. In Heideggerian terms, this means facing **anguish** and confronting the **abyss** (*Abgrund*) that lies beneath everyday inauthenticity.

Second, a lie that is **well dressed** can become **plausible**. When Lie wears the clothes of Truth, it is easily accepted.

Third, **truth can be scandalous**. When it appears in its naked form, it disturbs and provokes rejection.

As a consequence, a **well-dressed lie is often preferred** to a naked and unsettling truth.

Another important point is that Lie does not have the courage to descend into the well, while Truth does. This reveals the **dynamic and transformative nature** of truth: it requires effort, exposure, and risk.

The well itself has a symbolic meaning. Looking into it, we see not only the truth at the bottom, but also our own **reflection** on the surface of the water. This reflection represents our **interpretation**. The subject who seeks truth does not disappear; rather, it becomes part of the process.

Finally, the myth shows that truth is not something that fully exposes itself. Its nature is not pure appearance, but rather a form of **withdrawal**. Truth tends to **hide**, to remain partially concealed.

In this sense, truth is not something immediately available, but something that must be **sought, interpreted, and brought to light**.

7.1.3 *Aletheia*: Truth as Path and Unconcealment

This concept is closely connected to the Greek word for truth: **ἀλήθεια** (*Aletheia*).

There are two possible etymological interpretations of this term, each revealing a different way of understanding truth and its search.

In the first interpretation, **ἀλήθεια** is divided into **ἀλή** (*Alé*), meaning “footsteps”, and **θεια** (*Theia*), meaning “divine”. Truth, in this sense, can be understood as “**divine footsteps**”.

This interpretation suggests a **dynamic and contemplative** approach: truth is not something to be captured or possessed, but something to be **followed**. It is like tracing the path of something sacred, moving step by step without the pretension of fully grasping it. The search for truth becomes a **journey**, an attentive and receptive way of dwelling in reality.

In the second interpretation, **ἀλήθεια** is divided into **ἄ** (“not”) and **λήθεια** (from the verb *lanthànō*, meaning “to be hidden”). In this sense, truth means “**not hidden**”, or **unconcealment**.

Here, truth is understood as the act of **bringing something out of hiding**, of **unveiling** what is concealed. Interestingly, to **unveil** means to remove a veil, while to **reveal** also implies a movement of veiling again. Thus, the core of this interpretation is the idea of **hiding and revealing**.

In this second perspective, the search for truth becomes more **active** and **inquisitive**. It is not simply following a path, but actively trying to **expose** and **illuminate** what is hidden.

A useful image helps clarify the difference between these two approaches. In the first case, it is like walking in a forest guided by **fireflies**, gently following their light. In the second case, it is like using a **flashlight**, directing a beam to uncover specific things in the darkness.

These two interpretations show that truth can be approached both as a **path to follow** and as a **process of unveiling**, highlighting its dynamic and multifaceted nature.

7.2 Truth, Technology, and Transparency

As we have already seen, the **technical attitude** leads human beings to relate to everything around them, such as nature, living beings, and even other human beings, not in a contemplative way, but in a **manipulative** one. Things are no longer encountered for what they are, but for what they can be **used for**.

Thus, the forest is no longer a forest in itself, but becomes a **resource** (*Bestand*): a reserve of wood for construction, heating, hunting, or shelter. Everything is directed and forced toward human purposes and inserted into projects.

This techno-scientific approach, intensified by digital technologies, fully embraces the idea of truth as something to be **brought out of hiding**, exposed, and made completely transparent.

A clear example can be found in the digital world. On the internet, individuals are constantly pushed to **expose themselves**, sharing personal data (voluntarily or not) as

a condition for existing within the network. The inner world is transformed into **content**, something to be displayed and consumed.

In this context, **transparency** becomes the dominant model of truth. Transparency is opposed to **appearance**: while appearance is how something shows itself spontaneously, transparency seeks to **break through the surface** and expose everything from within. According to Heidegger, this way of unveiling, the one that removes the veil without restoring it, is a **violent** relation to truth. It lacks **care**. It does not respect the balance between proximity and distance, between revealing and concealing. It is an exposure without **Rücksicht** (respectful distance) and without **Nachsicht** (benevolent approach).

7.2.1 Truth as Clearing

Against this, Heidegger proposes a different image of truth: **truth as clearing** (*Lichtung, radura*).

A clearing is what appears when, in a dense forest, the trees open up and allow **light** to filter through. It is not a total illumination, but a **space** where something can appear. Human beings always move within a horizon of **mystery** and **concealment**. In this condition, truth cannot be a total and blinding exposure, but only a **partial illumination**. Heidegger plays on the ambiguity of the word *light*, which means both **light as illumination** and **light as lightening, making space**. In this sense:

- light illuminates what appears,
- the clearing creates the space in which it can appear.

Truth is therefore not something fixed, complete, and fully accessible. It is not a total possession of reality. Rather, it is an **event**, a **happening**, a moment in which something becomes visible without ever being completely exhausted.

It is like a **crack of light** that opens within the unknown, without eliminating the mystery that surrounds it. Truth exists precisely within this tension between revealing and concealing.

This conception is very far from the contemporary idea of truth as total **transparency**, where everything must be exposed and made visible. For Heidegger, truth requires not only unveiling, but also the preservation of what remains **hidden**.

7.3 Transparency and Surveillance Society

Transparency has been elevated to a value, presented as a formula capable of ensuring a more efficient and secure life. Yet, contrary to its democratic promise, it has increasingly become an **instrument of control** in the hands of corporations and governments.

Surveillance technologies monitor and shape behaviors, while the very ideal of transparency conceals the **real structures of power**. Individuals are encouraged to share every aspect of their lives, producing a digital environment in which they **voluntarily expose themselves** in search of recognition and validation. In this way, the conditions are created for the growth of a **surveillance society**.

In a context dominated by self-exposure, genuine human connection becomes increasingly rare. The constant performance of the self leaves little room for empathy, while fostering **competition** and **shame**. The spectacle of transparency shows everything that can be exposed, but in doing so it **empties it of meaning**.

Something can be transparent only if it is, in a sense, **empty**.

7.3.1 From Narrative to Digital Exposure

If we consider traditional narratives, like stories, myths, and accounts transmitted within families, we see that they create a **symbolic continuity** between generations. These narratives are addressed to us personally, and through them a shared world of meaning is built.

Today, however, narratives have largely moved online. Digital stories (for example, those shared on social platforms) are produced by **strangers**, who become familiar to us without ever truly encountering us. These contents enter our daily lives through **infotainment**, a mixture of information and entertainment.

Yet these narratives differ profoundly from traditional ones. They are often driven by **commercial intentions**, rather than by the desire to transmit experience. The act of storytelling itself changes meaning: instead of a shared participation in another's existence, it becomes a **one-way transmission** of content.

What once created closeness now becomes a **ghostly and ephemeral presence**. We attend, we observe, but we do not truly participate.

From a phenomenological perspective, the democratization of communication also has positive aspects, such as bypassing traditional media filters and making certain realities visible. However, an increase in information does not necessarily lead to **better understanding**.

More information is not better information.

On the contrary, the excess of information can generate **noise** that paralyzes our capacity for judgment. At a certain point, information ceases to illuminate and instead becomes a form of **darkness**.

It no longer informs, but **deforms**, flattening everything within the uniform structure of digital platforms. In this environment, **truth and lies wear the same clothes**: they both appear as information.

7.3.2 Fake News and the Crisis of Truth

Let us now consider the phenomenon of **fake news**. Their purpose is not truly communicative, but **addictive**. They are designed to generate cycles of consumption, to capture attention, and to keep users engaged.

Fake news are not simply lies. They are something more dangerous: they are **indifferent to reality**. The crisis of truth we are experiencing today does not stem from a simple mismatch between facts and knowledge, nor from a lack of information. Rather, it undermines our very **trust in facts themselves**.

With the development of technologies such as generative artificial intelligence, it is now possible to create images, videos, and content that perfectly mimic reality. This leads to a condition in which we begin to **doubt what we see**. The problem is no longer distinguishing true from false, but the erosion of the very idea that something can be **trusted as real**.

7.3.3 The Digital Panopticon

This situation can be understood through the concept of the **Panopticon**. Originally conceived as a prison structure, the Panopticon is organized in such a way that a single observer can monitor all individuals, who are isolated from one another and unable to communicate.

In its digital form, however, the Panopticon operates differently. Individuals are not isolated; on the contrary, they are **encouraged to communicate** and interact. This is because interaction generates **data**. A connected individual produces far more information than an isolated one.

In this **digital panopticon**, trust becomes unnecessary. Information is always available, and the traditional need to rely on others is replaced by systems of **control**. Trust, as a social practice, gradually loses its meaning, while control expands into every aspect of life.

The society of transparency thus reveals its proximity to a **society of surveillance**. However, unlike the classical model, where control was achieved through isolation, here it is achieved through **connection** and **hypercommunication**.

The inhabitants of this system are not prisoners in the traditional sense. They do not feel constrained. On the contrary, they experience a sense of **freedom**. Yet this freedom masks a deeper mechanism: individuals **voluntarily expose themselves**, constantly producing and sharing information.

This leads to a form of **self-exploitation**, which is more effective than external coercion because it is accompanied by the **feeling of freedom**. People expose themselves not because they are forced to, but because they feel the need to share, to be seen, to be recognized.

In this condition, the boundary between freedom and control collapses. The society of control reaches its full realization precisely when individuals **participate in it willingly**, exposing their private lives without restraint. At this point, freedom and control **coincide**.



UNIVERSITÀ DEGLI STUDI DI ROMA LA SAPIENZA

PART II

Digital Existence and Techno-Capitalism



Lecture of 13/04/2026

8.1 Philosophy and the Networked Human Being

Many branches of knowledge attempt to define what it means to be a human being in the networked world. These include scientific disciplines such as neuroscience, as well as the so-called human sciences, like social psychology and anthropology.

However, these approaches, although valid within their own domains, often provide a **fragmented or partial vision**. They struggle to capture the full depth and breadth of the transformations brought about by this new form of existence.

Philosophy, instead, is situated **upstream** of these specific fields of knowledge. Its task is not to provide another specialized explanation, but to bring to light the **most fundamental questions**, those that are usually overlooked because they are taken for granted, assumed to be already clarified.

By redirecting attention to what remains implicit or hidden, philosophy engages in a work of **reconstruction**: it questions the underlying assumptions, values, and meanings that shape our thinking and our actions.

This approach allows us to identify not only what is already happening, but also the **possible developments** that have not yet been fully recognized or pursued.

In this perspective, Heidegger's analysis remains central. In 1927, he describes the human being as **Dasein**, that is, a being that is aware of its own existence.

Adopting a **phenomenological** approach, Heidegger identifies the fundamental structures of this existence, the so-called **existentials**, which define the way in which Dasein is in the world.

8.2 Dasein on the Net: From Appearance to Exposure

Before proceeding, a preliminary consideration is necessary. **Phenomenology**, as we have seen, is the method that consists in observing a phenomenon and describing it as it appears.

However, when Dasein is on the net, its mode of appearing is fundamentally different. Being online is not a necessary and involuntary condition, like being-in-the-world. It is not something in which we simply find ourselves.

Here we can identify a first peculiarity: the phenomenon of Dasein on the net does not simply **appear**, it **exposes itself**.

On digital platforms, Dasein is not immediately present before others. In everyday life, we are always already in front of others and others are in front of us. Online, instead, this presence must be **constructed**. Dasein must actively **expose itself**.

This introduces a fundamental mediation between the observer and what is observed. On the net, we do not simply exist; we must **connect**. There is no being-online without this act of exposure. To be there is to **make oneself visible**.

The notion of exposure has a double meaning. On the one hand, it derives from *ex-porre*, meaning to bring something out, to express oneself so that others may see. On the other hand, exposure is always the result of a **deliberate staging**. What is shown is not simply given, but **selected**.

Unlike the shared world, where others are always present, online we can know another Dasein only through what it **chooses to reveal**. Outside of this exposure, there is nothing: *non-ci-è*.

For this reason, the digital environment imposes a constant demand: we must **publish**. That is, we must make public what would otherwise remain private: our preferences, opinions, abilities, and above all, our **image**.

8.2.1 Exposure and Concealment

At the core of exposure lies a fundamental structure: every act of exposing is also an act of **concealing**. What is shown necessarily implies that something else is **hidden**.

This concealment corresponds to what remains **private**, withdrawn from the public gaze. Even if it seems that privacy is progressively eroded by the compulsion to share, this process never becomes total.

No matter how intense the exposure, there will always remain **unseen moments**, aspects of existence that escape visibility. In this sense, Dasein never fully coincides with what it shows, nor is it ever completely exhausted by its exposure.

This transformation leads to a further consequence: the boundary between **public** and **private** becomes blurred. The distinction no longer lies between what is public and what is private, but rather between what we **choose to reveal** and what we deliberately **withhold**.

8.2.2 Performance, Projection, and Digital Identity

What do we tend not to expose? Typically, everything that does not enhance the image we wish to project: our failures, defeats, moments of fragility, unflattering aspects of ourselves. In short, everything that we would rather not confront is first withdrawn from the gaze of others.

In doing so, we begin to present ourselves as **goods**, displayed like products on supermarket shelves. This analogy is not accidental: just as goods are arranged to attract attention and be consumed, so too do we expose ourselves online. The relationship with others is no longer grounded in gratuitousness, but in the attempt to **capture attention**, to draw others into our own network.

This dynamic of **exposure and concealment** produces a fragmented and inauthentic vision of both others and ourselves. What appears is not the other as such, but a **mediated and filtered version**.

The term *alter* (the other) acquires here a new meaning: the other becomes an **altered alter**, that is, a modified, staged version of themselves. Their presence is no longer immediate, but constructed and filtered through layers of mediation.

In this context, **Mitsein** (being-with-others) undergoes a profound transformation. Deprived of concrete bonds such as friendship, affection, or shared work, it is reduced to the **consumption of content** produced by others.

Thus, the mode of being online is no longer simply being-in-the-world, but **performance**. Each individual becomes both actor and product, continuously staging themselves.

This performative structure has a decisive consequence: it removes the **authentic presence of the other** from our existential horizon. We are no longer in direct relation with others, but only with their projections.

As a result, we are simultaneously distanced **from others** and **from ourselves**. The virtual society does not grant access to the other as such, but only to the **representation** each Dasein constructs and exposes.

The notion of **projection** can be understood in a cinematic sense: it is the film that Dasein constructs and displays online, where it is at once **actor, protagonist, director, and producer**.

When being-in-the-world enters the network, it is partially relieved of the burden of developing an authentic existential project. Instead, Dasein tends to take refuge in an **identitarian projection**, specifically designed for others.

It is important to distinguish between **project** and **projection**. The project is oriented toward oneself: it concerns the concrete realization of one's possibilities in life. The projection, although sharing the same root, is oriented toward others. It does not aim at realization, but at **display**.

Why do we expose ourselves for others rather than for ourselves? Because digital plat-

forms are structured around performance and amplify what Heidegger calls **comparative measurement** (*comparazione commisurante*). Relationships are shaped through processes of comparison: distinction, opposition, leveling, or denial of differences.

In this framework, being-with-others is governed by **subjection to others**. Two main dynamics emerge. On the one hand, **admiration**, which can easily turn into **envy**. Both share the same root related to seeing (*mirare, videre*). On the other hand, when confronted with the curated lives of others, we may experience **shame** or **guilt**.

The network intensifies this natural tendency to compare by translating it into a **numerical language**: likes, views, followers. Here, **quantitative approval** replaces qualitative judgment. The simple act of liking does not require explanation; what matters is not *why* something is appreciated, but *how much* it is.

In this environment, what counts is no longer what something **is**, but how it **appears**. Not appearance as genuine manifestation, but as **semblance**. It is no longer necessary to realize a concrete project in reality in order to provoke admiration or envy. It is sufficient to project an identity that appears as we wish to be seen.

8.2.3 From Immediacy to Instantaneity

Even media that claim to present reality in its immediacy inevitably introduce mediation. Indeed, the very act of recording and presenting a phenomenon already implies an **interpretation**. This results in a **double mediation**: first, the recording of the event; second, its presentation online.

It is therefore essential to distinguish between **immediacy** and **instantaneity**. Immediacy refers to an experience without mediation, lived in presence. Instantaneity, instead, characterizes the rapid consumption of content offered by digital media. These two dimensions do not coincide.

Thus, the digital experience replaces lived immediacy with a form of **instant consumption**, further distancing Dasein from an authentic relation with reality.

8.3 Reinterpreting Heidegger's Existentials in the Digital Age

Let us now reconsider Heidegger's existential structures in what we may call the **age of algorithmic power**.

8.3.1 Being-in-the-Web

The first fundamental structure is **being-in-the-world** (*In-der-Welt-sein*). To this, we can add a new, contemporary dimension: **being-in-the-web** (*In-der-Web-sein*), a for-

mulation that is not Heidegger's, but helps us interpret our present condition.

The world, as we have seen, is not merely a geographical space, but a **network of meanings and practical references** that we inherit and progressively inhabit. To be in the world means, first of all, to **experience it**: to become familiar with it through practice, habit, and interaction.

From Contact to Connection. This familiarity arises through **contact**. To come into contact with the world means to engage with things, tools, and others in a direct, embodied way. The term itself reveals this dimension: *con-tact* contains the root of *touch* (from the Latin *tango*).

Our first understanding of the world is not theoretical but **practical and sensory**. As children, we do not know that water is H_2O ; we know it by touching it, drinking it, experiencing it. The **senses** are the channels through which this exchange between ourselves, the world, and others takes place.

Heidegger names this exchange *Umgang*: a term that indicates not only interaction, but also **manipulation and engagement**, an active exchange of energy, ideas, and possibilities.

In the digital environment, however, **contact is replaced by connection**. This shift has profound consequences. Connection operates at a distance and relies only on those senses that can function across space and time: **sight and hearing**.

Online, we gain an almost unlimited capacity to see and hear. Yet this expansion comes at the cost of a **reduction**: we must renounce touch, taste, and smell, those senses that require physical presence and direct experience.

Thus, inhabiting the network means knowing the world while **excluding three of our five senses**. This transformation alters the very structure of experience, since these excluded senses play a fundamental role in shaping our understanding and orienting our search for meaning.

In this way, **being-in-the-web** modifies the original condition of being-in-the-world: it replaces embodied familiarity with a mediated, partial, and distance-based relation to reality.

8.3.2 Digital Thrownness

Let us now consider the second existential: **thrownness** (*Geworfenheit*).

Thrownness refers to the unavoidable condition in which each of us finds ourselves: we are cast into the world without having chosen it, into a specific time, society, body, and context.

At first glance, it would seem improper to extend this concept to the digital sphere. No one has literally thrown us into the network. We **choose** to enter it, for example by

creating profiles and accounts.

And yet, once we inhabit this digital *Umwelt* (surrounding world), the sense of **dis-orientation**, **rootlessness**, and **lostness** does not disappear. On the contrary, it often becomes even more intense.

The Net as Protection and Capture. Let us reflect on the structure of the web itself. A network is composed of **nodes and links**. This structure allows for connection, but also suggests another image: the **net**.

In one sense, the net can be seen as a **protective device**. Like the net used by acrobats, it prevents us from falling into the void. Similarly, during events such as the pandemic, the network functioned as a **means of salvation**, allowing connection when physical contact was dangerous.

It is not accidental that *contact* and *contagion* share the same root (from *tango*, to touch), yet diverge in meaning.

However, the net also has a more unsettling dimension. It is not only a tool of protection, but also a **device of capture**. Here, the metaphor of **fishing** becomes illuminating.

Every action performed online leaves a **trace**. This introduces a scenario structured around **predators and prey**. On one side, there are large corporations that collect and analyze user data through systems of surveillance. On the other, there are users who, in order to inhabit the network, continuously expose themselves, producing and surrendering data.

In this sense, users can be understood as **digital prey**.

The term **clickbait** makes this dynamic explicit. The word “bait” refers directly to fishing: it is the hook designed to attract and capture. Just as fishermen choose bait according to the type of fish, digital content is tailored to specific audiences, using psychological and emotional triggers.

These triggers, such as anger, pity, amusement, indignation, or curiosity, are employed to **capture and maintain attention**. Algorithms analyze preferences, behaviors, and motivations in order to refine this process.

Moreover, as in fishing, the goal is not always immediate consumption. Sometimes the aim is to **keep the prey alive**, to maintain engagement over time. In the digital environment, this corresponds to the continuous stimulation of the user, preventing boredom and ensuring constant activity.

Thus, the network reveals a dual nature: it is both a **space of connection** and a **structure of capture**, intensifying the ambiguity already present in the human condition of thrownness.

8.4 Time, Space, and Identity in the Digital Condition

We can now clarify the specific form that **thrownness** assumes in the digital condition. Being online generates the perception of inhabiting a dimension that is not fully understandable nor entirely controllable: a fundamentally **opaque environment**, where it is difficult (if not impossible) to develop genuine familiarity.

For this reason, being online is not merely an **alternative** way of being-in-the-world, but an **alterative** one: it alters the very structure of our existence.

This transformation becomes evident if we consider how our experience of **time** and **space** has changed.

8.4.1 Fragmented Time

The digital society is characterized, first of all, by a progressive erosion of **duration**. Time no longer unfolds as a continuous horizon, but fragments into a succession of **isolated instants**, suspended in the present and disconnected from one another.

8.4.2 Flattened Space and Platform Logic

At the same time, we witness a transformation of space. What was once lived as **rootedness** (*radicamento*) becomes neutralized within the logic of the **platform**. Space loses its existential depth and significance, existing only insofar as it is **connected**.

The platform, in this sense, produces a **flattening** (*flat-form*). Everything that does not conform to this flat structure, everything that exceeds it or stands out, risks losing relevance. What exists, exists only insofar as it is present and visible within the network.

8.4.3 Fragmented Identities

Within this framework, the construction of virtual identities further transforms Dasein. The self becomes **fragmented** into multiple profiles, giving rise to increasingly **atomized and fluid identities**.

These identities are dispersed within digital swarms of **alter egos**, often deprived of stable reference points such as face, memory, name, origin, or direction.

Thus, the digital condition intensifies the experience of thrownness: not as a stable situatedness in a meaningful world, but as a **dispersion** within an unstable, fragmented, and constantly shifting horizon.

8.4.4 Acceleration and Dromocracy

Heidegger affirms that **possibility is higher than reality**. In the digital age, this statement appears almost prophetic.

Virtual reality presents itself as a space where human beings can explore **infinite possibilities of identity** without ever truly inhabiting any of them in a stable way. We can continuously switch from one profile to another, moving across different representations of ourselves.

In this context, the only temporal dimension that seems to survive is the **present**, reduced to a sequence of contingent instants. Time, emptied of duration, becomes a mere transition from one *now* to another *now*, without continuity.

Chronological time (*chronos*), once experienced as a flowing horizon, is replaced by a fragmented succession of disconnected moments. When time loses its narrative continuity, it becomes **disarticulated and atomized**.

In the intervals between these instants, where nothing happens, **boredom** emerges. As the philosopher **Byung-Chul Han** observes, our contemporary understanding of time generates the impulse to **eliminate or shorten empty intervals**. Perception must be constantly stimulated with new content.

This structure of time discourages any form of **contemplative lingering**. Instead of dwelling on what appears, we are driven toward constant movement and consumption.

In this sense, we are witnessing a shift from **democracy** (*demos* + *kratos*, the power of the people) to what can be called **dromocracy** (*dromos* + *kratos*), the power of **speed**. Acceleration becomes a strategy to overcome the limits of human life. The faster one lives, the more possibilities one seems able to realize. Infinite speed appears as a way to approach an unlimited horizon of possibilities.

8.4.5 Disorientation and the Loss of Authentic Relation

At the same time, technology seeks to eliminate **distance**. The internet dissolves geographical boundaries, producing a global, ubiquitous, and stateless individual, increasingly detached from any sense of **rootedness**.

The anxiety generated by this deterritorialized condition differs from Heidegger's **Angst**. For Heidegger, anguish arises from the awareness of finitude and can open the path to authenticity. In contemporary society, however, where discourse has degenerated into chatter and knowledge into curiosity, even **death** is symbolically removed.

Deprived of its existential weight, death no longer functions as an orientation toward an authentic life.

In this context, the technological prostheses we rely on and the virtual environments we inhabit prove insufficient to satisfy our fundamental need for **genuine relationships**.

Recognition, empathy, and meaningful dialogue, those forms of exchange that generate shared meaning, are increasingly replaced by mediated interactions within a digital environment that resembles a **panopticon**, where individuals are constantly monitored, exposed, and, at times, silenced.

Lecture of 14/04/2026

9.1 The Digital as an Alternative Culture

In the previous lecture, we began to understand that the network and its modes of operation are not merely **tools** or neutral containers in which we act. Just as being-in-the-world does not simply mean occupying a geographical space, being-in-the-web cannot be reduced to a simple technological shift.

The transformations introduced by the digital dimension cannot be interpreted as a mere change of medium. They deeply affect the way we experience **time and space**, our relation to **ourselves** (identity), and our relation to **others** (alterity).

These are not secondary aspects of human existence. On the contrary, they are fundamental structures that define what it means to be human, and therefore must be taken seriously in their transformation.

For this reason, the virtual sphere should not be seen only as an **alternative** reality, but as an **alterative** one: it modifies the very structure of existence. More precisely, it can be understood as the emergence of a new form of **culture**.

The term culture itself derives from *cult*. This etymology is significant, because it reveals that every cultural transformation also implies a transformation of **values, beliefs, and worldviews**.

In this sense, culture has a **religious root**, if we understand religion not in a strictly confessional sense, but as the capacity to **bind people together** through shared symbolic values.

The term *re-ligio* comes from *ligare*, meaning to **tie** or **connect**. Thus, culture, and even more so digital culture, can be interpreted as a system that connects individuals through shared practices, symbols, and meanings, shaping their way of inhabiting the world.

9.2 From Archetype to Stereotype: Three Models of Society

If we observe the history of our civilization from the perspective of **values**, we can broadly distinguish three different models of society.

The first is the society founded on the **archetype**. The term *arche* refers to a principle, an origin, a foundational source of order and law. In such a society, values are grounded in a **transcendent principle**, typically identified with God.

This principle governs the world and human life, and the fate of individuals depends on its **providence**, that is, on how this divine power dispenses its gifts. Human beings, in this context, await **salvation** from something external to themselves. They rely on the *arche*, which stands above them and must be worshipped and obeyed.

This model characterizes traditional societies, such as the medieval one, where existence is oriented toward a higher, divine order.

The second model is the society based on the **prototype**. To understand this shift, we can recall the famous statement written by **Friedrich Nietzsche** in 1882: “*Gott ist tot*” (God is dead).

This expression marks a radical transformation. Human beings no longer await salvation from divine providence, but begin to **provide for themselves** through technology. The source of fulfillment is no longer external, but internal to human action.

The term *prototype* is significant: *protos* means “first”. In the absence of God, human beings become the **first principle**, their own origin. They move from being creatures to becoming **creators**.

This transformation also changes the way we relate to the world. The contemplative and poetic gaze is replaced by a **technical and manipulative gaze**. Things are no longer primarily contemplated, but grasped and used as instruments.

In this context, limits themselves are transformed. If human beings must provide for themselves, then **rules and boundaries** are no longer given from above, but are self-imposed. There is no longer an external principle that defines what cannot be done.

Thus, a fundamental tension emerges: the distinction between what we **can** do technically and what we **should** do ethically. Without a transcendent limit, the dominant value becomes the **constant overcoming of limits**.

Limits are no longer accepted, but actively sought in order to be surpassed. This endless drive toward overcoming transforms ethics itself. Ethics, in this framework, risks becoming **pathetic** (from *pathos*, suffering): a field marked by tension and struggle, where human beings are burdened with the responsibility of defining their own limits without any external guidance.

The third model is that of societies founded on the **stereotype**. This is the model that

characterizes the contemporary digital world.

To understand this, we must first consider the etymology of the term. *Stereos* means **rigid**, while *typos* means **image**. A stereotype, therefore, is a **rigid image**.

In typography, a stereotype refers to a printing technique based on fixed and stable compositions that allow for the repeated reproduction of the same text. In psychology, instead, a stereotype is a **generalization** about a group, not grounded in direct experience, but derived from socially transmitted beliefs (what “is said” rather than what is lived).

This already recalls the language of **Das Man**, the dictatorship of mediality, where meanings circulate and impose themselves through repetition rather than through authentic understanding.

A stereotype can thus be defined as a process that reduces a **dynamic complexity** into **rigid and simplified images**. This operation is characteristic of the digital environment and produces ambivalent effects.

On the one hand, it allows for **simplification and acceleration**. On the other hand, it leads not to a deeper understanding of reality, but to its **banalization**.

In this sense, the stereotype becomes the typical form of thought within a society dominated by mediality. It is a form of thinking that does not derive its strength from truth or grounding, but from its **massive diffusion**.

Such thinking operates through already established forms: it repeats what has already been thought, making everything more easily **classifiable and categorizable**.

The network reinforces this mechanism by reducing everything it encounters into **data**. Reality is translated into a rigid, schematized form that can be processed, stored, and predicted.

Within the stereotype, we can recognize both:

- the way the network **knows us**, as sets of data among other sets of data
- the way we come to **know others**, through the same reductive structures.

In both cases, what is grasped is only the **average course of everydayness**, never the authentic singularity of existence.

Through the constant and uncritical repetition of what has already been said, stereotypes enable **prediction**. A thinking that merely reproduces the already-thought becomes **docile**: it no longer truly thinks.

In becoming predictable and anticipable, this form of thought finds its most fertile ground in the network.

Digital platforms, in order to host individuals, require them to translate their complex, mutable, and unstable existence into the **rigid form of a profile**. Everything that does not conform to this flattened structure becomes irrelevant.

To exist online thus means to **reform one's identity** according to standardized forms, conforming to the structure of other profiles.

In this way, the stereotype operates at a deep level: it transforms not only how we appear, but also how we relate to **ourselves**, to **others**, and ultimately how we conceive the very notions of **individual** and **community**.

9.3 From Community to Digital Swarms

Our understanding of **identity** and **alterity**, being intrinsically connected, cannot be treated separately. Moreover, they are deeply affected by the transformation of **time** and **space** produced by the digital environment.

In particular, what we traditionally call a **community** rests precisely on those elements that the network tends to erode: **duration** and **proximity**.

From this perspective, we can distinguish three different forms of human aggregation: **community**, **society**, and **mass**.

A **community** derives from *cum munia*, where *munia* refers to **gifts**. It is therefore based on the circulation of the gift and on the paradigm of **gratuity**.

Within a community, identity is formed through a sense of **belonging** and cohesion grounded in deep and enduring bonds: family, friendship, and care for those who are **near** to us. Proximity, both physical and existential, is essential.

A **society**, by contrast, is not primarily held together by gift and gratuity, but by **interest**. The center of gravity shifts from shared belonging to the **individual**, who pursues goals that require coordination with others.

Society is structured through **norms**, roles, and institutions such as work, business, and public life, and can function even in the absence of strong emotional or existential bonds. The third form is the **mass**. Here, the individual dissolves into **indistinction**. Identity is reduced to a number, and a large group acts as a single, undifferentiated entity.

Unlike the community, the mass lacks depth and continuity. It forms and dissolves rapidly, depending on contingent circumstances such as a concert, a protest, or a demonstration. Its strength lies in **physical presence**: in occupying space and imposing itself as a unified force. However, this unity is superficial, lacking the durable bonds and shared meaning that characterize a true community.

In this sense, the mass can be understood as a form of aggregation where what is **common** is reduced to mere coexistence, without the depth of shared existence.

Digital communities cannot be fully reduced to the traditional forms of aggregation such as community, society, or mass. Although they borrow the name, they are more accurately described as **digital swarms**.

Unlike communities, they do not rely on deep, meaningful bonds. Unlike societies, they are not sustained by stable shared interests. And unlike masses, they do not require phys-

ical co-presence. Instead, they are held together by **fragile and fleeting preferences**. Desires and preferences shape the digital environment, giving rise to the illusion that the world is constructed around our needs. Through constant interaction with devices, we may feel as if we are escaping **thrownness** (*Geworfenheit*), that condition of being placed in a world not of our choosing, by creating a space that appears entirely **available** to us.

To be online thus means attempting to eliminate **negativity**: opposition, resistance, limits, and unpredictability. These are precisely the elements that characterize real encounters with the world and with others.

This removal of negativity profoundly transforms our relation to **alterity**. The other is no longer encountered as a concrete, embodied presence, but as a **profile**, one among many within an indistinct multiplicity.

9.4 Alterity and the Disappearance of the Other

In their physical absence and virtual presence, what we encounter is not the other as such, but their **projection**. This form of alterity does not truly affect us, because distance protects us from being transformed.

Yet, what truly alters us is precisely what **touches** us. In real encounters, something in the other, both similar and different, penetrates our structure and transforms it. Contact, presence, corporeality, and proximity are therefore essential.

In digital connection, the presence of the other does not disappear, but is radically **transformed**. The other becomes disembodied, shielded by the screen, protected from the tension and opposition of real interaction.

When the other begins to challenge or unsettle us, when this process of transformation starts, we can simply **remove** them: blocking, deleting, archiving. In doing so, we preserve our identity as something **identical to itself**.

However, identity is not something given once and for all. It is continuously constructed through relations with others, not only through agreement, but also through **conflict and opposition**. It is through this dynamic that we generate **meaning** (*sensus*).

Online, only those who do not challenge us gain access to our **narcissistic bubble**. We remain protected from discomfort, from difference, and from transformation.

Thus, being on the net means being **shielded** from the other, their body, their gaze, and their capacity to affect us. We retain control over interaction: we can continue, interrupt, or silence communication at will.

Platforms themselves operate in the same way. When expressions are deemed to violate guidelines, users are **excluded** and reduced to silence, effectively erased from the digital sphere.

Yet, **resistance** is essential for growth. Just as muscles develop through opposition, so too do our ideas, beliefs, and identity. Without resistance, there is no development.

In the absence of opposition, what grows is not strength but **stagnation**. Muscles enable movement and transformation; fat, instead, represents the accumulation of the same.

Similarly, the ego, when deprived of the resistance offered by the other, expands by feeding on what is identical, preventing the emergence of the **new**.

The **flattening effect** produced by inhabiting the digital world transforms our relation to alterity. The other, who should be experienced as different and disruptive, is replaced by a reassuring **identity of sameness**.

In this proliferation of similarity, where conflict is removed, identities multiply in the rigid form of **profiles**. The other, in their true form, interrupts and challenges us, leaving a mark on our experience. The identical, instead, does not problematize us: it acts as a **mirror** that reflects us without generating any real reflection.

In the absence of genuine alterity, there are no true relationships, but only **impersonal connections**. One might expect that hiding behind a screen reduces conflict and discomfort. However, the opposite occurs. The need to **perform identity** online intensifies **commensurating comparison** and competition, driven by the dual forces of **envy** and **shame**.

At the same time, while we are encouraged to expose ourselves and become increasingly transparent, this exposure makes us vulnerable to phenomena such as **online hate**. This reaction often emerges from an ego that is silenced or denied expression, sometimes even by opaque algorithmic mechanisms.

Online, the distinction between **opinion** and **identity** collapses. Since there is no broader existential context to rely on, individuals cling rigidly to their opinions, defending them as if their very identity were at stake.

This leads to a fundamental degradation of **dialogue**. A true dialogue is not merely the exchange of statements, but is grounded in **listening**. Speaking and listening are inseparable. Even etymologically, this connection is evident: in German, *hören* (to hear) is related to *gehören* (to belong). Listening establishes a form of belonging.

When listening disappears, discourse degenerates into an **echo chamber**. With the exclusion of the other, what remains is a void in which our own voice returns unchanged and unchallenged.

9.5 Identity, Image, and the Condition of Homo Digitalis

The disappearance of physical presence fosters a compulsive online existence. Life is replicated through curated images, filters, and strategies aimed at provoking reactions,

whether positive or negative, as long as they generate **engagement**.

In this context, Heidegger's notion of **idle talk** finds its digital expression. It manifests in threads and viral discussions, where the quantitative accumulation of voices produces a **storm of information**. This noise suffocates the silent voice of **conscience**, which calls Dasein toward authenticity.

Authenticity begins to emerge when we stop seeking others as identical reflections of ourselves. Only then can we encounter the other as **equal** rather than identical.

To be identical means to erase difference. To be equal means to recognize the other in their **difference**. Authentic existence implies that no one else can be identical to me, and precisely from this irreducible uniqueness arises the possibility of understanding the other as an equal.

Within the **absence of distance** promoted by virtual reality, an important distinction must be clarified: the absence of distance does not mean **closeness** or **proximity**. The removal of distance does not bring us nearer to others; it simply eliminates the space that separates us, without generating a genuine relation.

In this condition, the effects of **media hyper-exposure** emerge. Life, when reduced to performance, produces a growing sense of **inadequacy** and **shame** when we compare our imperfect and unpolished existence to the curated images of others, such as influencers, whether real or artificially constructed.

This phenomenon can be described through the notion of **Promethean shame**: a feeling of inferiority that human beings experience in relation to their own creations. We produce perfect objects, images, and representations, yet we perceive ourselves as flawed in comparison to them.

In this framework, the other is no longer encountered as a subject, but as a **source of silent gratification**, expressed through likes and numerical approval. Relationships become **depersonalized** and **asymmetrical**. Following someone does not imply reciprocity; there is no mutual listening, no shared exchange, and therefore no genuine **belonging**.

Communication becomes **unidirectional**: content is produced by a few and consumed by many. Those who consume disappear into an anonymous and faceless public, expressing themselves only through **mute approval**.

These empty forms of relation give rise to what can be called the condition of the **Homo digitalis**, who inhabits an environment increasingly characterized by **solitude** and **insubstantiality**, a kind of social and spiritual desert.

The progressive **expulsion of the other** from our existential horizon generates forms of **asociality**. These, in turn, often manifest as identity-based reactions, which can become both **destructive** and **self-destructive**. Such dynamics threaten the possibility of reconstructing authentic communal bonds, those grounded in justice, cooperation, and shared meaning, rather than mere interest or competition.

In this context, comparison with others, distant, filtered, and altered, drives us to constantly **measure ourselves** against them, intervening not on our real existence, but on the **image** we choose to expose.

Let us reflect more deeply on the notion of **image** in the digital age. We can observe that digital pictures are no longer **portraits**, but **products**. Digital photography does not simply capture reality; it allows us to **produce** and construct our image through filters, editing, and manipulation.

Through this process, we generate a **hyper-real image** of ourselves, one that exceeds and detaches from actual reality. While this manipulation may appear to expand our possibilities and thus increase our **freedom**, it simultaneously leads to the progressive elimination of the **real reference**.

This dynamic is particularly evident in the phenomenon of the **selfie**, where the subject who is photographed coincides with the photographer. This fusion between the represented self and the representing self intensifies the **detachment** between the individual and their digital profile, producing an increasingly **inauthentic** and **distorted** relation both with oneself and with others.

The term **retractus** (“ritratto”) is especially meaningful here. It refers not only to a portrait, but also to something that is **withdrawn**, secluded, held back. Traditionally, creating one’s image required a process of **withdrawal** from the gaze of others, an inward movement of reflection. In contrast, digital images are primarily oriented **toward others**, produced for exposure and recognition.

From this perspective, digital networks lack the traditional **amphitheatrical structure** of mass media. In conventional media such as television or radio, attention is directed toward shared issues of **public relevance**, creating a common horizon.

Digital media, instead, operate through **centrifugal forces**. The individual spectator becomes the center, directing attention exclusively toward what aligns with personal interests. As a result, the **public sphere fragments** into volatile and unstable swarms, driven by preference rather than shared concern.

Instead of convergence around common issues, digital environments promote **divergence**. This divergence manifests as **distraction** (*distrazione*) and **diversion** (*divertimento*), leading attention away from depth and continuity.

In this context, it is not surprising that our era is often described as the age of **infotainment**, a hybrid of information and entertainment. However, this fusion rarely achieves either true understanding or genuine enjoyment. Instead, it produces a **blurred, superficial, and alienating experience**, where meaning is diluted and attention is constantly dispersed.

10

Lecture of 20/04/2026

10.1 Umgang and the Primacy of Meaningful Interaction

In the previous lectures, we have introduced the concept of **Umgang**, developed by Heidegger. This term, often translated as “commerce”, more properly refers to the **exchange of meaning** that occurs between Dasein and others, and between Dasein and entities, that is, the things and tools that surround it.

This exchange does not take place on a purely **cognitive** level, nor does it arise from scientific knowledge. Our relation to the world is not primarily based on calculation or measurement, but on a process of **familiarization** that develops through continuous interaction.

Through contact with things and with others, our experience of the world is structured. The self is not fixed, but **variable**: it constitutes its identity through **alteration**, that is, through the encounter with what is radically other.

It is precisely this encounter with alterity, which is something different that affects and transforms us, that gives rise to **wonder** and **disorientation**. These experiences leave a trace, contributing to the formation of our identity and uniqueness.

To experience the world therefore means to expose ourselves to the **oppositional character** of reality. Unlike other living beings, which adapt themselves to the environment, human beings respond by **adapting the environment to themselves**. This marks the passage from **Welt** to **Umwelt**, where the world is shaped according to human projects through technology.

This dynamic is reflected in the German term “**zu nehmen**” (to take), which is etymologically connected to “**Name**”. Taking and naming share the intention of **appropriating** something in order to render it usable.

However, the totality of reality, which would otherwise appear overwhelming and generate a sense of **panic** (from *pan*, meaning totality), is fragmented into **names** and **things**. By doing so, we make reality manageable and intelligible.

10.2 Technocapitalism and the Logic of Performance

Technology, understood as the mode of ordering the world into rational and functional structures (**Gestell**) and rendering entities constantly available (**Bestand**), reaches in the digital age its **maximum expansion and fulfillment**.

Within this system, often described as **technocapitalism**, we witness a final fusion of **technology**, **economy**, and **science**, each reinforcing and presupposing the other.

Science produces knowledge in order to generate **data** for technology and **quantifiable measures** for the economy. The economy, in turn, invests in the directions indicated by science in order to further develop and refine technology. Technology, finally, operates according to its own internal paradigm, governed by a fundamental law: **self-implementation**.

This law implies that technology follows a strictly **performative logic**, aiming primarily at the **increase of efficiency**. Efficiency is pursued through the progressive elimination of everything that is **dysfunctional**, that is, anything that slows down or interferes with performance. Error, doubt, hesitation, ethical limits, emotions, and digressions, elements that are constitutively human, are thus marginalized or removed.

Alongside efficiency, technology also pursues the **increase of speed**. Acceleration prevents reflection, eliminating the time necessary to reconsider and reinterpret experience. Human existence is thus pushed toward a condition of **optimization**, lived at an ever-increasing pace.

In this process, **velocity** turns into **voracity**: time itself becomes a consumable resource, treated like any other commodity. This transformation undermines systems such as **democracy** and **juridical processes**, which depend on slow thinking, deliberation, and dialogue, and subjects them instead to the accelerated logic of **dromocracy**.

10.3 Information, Transparency, and the Crisis of Truth

Technology also aims to eliminate **waiting** and so-called empty time, as well as to abolish **distance**, making everything immediately available and accessible. In this sense, Heidegger's notions of **Zuhandenheit** and **Vorhandenheit** find their full realization.

Our digital **Bestand** (social networks, marketplaces, forums) becomes a vast repository where both people and things lose their **corporeal presence** and are transformed into **data profiles**, arranged within the digital **Gestell**.

In this framework, the other exists only insofar as they **show themselves**. Accessing a profile does not mean encountering the other in their full existential depth, but only engaging with a **partial and mediated representation**.

To complete this picture, alongside efficiency, speed, and availability, technology also pursues **transparency**. In the contemporary **stereotypical society** (from *stereos*, rigid,

and *typos*, form), every element must be translated into **information** in order to be readable by machines.

However, **information** lacks the depth and weight of **narrative**. It flows rapidly, one piece after another, oriented toward novelty and immediacy. Information accumulates without generating a coherent meaning or allowing time for reflection.

Narrative, by contrast, weaves together multiple voices, constructing **sense** and **temporality**. Information, instead, produces a continuous bombardment that dissolves into an indistinct background noise, the so-called **infonoise**.

This overabundance of information does not lead to greater awareness or wisdom. Rather, it results in **dispersion**, fragmenting our attention and dispersing us across an indefinite multiplicity of possibilities.

In a society where everything must be reduced to **information**, truth tends to coincide with **transparency**. Yet, as we have seen, truth does not manifest itself as total exposure. Like the figure of **Veritas**, truth appears through a dynamic movement of **unveiling and revealing**, but also of **withdrawal and concealment**.

Truth is not fully illuminated presence; it often withdraws into the shadowy space of the **Lichtung** (clearing), or hides in depth, calling us to a movement of **search** and **transformation**. It emerges within a tension between light and darkness, appearing and disappearing. For this reason, truth cannot be reduced to **total illumination**, which risks producing not clarity but **blindness** through excess.

10.4 Digital Identity and the Commodification of the Self

This form of blindness is precisely what characterizes **transparency**. Etymologically, transparency comes from *trans-spicere*, meaning “to see through”. It implies the absence of visible boundaries between inside and outside. However, this condition does not truly eliminate boundaries; rather, it transforms the relation of the **observer**, who assumes full visibility as a norm.

In the digital environment, existence is no longer sufficient in itself. Unlike being in the world, where we are already exposed to others, to exist online requires **self-exposure**. One must **appear**, and more precisely, must become **showy** (*appariscente*).

Thus, we move from the simple **appearance** of the self to its **exhibition**. The digital self becomes a **performance**, a constructed image shaped through filters, editing, and aesthetic strategies. In this sense, we produce **counterfeit versions** of ourselves, transforming identity into a **commodity**, displayed like goods on a shelf.

Interestingly, contemporary digital culture no longer privileges only flawless and idealized images. Instead, it increasingly rewards forms of **simulated authenticity**, which

generate empathy and engagement. However, this authenticity is often **strategic** and guided by commercial logic, and therefore remains fundamentally inauthentic.

Within this framework, several phenomena emerge. Practices such as **sharenting**, where children become the content of parental profiles, transform personal life into a form of **mass consumption**, raising significant ethical and legal concerns.

Similarly, forms of **compassion capitalism** (or “charity porn”) commodify vulnerability, turning suffering into entertainment and profit. Even more extreme is **pain capitalism**, where suffering is normalized and publicly exposed, often without regard for dignity.

These dynamics raise fundamental questions about **care** (*Nachsicht* and *Rücksicht*). What happens to the dignity of the individual when their vulnerability becomes content? What remains of authentic care for others?

Moreover, identity itself tends to become **radicalized** within profiles. Communities centered around illness, grief, or personal struggle may provide recognition and validation, but often without enabling genuine transformation. Instead, suffering risks becoming a source of **attention, approval**, and even **profit**.

In this context, it is important to distinguish between **visibility** and **recognition**. Having many views does not mean being truly seen. To **see the other** is fundamentally different from consuming their content.

Finally, the digital condition dissolves any shared temporal or symbolic horizon. There is no longer a common reference that structures experience. Instead, reality fragments into **self-constructed bubbles**, increasingly closed and impermeable, where each individual inhabits a personalized and isolated world.

A phenomenological observation of the digital age reveals a transformation in the very notion of **performance**. On the one hand, content is consumed with extreme rapidity, almost **frantically**, as in platforms such as TikTok. On the other hand, performance increasingly consists in the mere act of **showing oneself**, even silently, maintaining a constant yet minimal interaction with users over time.

This results in a paradoxical condition: being simultaneously **alone** and **with others**, yet not fully belonging to either state. It produces a form of **hyper-invaded solitude** or, conversely, an **hyper-isolated multitude**, where digital swarms continuously form and dissolve without rooting themselves in shared meanings or ideologies.

Unlike traditional masses, which even within the anonymity described by the dictatorship of **Das Man** still revolved around some form of **ideology**, digital masses lack any common horizon. The only remaining “ideology” is that of **individual desire**, expressed through preferences, consumption, and immediate satisfaction.

Moreover, while pre-digital masses manifested themselves through the physical **presence of bodies**, the digital mass is characterized by anonymity without corporeality, combining dispersion with the absence of shared purpose.

10.5 From Possession to Access: The Transformation of Our Relation to Things

This transformation does not concern only our relation to others, but also our relation to **things**. The Heideggerian concept of **Umgang**, the ongoing exchange with the world, extends to objects as well.

Today, instead of **possessing** things, we increasingly seek **experiences**. Ownership is replaced by **access**: we want to use things without establishing lasting bonds with them. This logic extends beyond objects to relationships themselves.

Possession implies **stability** and an intense relation that confers value. Objects, in this sense, act as **anchors** connecting us to our past and to those who came before us. Their value is often symbolic and inestimable, independent of their market price.

However, digital platforms and the logic of the **sharing economy** undermine this bond. Practices such as reselling (e.g., through platforms like Vinted) encourage us to **detach** from objects and, with them, from memory itself.

The Latin term *recordari* (to remember) literally means “to bring back together”, to re-establish a bond with the past. Yet, in a system oriented toward constant novelty, the past is something to be **discarded** in favor of ever-new experiences.

For the market to function efficiently, it must eliminate what is **dysfunctional**, including emotions that bind us to objects and distinguish **value** from **price**. Thus, the symbolic and personal value of things is flattened into an **exchange value** identical for all.

Possession also involves **use** and **contact**. The hand of the owner, through handling and interaction, confers uniqueness to the object, making it **irreplaceable**.

In the absence of **tactile contact**, however, no real bonds are formed. What remains are only **connections**, deprived of the corporeal and sensory dimension that is constitutive of authentic relationships.

Without this embodied interaction, both our relation to things and to others becomes increasingly **superficial**, transient, and interchangeable.

10.6 Digital Objects and the Loss of World

Let us reflect on a fundamental transformation: while **industrial capitalism**, characteristic of the society of prototypes, transformed **matter** into commodities, **technocapitalism**, typical of the society of stereotypes, transforms the **immaterial** into commodities. We thus move from the commercialization of material goods to the commodification of **data, images, identities, and experiences**.

In this process, the distinction between **culture** (as *cultus*, that which binds people through shared values) and the **market** becomes increasingly blurred. Communities dis-

solve into multiple **virtual communities**, which, once turned into commodities themselves, lose their authentic nature.

The world, traditionally, is constituted by **objects**. The term “object” derives from *ob-iacere*, meaning something that **stands against**, an obstacle that resists us. Objects, in their original sense, possess a dimension of **negativity**: they oppose resistance and confront us.

Digital objects, however, lack this negativity. They do not resist. The smooth surfaces of screens and devices create a world characterized by **polished immediacy** and the absence of friction. Everything becomes instantly available, ready to hand, with minimal effort.

This absence of resistance within our technical **Umwelt** produces a **deficiency of world**. Authentic experience is impoverished, as reality is increasingly accessed through screens that function as **windows**. Yet, these are not windows onto reality itself, but onto its **mediated projection**.

In this condition, physical contact with reality disappears. The world is stripped of its **corporeal dimension**: it is no longer grasped by human senses, but by **machinic sensors**. However, as Heidegger emphasizes, the human relation to things is not secondary but an **existential structure** essential for the formation of identity.

Consider the experience of a **child**. Objects play a fundamental role as **bridges** between the self and the environment. Through tactile interaction, children establish deep and irreplaceable bonds with things, such as a beloved toy. These are known as **transitional objects**, which provide comfort and enable the development of imagination and relationality.

Such objects are soft, manipulable, and invite exploration. They allow the child to encounter both **self** and **other**. In contrast, digital devices function as **narcissistic objects**. They are smooth, hard, and cold, discouraging manipulation and tactile engagement.

While transitional objects **stabilize** the child’s experience of reality and foster imagination, smartphones tend to **saturate** imagination with continuous stimuli. This constant influx fragments attention and destabilizes the mind.

Moreover, interaction with devices is typically **repetitive** and non-creative, based on simple gestures such as tapping. This reduces the need for manual creativity and limits the development of meaningful engagement with the world.

Through these narcissistic objects, the individual increasingly perceives only **themselves**, excluding the other. The subject withdraws into digital **bubbles**, shielded from alterity and protected from unpredictability.

We can thus observe a further transformation of Heidegger’s categories. Beyond **Zuhandenheit** (ready-to-hand) and **Vorhandenheit** (present-at-hand), digital experience introduces forms such as **“Zufingerheit”** and **“Vorfingerheit”**, a reality that is no longer

within reach of the hand, but merely **within reach of the finger**.

In this process, we lose not only three of our five senses, but also the **full use of our hands**, reducing our interaction with the world to minimal, fragmented gestures.

11

Lecture of 21/04/2026

11.1 Digital Life as Performance

The advent of the internet has undoubtedly made it easier to **connect**, share content, find inspiration, and stay informed. However, the intensification of participation in the digital world has led to profound **anthropological transformations**.

Recent studies increasingly highlight a correlation between extensive use of social media and the emergence of **cognitive, mental, behavioral, and emotional disorders**, including eating disorders and suicidal tendencies, which were previously less widespread. A decisive turning point can be identified during the **pandemic**. The conditions of lockdown and social isolation led many individuals to increasingly **share and display their lives online**, blurring the boundaries between **private and public, personal and professional**, and **real and digital identity**.

Deprived of one of the defining structures of human existence (**being-with-others**) individuals experienced a void generated by the absence of physical presence. In response, digital networks were adopted as a form of **survival tool**, compensating for the lack of contact.

This shift, however, transformed life itself into a **performance**. What we present online is not life as it is lived, but a **representation** of it. The term “representation” recalls the **theatrical dimension**, where living is replaced by staging.

Individuals become at once **directors, actors, and producers** of their own existence, constructing roles rather than simply inhabiting them. Removed from the direct gaze of others, they gain control over what to **show** and what to **conceal**, deliberately shaping their digital identity.

Within the confined space of profiles, individuals adapt to the **rules of platforms**, which encourage exposure of increasingly **intimate aspects** of life in exchange for approval, measured in likes and views.

As a result, even experiences such as **suffering, pain, and grief** are transformed into **content**, shared with vast audiences of strangers. Yet these expressions are reduced to **fragments**, dispersed within the continuous global stream of information.

At the same time, a growing **emotional distance** emerges. Relationships based on **connection without contact** prevent us from grasping the real weight and depth of the experiences we observe.

Paradoxically, the more stories are shared online, the less genuine **participation** they evoke. What begins as **empathy** gradually shifts toward **indifference**, as repetition and overexposure dull our capacity to be affected by the suffering of others.

11.2 Attention, Recognition, and Self-Commodification

Our **need for recognition** and our **fragility**, in order to exist within the digital environment, must be transformed into **content**, and therefore into something **commodifiable**. This transformation reflects the fundamental logic of **capitalism**, which operates by converting every aspect of existence into **merchandise**.

With the expansion of capitalism into the digital sphere, this logic has intensified. Vulnerable individuals, such as **children**, the **sick**, the **disabled**, and those in conditions of psychological or economic fragility, are increasingly exposed and transformed into content for mass consumption. This process is often exacerbated by a **regulatory vacuum**, allowing unethical practices and forms of **cybercrime** to emerge.

It is undeniable that digital platforms have revolutionized communication, breaking down geographical and cultural barriers and giving voice to those previously unheard. They have facilitated the emergence of **social movements**, enabled minority representation, and fostered networks of **solidarity** that extend beyond physical boundaries.

However, as phenomenology teaches, every phenomenon has a hidden side. Alongside these benefits, there exists a less visible dimension characterized by **emotional manipulation**, **social pressure**, and **competitive dynamics** that platforms amplify.

Social networks are not neutral tools. They are designed to **capture attention** and retain it for as long as possible, in order to deliver **targeted content**. The very term “target” reveals a **strategic and bellic logic**, where users become objects of calculated engagement.

Within these **digital bubbles**, individuals are shielded from genuine **alterity**, that form of otherness capable of transforming us. As a result, we progressively lose our **critical**, **dialogical**, and **dialectical** capacities.

Thinking becomes **polarized** and identity increasingly **radicalized**, feeding a culture centered on **appearance** and the pursuit of **consensus**, rather than on the search for **sensus** (meaning).

This shift has deep roots. The individualism that characterizes digital culture is not accidental, but reflects an economic and cultural paradigm that predates it. Contemporary society places emphasis on **merit**, **performance**, and **individual achievement**, while values such as **solidarity**, **collaboration**, and **care** are marginalized.

The prevailing narrative suggests that success depends solely on **individual effort**, ignoring the broader social conditions that shape opportunities. This myth of **self-sufficiency** and **meritocracy** compels individuals to become **interpreters of themselves**.

In the digital environment, this results in the construction of curated identities designed to attract attention and approval. Individuals transform themselves into **products**, displayed and marketed in a continuous state of **competition** with others.

11.3 Techno-Capitalism and the Personal Brand

At this stage, **capitalism** reaches a new and radical configuration. Traditionally, the system was structured around a **dialectic between master and slave**, where the dominated subject sought emancipation. In **techno-capitalism**, however, this distinction collapses: the individual becomes simultaneously **master and slave**, both **employer and worker of oneself**.

The mechanisms of exploitation do not disappear, but are redirected inward. Exploitation becomes **self-exploitation**, disguised as **freedom**, **aspiration**, and **personal ambition**. Individuals willingly participate in their own commodification.

Within this framework, we construct **personal narratives** designed to attract the attention of a specific audience, such as friends, followers, or strangers. To be visible online, one must be **transparent**, exposing oneself in ways that allow classification, recognition, and categorization.

Thus, individuals are encouraged to develop a coherent and identifiable **personal brand**. Identity is transformed into a **product**, consumed rapidly within the flow of digital content. Metrics such as **likes**, **comments**, and **shares** become units of value in an **attention economy**, where identity is continuously negotiated.

What matters is no longer who we are in essence, but **how we are perceived**. Value shifts from the intrinsic to the **performative**: existence becomes dependent on visibility.

11.4 From Social Feedback to Algorithmic Visibility

The origins of this dynamic can be traced back to early experiments in social platforms. In 2003, Mark Zuckerberg created a site known as “**Hot or Not**”, where users could compare images and rate attractiveness. This project, based on the unauthorized use of personal data, revealed both the **potential of social engineering** and the willingness of individuals to expose themselves in exchange for recognition.

The rapid success of such systems demonstrated a fundamental human vulnerability: the desire to be **seen**, **evaluated**, and **approved**. Social platforms exploited this need by introducing mechanisms of **instant feedback**, such as notifications and reactions.

These mechanisms operate through cycles of **intermittent reward**, similar to behavioral

experiments. The unpredictability of receiving likes or comments increases engagement, triggering the release of **dopamine** and reinforcing repetitive behavior.

Over time, users learn which types of content maximize visibility and approval, adapting their behavior accordingly. In doing so, they generate vast amounts of **data**.

This data becomes the foundation of a new economic model: rather than selling products directly, large technological companies collect and analyze user data in order to sell it to **advertisers**.

Users, through their activity, effectively **train** the platforms, enabling them to refine targeting strategies and optimize engagement. In this system, the user is no longer the customer, but the **product** itself.

The development of digital platforms reaches a further stage with the acquisition of Instagram, where the logic of surveillance and data extraction becomes even more refined. A crucial transformation concerns the very **form of communication**: while earlier platforms such as Facebook combined **text and images**, Instagram marks the transition toward a predominantly **visual culture**.

In this environment, visibility becomes the central resource. Brands quickly recognize the opportunity to exploit highly followed individuals in order to **shape collective desires**. At the same time, the digital space allows the emergence of new figures, the **influencers**, who build audiences and establish direct relationships with followers.

Success within this system requires a double movement. On the one hand, individuals must **adapt to market standards**, aligning their content with the expectations of brands and platforms. On the other hand, they must appear **authentic**, spontaneous, and genuinely engaged with their audience. This produces a paradoxical condition in which authenticity itself becomes **strategically constructed**.

What is consumed, therefore, is not merely the advertised product, but primarily the **influencer as a persona**. If in the past brands attempted to humanize themselves, now it is individuals who **transform themselves into brands**. Advertising is no longer presented explicitly, but is embedded within everyday narratives through **storytelling** and **product placement**, creating a blurred boundary between communication and commercialization.

A further decisive shift occurs with the introduction of **algorithmic feeds**. Content is no longer displayed chronologically, but reorganized according to personalized algorithms. While presented as an improvement of user experience, this system primarily serves to **maximize engagement time**, thereby increasing exposure to advertisements.

In this sense, algorithms are not neutral or democratic. They reinforce existing **power structures** through several mechanisms:

1. **Socio-economic privilege**: those who succeed often possess the resources (time, capital, skills) necessary to invest in their online presence.

2. **Stereotypical amplification:** visibility is granted preferentially to content that aligns with pre-existing social patterns and expectations.
3. **Behavioral internalization:** creators adapt themselves to algorithmic logic, shaping their identity and content to maximize virality.

11.5 Fake Authenticity and the Serialization of Feelings

With the rise of platforms such as TikTok, a further transformation takes place. Content production becomes **faster**, more **informal**, and widely accessible. The polished aesthetic of earlier platforms gives way to seemingly spontaneous and everyday representations.

However, this apparent spontaneity is itself a form of “**fake authenticity**”. It responds to a market demand that no longer seeks idealized perfection, but rather **relatability**. Users do not want to be inspired by distant perfection, but to recognize themselves in what they see.

As a result, visibility is achieved not only through refined and curated images, but also through **raw**, **imperfect**, and even **extreme or desperate** content. Authenticity, once again, is not recovered, but **reconfigured as a new aesthetic and economic strategy**. The pandemic marks a decisive turning point, opening the way to a new aesthetic paradigm that can be defined as **artificial simplicity in continuous scrolling**. Platforms such as TikTok foster a rapid, fragmented, and often disorienting experience, where content is consumed in an uninterrupted flow.

The aim of this system is not merely to **understand users’ preferences**, but to actively **shape their interests**, constructing highly detailed behavioral profiles. Content selection is optimized to maximize engagement, even at the cost of amplifying **negative emotions** such as anxiety, fear, or sadness, whenever these increase interaction.

This raises a fundamental question: *what remains authentic when complexity and intimate emotions, such as pain or grief, are reduced to short, standardized videos?* When emotions become **replicable** and **serial**, identical to millions of others, they lose their original intensity and depth.

The process at work is a **serialization and stereotypification of feelings**. Emotions are no longer lived as singular and meaningful experiences, but are reformatted into consumable units. This transformation has profound consequences:

- For the **individual**, it produces a distancing from one’s own inner life, reducing experience to performance.

- For the **social dimension**, it weakens the possibility of genuine participation and shared meaning.

Within this economy of attention, platforms tend to reward the most **extreme**, **shocking**, or **emotionally manipulative** content. Users are pushed to expose even the most intimate aspects of their existence, like suffering, grief, and even joy, stripped of their depth and reconfigured for rapid consumption.

Thus, reality itself is transformed into a **spectacle**. What is required is no longer ethical or emotional participation, but merely **attention**. This shift is crucial: it replaces involvement with passive consumption.

As a consequence, individuals are deprived of the possibility of constructing **meaningful narratives**, and with them, of establishing **authentic relationships**. Experience is fragmented, and connection becomes superficial.

11.6 Anomic Digital Space and New Forms of Exploitation

In this context, the digital environment takes on the characteristics of an **anomic space**. The term “anomy” (from the Greek *a-nomos*, without law) indicates a condition in which shared norms and protections are absent or insufficient.

Online existence, therefore, unfolds within a space that is only partially regulated, where significant forms of interaction and exposure occur without adequate ethical, legal, or social frameworks to guide and protect them.

Let us now consider three emblematic phenomena that concretely illustrate the dynamics analyzed so far: **sharenting**, **compassion capitalism**, and **pain capitalism**.

11.7 Sharenting

The first phenomenon, **sharenting** (from “share” and “parenting”), consists in the systematic **exposure of children**, often minors, on digital platforms, making them the central subjects of online content.

Initially perceived as harmless or even positive, this practice has revealed serious and concrete risks. A first critical issue concerns the **manipulation and misuse of children’s images**, which may be altered and circulated within illicit networks, including those related to child exploitation.

Even more troubling is the behavioral dynamic induced by algorithmic logic. When parents observe that certain types of content, such as videos of children eating or bathing, generate higher engagement, they are incentivized to **reproduce and intensify** this

content. In doing so, they may unknowingly expose their children to significant risks, subordinating their well-being to the demands of visibility and monetization.

At the same time, sharenting is also rooted in a broader social context. The sense of **isolation, inadequacy, and anxiety** often experienced during parenthood (especially motherhood) finds expression online. Social media appears to offer a space of sharing and recognition, compensating for the lack of strong social support systems in increasingly individualistic societies.

However, this apparent community reveals itself as a **system of capture**, governed by the impersonal logic of the market. What begins as a search for connection is gradually absorbed into an economic mechanism that transforms visibility into value.

In this context, a profound transformation occurs: **childhood itself becomes commodified**. While modern welfare systems sought to protect children from labor and guarantee their right to education and play, digital capitalism reintroduces a new form of exploitation. Childhood is turned into a **continuous performance**, a permanent reality show.

Children featured in such content may be required to repeat scenes multiple times, follow scripts, and dedicate time and energy that should instead be reserved for play, growth, and learning. Their activity becomes, de facto, a form of **labor**, driven by parental ambition and algorithmic incentives.

Finally, this phenomenon raises a crucial issue concerning identity. These children will grow up with a **digital double**, a publicly accessible identity constructed without their consent. This leads to what can be defined as **secondary contentification**: once content is uploaded, it becomes almost impossible to control its circulation.

Thus, sharenting not only exposes children in the present, but also projects long-term consequences into their future, questioning the very boundaries between care, exploitation, and identity in the digital age.

11.8 Compassion Capitalism

The second phenomenon is **compassion capitalism**. It emerges from the broader trend of the **spectacularization of pain** on social media, where suffering becomes a central element of viral content.

In this context, individuals affected by **illness, disability, poverty, or abuse** are exposed online and transformed into consumable content. Often, these subjects are unable to give informed consent, or are filmed without full awareness, treated as **objects** at the disposal of those who seek to monetize their vulnerability.

A particularly significant manifestation of this dynamic is the proliferation of so-called **misery shows**, where individuals from disadvantaged backgrounds receive gifts or financial aid in exchange for narrating their personal tragedies. While these acts may

appear charitable, they convey a deeper ideological message: that **consumer goods** and monetary interventions are sufficient to resolve complex human problems.

Thus, beyond entertainment, media contributes to shaping a cultural belief in the **redemptive power of consumerism**. Since the 1990s, a hybrid format has developed, combining elements of talk shows, crime reporting, and entertainment. This format trains audiences to consume narratives of suffering enriched with **voyeuristic details**, fostering a form of emotional engagement that is superficial yet addictive.

Voyeurism, in this sense, establishes a **power dynamic** between observer and observed. Access to the intimate lives of others becomes a form of **control**, where visibility implies exposure and vulnerability.

Contemporary digital practices further intensify this logic. For example, extended streaming sessions (such as *subathons*) encourage creators to remain online for prolonged periods in exchange for subscriptions, effectively transforming endurance and self-exposure into economic strategies. In some cases, users even pay to witness acts of **humiliation** or **self-imposed strain**, reinforcing the commodification of the body and dignity.

Even seemingly positive figures, such as philanthropic content creators, participate in this system. Their acts of generosity, while materially beneficial, are often structured to maximize **visibility, engagement, and profit**. The primary focus shifts from helping others to **showcasing the act of helping**.

For this reason, such practices cannot be considered genuinely altruistic. Authentic generosity presupposes **disinterestedness** and **gratuitousness**, whereas in compassion capitalism, these acts are embedded within a logic of **self-promotion** and **economic return**.

Ultimately, compassion capitalism transforms suffering into spectacle and care into strategy, raising fundamental ethical questions about dignity, agency, and the meaning of solidarity in the digital age.

11.9 Pain Capitalism

The third phenomenon is **pain (or suffering) capitalism**. Like the previous ones, it intensified during the pandemic, when social media initially functioned as a space to **cope with isolation** and to **share difficult experiences** beyond forced solitude.

At first, the exposure of pain, illness, grief, loss, could be interpreted as a form of **collective ritual**, a spontaneous attempt to process suffering through sharing. What may appear grotesque from the outside can, for participants, represent a search for **recognition** and **connection**.

However, as these practices evolved, a significant shift occurred: the **narration of suffering itself** became the **justification for online presence**. Profiles increasingly center their identity on pain, even continuing after the original event (such as the loss of a

loved one), presenting this choice as an effort to **normalize grief** and offer a supposedly **pedagogical experience** to followers.

This dynamic raises important concerns. Although framed as sharing and awareness, these narratives remain **isolated and competitive**, rather than forming genuine communities. Each story competes for visibility within the same attention economy, preventing the emergence of a truly shared space of care and support.

Moreover, the digital environment introduces a further transformation: **support itself becomes commodified**. Platforms offering emotional assistance, listening, or guidance increasingly operate through **paid services**. What was once a spontaneous act of **solidarity** is reconfigured as a **market transaction**.

This reflects a broader tendency of **techno-capitalism**: the transformation of the **immaterial**, such as care, empathy, hospitality, and listening, into **commodities**. Even the most intimate dimensions of human existence become objects of exchange.

Thus, while sharing painful experiences can indeed foster networks of support, the structural logic of platforms risks transforming suffering into a **resource**. Pain becomes part of a continuous flow of **entertainment, visibility, and recognition**, often temporary and unstable.

In this system, individuals may become dependent on the **ephemeral validation** derived from exposing their emotions, reinforcing cycles of visibility rather than enabling genuine healing or understanding.

Ultimately, pain capitalism reveals a paradox: the attempt to share and alleviate suffering risks reproducing and amplifying it, as it becomes integrated into the mechanisms of exposure, competition, and profit that define the digital environment.

12

Lecture of 27/04/2026

12.1 Logos and Forms of Intelligence

In this lecture, we extend Heidegger's analysis of existence to the digital age by focusing on another fundamental existential dimension: **logos**.

As we have already seen, **logos** is not limited to "language" in a narrow sense. It encompasses a wide semantic field: **word**, **discourse**, **dialogue**, **reason**, **opinion**, and more broadly the way meaning is articulated and shared.

To properly understand how logos is transformed in the digital context, we must first introduce a preliminary distinction between three forms of intelligence:

NI (Natural Intelligence) AI (Artificial Intelligence) HI (Human Intelligence)

Natural Intelligence (NI) is governed by **biological programs**. These are fixed, stable, and oriented toward fundamental functions such as **survival** and **reproduction**. Their logic is rigid and does not allow for genuine transformation.

Artificial Intelligence (AI), by contrast, operates through **mechanical programs**. Like biological programs, they are structured and predefined, but they are **detached from the sphere of life**. Machines do not possess an understanding of life or death; they can only **simulate** or **mimic** intelligent behavior.

Human Intelligence (HI) differs radically from both. It is not governed by fixed programs, but by **projects**. As we have seen, a project is oriented toward a goal, yet the path to reach it is **open**, **variable**, and **adaptable**. Human intelligence is therefore characterized by **flexibility**, **interpretation**, and **situated decision-making**.

From this perspective, we can identify two fundamental intersections:

- With **natural intelligence**, human beings share the **biological dimension** of life.
- With **artificial intelligence**, human beings share the capacity for **language** (logos).

It is precisely within this shared domain of **logos** that a crucial question emerges: if machines increasingly operate through language, *what remains specific to human discourse?* This question will guide the analysis of how language, meaning, and communication are transformed in the digital age.

12.2 Language, Ambiguity and Interpretation

Language presents a fundamental ambiguity that is essential to understanding the difference between human and artificial intelligence.

First of all, we must distinguish between two meanings of “language”:

- **Numerical language:** the formal, univocal language of programming.
- **Symbolic (natural) language:** the human language of words, meanings, and interpretations.

At first glance, language appears to be composed of words. However, it is crucial to understand that **language is not reducible to the sum of its words**. It cannot be translated or interpreted in a purely rigid or mechanical way.

12.2.1 Ambiguity as a Condition of Meaning

A classical example is given by **Hans-Georg Gadamer**, who writes:

“Being that can be understood is language.”

This sentence, originally written in German, lacks punctuation, and its meaning changes depending on how it is interpreted:

- “*Being that can be understood is language*”: only that portion of being which is expressed as language can be understood.
- “*Being, that can be understood, is language*”: being itself, insofar as it is understandable, is fundamentally linguistic.

The difference is subtle but decisive. It shows that **meaning is not fixed in the words themselves**, but emerges through interpretation.

A simpler example illustrates the same point. A mother tells her son:

“Go to the store, buy one liter of milk, and if they have eggs, buy six.”

A strictly logical or computational interpretation may lead to buying **six liters of milk**, instead of six eggs. This happens because the sentence is **ambiguous**, and its correct understanding depends on context, not just syntax.

From this, we can draw a fundamental conclusion:

Ambiguity is not a defect of language, but its essential condition.

Attempts to eliminate ambiguity, such as in programming languages, aim at **univocity**. However, in human language, ambiguity is precisely what preserves its **richness**, its **openness**, and its **possibility of meaning**.

This leads to a crucial distinction:

- Machines process the **text**.
- Humans interpret the **context**.

Without context, every expression remains potentially ambiguous. Human beings are not interested merely in decoding meanings, but in grasping the deeper **sense** (*sensus*) that emerges from the situation, the relationship, and the horizon in which language is used. Thus, language is not simply a system of signs, but a **living process of interpretation**, inseparable from the world and from the beings who inhabit it.

12.3 Human vs Machine Dialogue

We can now address the question: **how do human beings and machines enter into a dialogical relationship?**

12.3.1 Saying, Listening, Answering

The first dimension is that of **saying** or **telling**. When language is used in a purely **descriptive** way, based on pairing signs with predefined meanings, machines can perform efficiently, often faster than humans.

However, when language becomes **original**, **poetic**, or **evocative**, the situation changes radically. In poetry, words are not interchangeable: a specific word, in a specific context, can be used **only once** and still carry a unique meaning. This use cannot be reduced to calculation or prediction.

The limitation of machines does not depend simply on the quality of the input data. Even if we provided them with the greatest poetry ever written, the process would still tend to **flatten language**, reducing it to patterns of mediation. The result may appear coherent or even refined, but it lacks **authentic originality**. The same applies to humor: jokes depend on context, timing, and implicit meaning, which cannot be fully formalized.

The second dimension is **listening**. Here we must distinguish between different meanings of listening:

- **Hearing** as a technical reception of sounds.

- **Listening** as *sentire*, which also implies **feeling** and **understanding**.

In German, this distinction is reflected in the connection between *hören* (to hear) and *gehören* (to belong). Genuine listening implies a form of **belonging**, a shared existential situation.

Machines, however, do not truly listen. They **record**, **analyze**, and **process** signals, but they lack **interest** in the existential sense. Human beings listen because they are involved in an **inter-esse**, a being-in-between, a shared condition that makes understanding meaningful.

This difference can be illustrated by comparing a **recorder** with a **listener**. A recording device captures sound mechanically, whereas a human listener actively **interprets**, reorganizes, and gives form to what is heard. Listening is therefore not passive, but **creative and interpretative**.

The third dimension is **answering**. Here we must distinguish between:

- **Answer**: a response that arises from listening, interpretation, and engagement with the other's perspective.
- **Reply**: a response understood as *re-play*, a repetition generated by predefined patterns.

A genuine answer is **situated**: it depends on who is asking, on their context, and on their lived experience. For example, the meaning of “freedom” differs for individuals living in different social, cultural, or historical conditions.

A machine, instead, produces a **standardized reply**. It does not truly encounter the person who is asking, but generates an output based on patterns. In this sense, its response is **blind to the singularity of the other**.

Thus, the dialogical relationship between humans and machines reveals a fundamental asymmetry:

Human dialogue → interpretation, context, singularity

Machine interaction → processing, repetition, generalization

This distinction shows that while machines can simulate aspects of language, they do not participate in the **existential dimension of dialogue**, where meaning arises through shared experience, interpretation, and openness to the other.

12.4 Digital Discourse and Interaction

Let us now consider how **discourse is transformed online**, focusing on how we express ourselves and what we receive in return.

In traditional media, such as television and radio, communication took the form of **broadcasting**. The term itself indicates a **one-way transmission**: something originates from

a source and is sent outward without return. This model is **monological**, not dialogical, since there is only one speaker and no possibility of response. The audience remains **passive**, receiving a continuous flow of images and words.

With the emergence of the web, this structure appears to change. Broadcasts become **interactive**, and spectators seem to transform into **participants**. Through touchscreens and typing, users are no longer mere observers but can intervene, respond, and produce content.

At first glance, this suggests a transition from passivity to **action**. However, we must examine what kind of action is actually taking place.

12.4.1 From Handlung to Fingerlung

The term *action* derives from the Latin *agere*, meaning to **do, create, handle, move, and lead**. In German, this corresponds to *Handlung*, emphasizing the role of the **hand** as an organ of action.

In the digital environment, however, action is reduced to what we might call “**Fingerlung**”: interaction through the **finger**. Typing, clicking, and tapping replace the broader, richer meanings of action. Tasks can be accomplished without physical engagement, without manipulation, and without resistance.

This transformation has several consequences:

- The dimension of **creation** is diminished, since content is often already available as products or services.
- The experience of **handling and resistance** disappears, as digital objects lack the material opposition (*ob-iectum*) characteristic of physical reality.
- The possibility of **living together** in a shared space is weakened, since digital swarms do not form stable communities but remain dispersed and self-centered.

Within this regime of information, **freedom** is redefined. It no longer consists in acting in the full sense of *agere*, but in **clicking, liking, and posting**.

Moreover, digital interaction is characterized by the **absence of resistance**. The finger, as an organ, does not encounter opposition; it functions primarily as an instrument of **selection, command, and consumption**.

In Heideggerian terms, this shift can be expressed as a transition:

from *Zuhandenheit* (ready-to-hand) → *Zufingerheit* (at one’s fingertips)

Reality is no longer something we engage with through embodied interaction, but something immediately accessible, **instantaneous**, and **consumable**.

Thus, the apparent increase in interactivity does not necessarily correspond to a deeper form of action. Instead, it risks reducing human engagement to a series of **minimal gestures**, detached from creation, resistance, and genuine participation in the world.

12.5 Roots of the Transformation

We may now ask: **why is all this happening?** What are the deeper roots of this transformation?

On one side, there is a **religious-cultural foundation**, particularly linked to the Christian tradition. According to one interpretation, the world is **placed in the hands of human beings** so that they may use it as they wish. However, an alternative interpretation suggests that the world is **entrusted** to human beings for **care**.

This seemingly subtle semantic difference has profound consequences. To **use** the world implies domination and exploitation; to **care** for it implies responsibility and preservation. This distinction shapes our entire relation to **things**, **others**, and **reality itself**.

On the other side, **science and technology** realize and radicalize this project of domination. Digitalization represents the culmination of this process, where reality is increasingly ordered, controlled, and made available.

Within this framework, a crucial transformation occurs: if human activity is reduced to **preferences** rather than genuine **action**, then freedom is also transformed. Freedom no longer means the capacity to create something new, but merely the ability to **choose among pre-given options**. What appears as an expansion of freedom is, in fact, its **contraction**.

This leads to a new form of power that can be described as **digital totalitarianism**. Unlike traditional forms of domination, it does not impose itself through violence or coercion. Instead, it operates by:

- **lightening burdens**, taking over tasks that are difficult or repetitive.
- **replacing human initiative** in everyday decisions.
- creating a system of **dependency**.

In this regime, power is exercised through **influence** rather than force. Although digital systems cannot fully understand the depth of human emotions, they are increasingly capable of **shaping behavior** by exploiting what can be called **emotional capital**.

This influence operates at a **pre-reflective level**, below conscious awareness. Through data collection and algorithmic processing, a form of **psychopolitics** emerges, guiding behavior by acting on impulses, habits, and instincts before they become conscious decisions.

In what can be called an **infocratic regime**, individuals are not overtly controlled or punished. Instead, they are **continuously monitored** while being **entertained and informed**. Loyalty is not imposed, but **produced through engagement and dependence**.

Thus, human beings are no longer merely passive spectators. They become **active transmitters of data**, constantly generating and circulating information. This activity often takes the form of **communicative intoxication**, which can evolve into **addiction** and **compulsive behavior**.

12.6 Information and Temporality

The predominance of **information over narrative** has profound consequences, especially in the political sphere. Information, understood as **news** (what is new), has a **short temporal relevance**. It lacks the capacity to stabilize, to endure, and to build coherent meaning over time.

As a result, reality is drawn into a **permanent vortex of immediacy**. The urgency of the present compels us to continuously consume new content, preventing us from **dwelling**, reflecting, and understanding.

This leads to a fragmentation of time:

$$\text{continuous narrative} \rightarrow \text{disconnected instants}$$

In such a temporal structure, discourse cannot develop coherence, and knowledge cannot deepen. The rapid succession of information produces a form of **hyper-accelerated communication** in which time collapses into a series of isolated moments.

Ultimately, this condition undermines the possibility of **experience**, **understanding**, and **meaning**, replacing them with a continuous flow of stimuli that remains on the surface of reality.

12.7 Dromocracy and Political Crisis

Within this **contracted temporality**, politics faces a structural crisis. The time required for **reasoned, long-term decision-making** is no longer available.

We have already distinguished between **democracy** (centered on the *demos*, the people) and **dromocracy** (centered on *dromos*, speed). In a dromocratic regime, **speed replaces deliberation**. Decisions are no longer shaped through slow reflection, but through urgency and immediacy.

This shift undermines the human capacity for **judgment**. Pressed by necessity and acceleration, long-term thinking is replaced by **rationality in the narrow sense**: efficiency,

optimization, and quick solutions. However, such rationality does not dwell; it does not allow meaning to unfold.

Even political preferences, which we believe to be formed rationally, are increasingly shaped by digital mechanisms. Among these:

- **Trolls**, who intentionally spread misinformation and polarizing content.
- **Social bots**, automated accounts that simulate human behavior (posting, liking, sharing) to amplify certain narratives.

In this environment, a crucial distinction becomes blurred:

$$\text{vero (true)} \leftrightarrow \text{verosimile (plausible)}$$

The confusion between truth and plausibility gives rise to what is commonly called **post-truth**. What matters is no longer whether something is true, but whether it **appears believable** and spreads effectively.

A concrete example illustrates this mechanism: an image depicting a soldier humiliating a young girl spreads rapidly due to its **symbolic power**. Its immediacy makes alternative interpretations difficult, and it provokes strong emotional reactions.

At this point, a process of **damage control** begins. The same network that enabled the rapid dissemination of the image becomes a tool for its **neutralization**. This occurs through:

- the dissemination of **counter-narratives**.
- the activation of coordinated accounts.
- the suggestion that the image may be **fake** or generated by artificial intelligence.

The strategy is not to directly deny the truth, but to **flood the informational space** with conflicting interpretations. This produces a **distortion of truth**:

$$\text{truth} \rightarrow \text{noise} \rightarrow \text{uncertainty}$$

In this process, media are not neutral channels. They actively **shape reality** through a dynamic interplay of posts, reposts, shares, and reactions. The result is an **informational noise** that generates doubt rather than clarity.

Importantly, the manipulation does not consist in stating that the image is false. Instead, it **induces suspicion**, saturating the space of possible interpretations until certainty becomes impossible. Even if the truth eventually appears, often in a marginal note, it arrives too late.

By that point, perception has already been **oriented and conditioned**. Users, compelled to continuously express opinions, consume and reproduce information without truly **processing** it.

Thus, when reality becomes evident, it also becomes **difficult to sustain**. Rather than being denied outright, it is **diluted, displaced, and questioned**.

The aim is not to eliminate truth, but to ensure that it is **never fully clear**. In this condition, the possibility of shared understanding, and therefore of meaningful political action, is profoundly undermined.

The condition of passivity characteristic of the **post-truth** regime is further aggravated by the presence of **non-human speakers**, such as chatbots. These systems are capable of producing discourse at scale, generating large quantities of content at minimal cost. In doing so, they contribute to shaping **public sentiment** by simulating a force of opinion that does not truly exist, but appears **verosimile** (plausible).

This phenomenon distorts political debate. What emerges is not an authentic plurality of voices, but a **manufactured consensus**, where artificial amplification replaces genuine participation.

Alongside this, **political profiling algorithms** play a decisive role. Through targeted advertising, voters are exposed to content specifically designed to confirm their pre-existing beliefs. These so-called **dark ads** are:

- invisible to the broader public.
- personalized for specific users.
- optimized through the testing of thousands of variations.

Their purpose is not to inform, but to **manipulate**.

The consequences are profound. Identity becomes increasingly **radicalized**, and personal convictions undergo a process of **hardening**. This leads to a growing division within society, expressed in the phenomenon of **polarization**. Such polarization operates in a binary logic:

0 or 1

with no space for nuance, mediation, or intermediate positions.

As a result, the very possibility of engaging in a meaningful **political debate** based on arguments, programs, and shared reasoning, is progressively nullified.

The system of **tailor-made information**, grounded in micro-targeting and continuous user tracking, does not educate voters. Rather, it **deforms democracy into dromocracy**, neutralizing its capacity for self-observation, self-criticism and collective deliberation.

Instead of forming political judgments through dialogue and comparison with different perspectives, individuals are continuously exposed to content that **reinforces their own**

views. In this way, they are unknowingly enclosed within their own interpretative horizon, which intensifies polarization.

This dynamic reflects a broader paradigm of being in the net: a **continuous implementation of the same** and a simultaneous **expulsion of the other**. The other, understood as what is radically different, is progressively excluded from the communicative space.

12.7.1 Memes and Visual Communication

A central role in this process is played by **memes**. Their success lies in their capacity for rapid and viral diffusion. Memes:

- reproduce and mutate at high speed.
- rely on simple and immediate structures.
- require minimal cognitive effort to be consumed.

Typically composed of an image accompanied by a short, striking phrase, memes privilege the **visual** over the textual dimension. This preference reflects the broader tendency of digital communication toward immediacy.

However, this immediacy comes at a cost. By reducing complex realities to **pure appearance**, memes strip facts of their depth and substance. Images, unlike discourse, lack argumentative structure, rational grounding and the capacity for critical articulation.

In this way, the predominance of visual communication contributes to the erosion of **democratic discourse**, replacing argumentation with impression and reflection with reaction.

12.7.2 Democracy and the Limits of Speed

Our topic, **justice** in this context, and more broadly **democracy**, are **slow and complex systems**, often built through delicate interpretative balances. They emerge from **dialogue**, from **conflict**, from **compromise**, and often from **painful agreements** between opposing positions.

For this reason, **informational virality** deeply damages their functioning. It forces these systems to operate at a **speed** that they do not possess and cannot sustain.

Argumentation and **justification** cannot be reduced to tweets or memes. **Logical coherence**, which characterizes a discourse, requires **time** to be constructed. It needs duration, continuity, and the possibility to dwell within a reasoning process. This temporal dimension is completely incompatible with the vortex of **immediacy** that governs viral media.

We can therefore say that **information** follows its own **logic** and its own **temporality**. It does not operate simply within the distinction between **truth** and **falsehood**, but within the regime of **post-truth**.

Even **fake news**, first of all, is **information**. And as information, it already produces its full **effect** before any process of **verification** can begin. It circulates, shapes **perception**, and orients **judgment** in advance.

In this sense, **information moves faster than truth**. It runs ahead of it, and **truth**, which requires time to emerge and be recognized, can no longer catch up with it.

13

Lecture of 28/04/2026

In the last lecture we discussed **language** and how **being in the net**, together with the broader process of **digitalization**, profoundly transforms the way we **think** and **express ourselves**. The spaces in which we communicate and the tools we use are not neutral: they impose **rules** that are inherent to their functioning.

These rules are often difficult to identify, yet they exercise a real **normativity**, meaning that they effectively shape and influence our **behavior**.

13.1 Silence and Hypercommunication

Up to now, we have focused on the **words** we exchange online. However, human communication does not occur only through explicit verbal expression. In the real world, communication can also take place through the **absence of words**, that is, through **silence**.

Silence is itself a form of communication. It represents what we may call a **defective mode** of discourse, without thereby being deprived of meaning. On the contrary, it often carries a deeper and more essential significance.

13.1.1 Silence, Listening, and the Sacred

Silence is also closely bound to the dimension of the **sacred**. At the beginning of a sacred rite, silence is required: one is asked to **close the mouth** and **open the ears**, to listen. Silence, in this sense, is the condition that makes **listening** possible.

In contrast, the age of networks, characterized by a constant **compulsion to communicate**, can be understood as a **desacralized age**. Every space is occupied by **communicative noise**, which transforms expression into a continuous **performance of opinion**.

Through **idle talk** (chiacchiera), **equivocation** (l'equivoco), and **curiosity** (la curiosità), the network is flooded with voices, both human and artificial. This proliferation does not truly inform; rather, it **deforms communication** and, above all, **saturates the possibility of listening**.

Informational capitalism does not tolerate **silence**, because in silence **attention** is sharpened and **critical thinking** is strengthened. By remaining silent, we gain the possibility of **listening**, not only to others, but also to ourselves. Heidegger, in fact, tells us that **conscience** speaks through the **voice of silence**.

13.1.2 Silence and Contemplation

Silence calls us to **withdraw** (*ritrarsi*), to remove ourselves from dispersion, and to devote ourselves to **contemplation**. This withdrawal opens the possibility of a form of **transcendence**. The act of withdrawing (*ritratto*) also means, in this sense, the possibility of **projecting ourselves**. In order to construct a **project**, we must take a distance from our immediate image, we must transcend ourselves in order to represent who we are and who we may become.

A **project** requires **time**. It cannot be reduced to the speed and seriality of a **selfie**. In the contemporary condition, where being means **displaying ourselves online**, we lose access to this sacred dimension of silence, which implies **solitude** and **anguish** (*Angst*). Instead, we are driven toward **hypercommunication**, oriented not toward understanding, but toward the continuous **self-production of identity**. In this condition, silence is replaced by constant expression, and the possibility of an authentic relation with ourselves is lost.

Only **silence**, that is, what remains **unsaid** and **not-yet-revealed**, can set **imagination** in motion. Silence opens a space for **mystery**, allowing imagination and fantasy to emerge without being colonized by images already seen or words already heard. Outside of imagination, what remains is only **pornography**, understood as the total exposure and consumption of what should instead remain partially hidden.

13.1.3 De-distancing and Hyperactivity

The contemporary removal of distance between ourselves and the world must not be understood as a genuine **approach** (*avvicinamento*), but rather as a process of **de-distancing** (*de-distanziamento*). The network eliminates distance by making everything immediately available and ready for use, without requiring **action** (*Handlung*), but only the touch of a finger (*Fingerlung*).

However, this abolition of distance does not imply a true movement toward the other. It does not involve **attention**, **study**, or a **respectful relation**. Its aim is not to deepen relationships or strengthen bonds, but to remove every **limit** that stands between the subject and the immediate satisfaction of desire.

This dynamic reflects a fundamental assumption of **capitalism**, which seeks to eliminate resistance and delay in order to maximize consumption and availability.

Being in the network prevents us from entering a state of **contemplation** and **silence**. In this condition, **mouths, ears, and eyes are always open**. The eyes are compelled to capture continuous **novelty** in order to remain constantly **updated**.

At the same time, online we are never allowed to stop **expressing** and **exposing** ourselves. To cease communication means to risk **disappearing** from the existential horizon of others, and therefore, in a concrete sense, to **not be there** (non esserci).

In this context, we must distinguish between two forms of **freedom**. On the one hand, there is a **positive freedom**, which consists in the power to **do something**. On the other hand, there is a **negative freedom**, which consists in the power to **not do**.

This **not-doing** is not the opposite of action, but an **autonomous capacity**. It is the ability to refrain from acting, from exposing ourselves, from constantly producing. Only through this negative freedom do we become capable of **silence, contemplation, and deep attention**.

Where this freedom is lacking, we fall into a condition of **hyperactivity**. The dominant **compulsion to communicate** transforms us into a **showy** and **noisy subject**, immersed in a continuous **digital clamor**.

This clamor, made of **acoustic** and **visual noise**, saturates our attention. Instead of strengthening it, it ultimately **weakens** it, leaving no space for reflection or genuine listening.

13.2 The Digital Graphic Revolution

Having considered the **defective aspect of language**, namely **silence**, we must now turn to its **graphic dimension**, that is, **writing**. The **digital revolution** can also be understood as a **graphic revolution**, since it introduces a new form of writing.

13.2.1 From Alphabetic Writing to Computation

Traditional **alphabetic writing**, which we use to record words, has become so deeply integrated into everyday life that it now passes almost entirely **unnoticed**. Yet its history is extremely ancient and complex. Writing emerges from a combination, never fully stabilized in Western history, of four elements: **numbers, letters, figures, and matter**. Over approximately **five millennia**, writing has taken many different forms through the interaction of these components.

For our purposes, one moment is particularly significant. The **Greeks** did not invent alphabetic writing; they received it from the **Phoenicians**, with whom they maintained commercial relations. The Phoenician system was a **consonantal alphabet**, meaning that it recorded only consonants. As a result, a sequence such as “th ct s bg” could correspond to multiple meanings: “the cat is big”, “the cat is beige”, “the cut is big”, or

“the coat is beige”.

The Greeks transformed this system into a **vocalic-consonantal alphabet** by introducing **vowels**. This innovation is decisive. With the Greek alphabet, writing no longer requires prior knowledge of the word in order to be written, nor does reading require a full understanding of the language in advance.

In this sense, the Greek alphabet marks a fundamental **turning point**. It allows us to **read without necessarily understanding**. Precisely because it is universally readable, even independently of comprehension, it opens the possibility for writing to become **mechanizable**.

This feature anticipates our contemporary condition, where writing can be processed, reproduced, and interpreted by **machines**, independently of human understanding.

13.2.2 Computational Writing

Having outlined this historical premise, we can now consider the new form of writing introduced by **computers**. This new **graphic regime** differs from previous forms of writing in two fundamental respects.

On the one hand, it has a **conceptual character**, grounded in a clear separation between the **physical component (hardware)** and **meaning**. On the other hand, it has a **combinatory character**, which allows it to perform operations independently of human participation.

In **computational writing**, sequences of numbers are rewritten through other sequences of numbers, in view of producing a specific outcome, which itself takes the form of a numerical sequence. Writing is no longer a simple **recording of words**, but becomes an **operative process** governed by its own internal order.

For this reason, its most radical and unprecedented feature is that it is **mute**. Unlike traditional writing, it does not register a pre-existing reality expressed through language. Rather, it operates upon a **mute material**, transforming it through combinatory procedures.

In this sense, the **digital** is not merely a tool that accelerates the **diffusion of messages**. It introduces a deeper transformation: a true **symbolic revolution**. Computational writing does not replace traditional **textual writing**, but it competes with it, challenging its historical centrality.

On the one hand, we have **computational writing**; on the other, **textual writing**. By undermining the **monopoly of the text**, this graphic revolution profoundly alters our way of **conceiving reality**.

This shift is particularly evident in the domain of **law**. In Western civilization, law has traditionally been enacted, transmitted, interpreted and preserved in the form of **text**. The digital, however, acts as a **symbolic re-organizer** across all dimensions of life:

subjective, intersubjective, and collective. Its impact on law reveals the challenges introduced by this transformation.

13.3 Digital Codification and Data

At its core, digitalization consists in the **codification** of events of the physical world into **numerical form**. Phenomena, once converted into **signs**, are translated into sequences of numbers. Reality is thus **fragmented into discrete signals** and rearticulated as **numerical codes**.

This passage from the **physical** to the **signic level** marks a fundamental transformation in our relation to reality, which is no longer encountered as continuous, but as something that can be decomposed, processed, and recomposed within a digital framework.

A first observation is that **digital codification** renders **homogeneous** phenomena that are in reality highly **different** and **diverse**. An image of a child, a constitutional text, a song, a medical test, a sport result, any phenomenon, whether **natural** or **cultural**, can be translated into the same **numerical form**.

This power of **homogenization**, characteristic of the **society of the stereotype**, is achieved by setting aside both **direct perception** and **language**, which are the primary **vectors of meaning**. The transcription into a single digital language is possible only by rejecting everything that refers back to **sense**.

It is precisely this **arithmetic homogeneity** of data that constitutes the novelty of the digital revolution. Once phenomena are converted into numbers, **human intervention** is no longer required for their processing, since all operations occur internally within the system.

This transformation is possible because **digital writing** separates two moments that were previously united: the **perception of signs** and the **comprehension of meaning**. In traditional writing, reading involves recognizing letters, combining them into words, and allowing meaning to emerge. In digital writing, this process becomes inaccessible.

13.3.1 Opacity and Algorithmic Power

Computational processing takes place at such speed and complexity that no one, not even engineers, can follow it step by step. Moreover, it operates exclusively through the binary code of **0 and 1**. The immense sequences that rewrite reality in digital form renounce both the **sound of speech** and its **immediate legibility**, making this form of writing effectively **illegible**.

As a consequence, a division emerges. **Programmers** become the custodians of this inaccessible language, while **users** must delegate these operations to them, thereby losing **control** over the processes that shape their world.

From a **phenomenological** perspective, we must therefore acknowledge the emergence of a new class of **private legislators: software engineers and programmers**. They are legislators because they effectively **formulate the rules** that govern reality by embedding them into technological systems.

Their power is **opaque** for two reasons. First, they are **unelected** and largely unknown. Second, they legislate through **science**, using a language that is **inaccessible** and based on **calculation**, rather than on the **juridical reasoning** that traditionally characterizes law.

In this way, the structure of power itself is transformed, shifting from publicly visible norms to **hidden algorithmic processes**.

13.4 Big Data and De-symbolization

The notion of **digital writing** is not limited to the transformation of physical reality into data and its subsequent processing through programs. The **age of the network** introduces a third stage: the **statistical aggregation** of enormous quantities of data, known as **big data**, made possible by the interconnection of devices.

This aggregation aims at identifying previously unnoticed **correlations**, allowing us to trace **tendencies** within natural phenomena and social interactions, and to formulate **predictions** about the future. The mere establishment of correlations gives the impression that the world can **speak for itself**, without requiring human **interpretation**.

Although the statistical understanding of reality is not new, today **computational automation** amplifies it to an unprecedented degree. It not only allows us to identify general patterns of behavior and opinion, but also to **influence** and **shape** them.

However, digital writing remains a fundamentally **mute form of writing**. It cannot be directly **read** or **enunciated** in words, and therefore requires translation into a traditional **linguistic system**. Any activity mediated by computation becomes **opaque** to the user, since no one has direct access to the underlying **binary language**.

As a result, **intelligibility**, understood as the union between the physical sign and its meaning, takes place **outside** the computational system, even though this system has become a necessary condition for accessing reality.

This situation entails a concrete risk: that of **de-symbolization**. The **symbolic power** of language consists in attributing meaning to signs in a way that binds individuals together within a shared **community**, across space and time. Human beings do not simply use language; they **understand** and **interpret** it.

Language, as we have seen, has a double function. On the one hand, it **defines**, that is, it establishes limits and distinguishes meanings. On the other hand, it **opens** meaning to multiple **interpretations**. This **plasticity** of language is what makes it a living medium of communication.

The risk of de-symbolization lies precisely in the loss of this dual movement. When reality is reduced to data and correlations, meaning is no longer interpreted but merely **processed**, and the shared symbolic horizon that constitutes a community begins to dissolve.

The **expressivity of signs** consists in their **evocative power**, that is, in their capacity to stimulate meanings and interpretations within those who perceive them. This dimension, called **symbolic efficacy**, is entirely lost when signs are processed computationally. In a **computational language**, numerical sequences are fundamentally **uninterpretable**. They are deprived of symbolic force and lack any genuine expressive or evocative power. Unlike human language, they do not open meanings or generate interpretation.

13.5 Language, Ritual, and Law

This process has significant consequences within the **juridical sphere**. Computational writing strips characters of their symbolic dimension and overturns the ritual and juridical balances upon which law traditionally rests. Indeed, digital graphic activity delegated to computers takes place neither within a **bodily-lived space** nor within a **collectively constructed time**.

The functionality of digital writing derives precisely from its claim to have freed itself from the necessary union between **word** and **rite**. Yet word and rite constitute the symbolic nucleus of law. There exists a profound correlation between **logos** and **nomos**, between language and norm.

Norms are expressed through **linguistic formulations**, and in order to possess meaning they must obey grammatical, lexical, and semantic rules. Furthermore, juridical language remains intrinsically **open to interpretation**. The meaning of concepts changes according to time, culture, and historical context. For example, the notion of **family** does not signify the same thing in every civilization or epoch.

13.5.1 Expressive and Performative Language

Within law, words may possess both:

- **Expressive power**: language used to testify, deliberate, argue, or narrate within juridical procedures.
- **Performative power**: language capable of producing concrete effects in reality, such as pronouncing a sentence, taking an oath, or saying “yes” during a marriage ceremony.

Performative speech does not derive its force solely from what is said, but from the fact that it is uttered within a precise **ritual framework**. Solemn juridical acts require:

- a specific symbolic place,
- the presence of an authority,
- witnesses,
- and the bodily presence of those involved.

Rights and obligations cannot emerge through a merely formal declaration detached from its context. They depend upon a **chain of meaning production** that unites **language** and **rituality**.

There is therefore a structural integration between the **textual content** of the norm and the **institutional and symbolic dispositive** that authorizes and validates it.

Language alone is insufficient. Without its ritual and symbolic apparatus, there would remain only a text deprived of its context and therefore deprived of its force.

Although juridical rituals have transformed throughout history, they have never lost their fundamental symbolic efficacy.

Today, however, jurists are increasingly encouraged to regard the **ritual component** of law as something merely folkloric, superfluous, inefficient, and wasteful of time and resources, as if law could stand autonomously upon pure technical procedures alone.

13.5.2 Ritual Repetition and Computational Iteration

For this reason, it becomes necessary to distinguish between **ritual repetition** and **computational iteration**.

Computational iteration aims at the endlessly identical repetition of procedures that are fully predefined in advance. It operates according to the logic of the **stereotype**, mechanically reproducing operations without interpretation.

Ritual repetition, by contrast, has a symbolic function. It seeks to bring what is unsettling back into what is known, the foreign into the familiar, and even horror and violence into a sublimated order capable of being collectively managed.

Ritual therefore generates **meaning** through the mediation of **symbols**. It allows the collective elaboration of violence, conflict, and vengeance that would otherwise circulate freely and dangerously within society.

The juridical ritual, precisely through its apparent immobility and repetitiveness, makes possible the integration of horror, the sublimation of violence, and the overcoming of conflict.

The role of ritual is therefore to introduce a temporary **void of meaning**, an interruption that suspends immediate reactions in order to allow a reconstruction mediated by language, symbols, and the shared collective framework of the community.

It is through this symbolic alchemy that ritual attains its **symbolic efficacy**, manifested concretely in the resolution of conflicts and in the regulation of violence within human groups.

13.6 Digital Technique and the Transformation of Meaning

Digital technique, however, profoundly alters the conditions under which meaning itself is elaborated. By transforming the symbolic and graphic structures through which society interprets reality, digitalization simultaneously transforms the social conditions of this interpretation.

The graphic revolution inaugurated by digital writing manifests itself in two interconnected ways: on the one hand, it attempts to redefine **law**; on the other hand, it transforms the way society **thinks about itself**.

In this new framework, legitimacy and efficacy increasingly derive not from human reasoning, interpretation, and symbolic mediation, but from the supposedly objective operations of **calculation** and computational processing.

14

Lecture of 04/05/2026

14.1 From Digital Existence to Technocratic Capitalism

In the lectures of the first month, we addressed the **philosophical foundations** upon which our reflections are structured. These foundations were then developed throughout the second month of lectures. In the previous lessons, we focused primarily on the **environment** we inhabit, a world increasingly permeated by the **digital** and by our constant **online presence**.

We must now turn our attention to the **economic** and **cultural coordinates** within which these transformations unfold, particularly what we have previously called **technocratic capitalism**. To understand this system, however, we must first investigate its **roots**. Studying roots does not simply mean studying the past; rather, it means examining where a plant draws its nourishment.

14.2 Capitalism as a Religious Phenomenon

As always, we begin from a **phenomenological perspective**. How does contemporary capitalism present itself? According to the perspective we will gradually develop, capitalism appears less as a purely technical or pragmatic phenomenon and more as a **religious phenomenon**.

If we look at the history of civilization, we notice that there has always existed a profound relationship between **economy** and **religion**. Throughout centuries and millennia, these two dimensions have alternately converged and clashed. In particular, we shall examine the distinction between the spirit of **Northern Europe**, historically linked to the **Protestant world**, and the capitalism of **Southern Europe**, linked instead to **Catholicism** and to a conception centered more on the **community** than on the isolated individual.

However, spirits themselves cannot be directly observed phenomenologically. We can only search for their **traces**, which are sedimented within language and within the great words upon which our culture rests.

One of the characteristic mechanisms of capitalism consists precisely in taking these **great symbolic words** and amputating their deepest dimension in order to produce **substitutes**, **prototypes** that resemble the originals but are deprived of their gratuitousness and transformed into **goods** and **commodities**.

14.2.1 Homo Economicus and Sacrifice

The starting point of this reflection is the thesis that the **homo economicus**, so that particular way of relating to the world typical of economics, is far older than economic science itself. This disposition consists in taking, grasping, seizing, appropriating reality, both physically and symbolically, through naming and possession (*zu nehmen*).

This economic attitude is deeply rooted in the history of religion itself. In fact, long before economics emerged as a discipline, religion had already invented the logic of the **homo economicus**, especially through the structure of **sacrifice**.

Sacrifice, which lies at the center of many religious experiences, may be understood as a form of **exchange** between human beings and the divine. In this sense, the first merchant was primitive man, and the first creditor was God.

Without this premise, neither capitalism nor the history of Western civilization can truly be understood. There exists what we may call an **archaeology of concepts**, through which economy continually refers back to theology.

Between **market** and **spirit**, there has always been a profound continuity. Theology frequently employs economic categories, while economic language itself remains deeply permeated by theological traces. The Bible, for example, is full of economic imagery: markets, merchants, exchanges, debts, coins, and contracts. Even the betrayal of Christ is mediated through money.

Many concepts reveal this overlap between theology and economy:

- **price**,
- **debt**,
- **credit**,
- **belief**,
- **faith**,
- **pact**,
- **covenant**.

These terms demonstrate the fluidity and reciprocal influence between the religious and the economic sphere.

Why does the dialogue between **economics** and **theology** still appear so weak today? One reason is that modern disciplines have become increasingly separated: economists often lack theological culture, while theologians possess little economic knowledge.

14.2.2 Walter Benjamin: Capitalism as Cult

Let us begin from the thesis that **capitalism functions as a religion**. Walter Benjamin, almost one hundred years ago, identified three essential characteristics of capitalism understood in this way.

The first is that capitalism is a religion of **pure cult**, perhaps the most extreme cult ever known. Within it, nothing possesses meaning except in relation to the cult itself. Capitalism has no true dogma or coherent ideology in the traditional sense; it exists as a continuous practice, as pure ritual activity.

The second characteristic is the **permanent duration of the cult**. Capitalism admits no interruption. Through digitalization we can work, communicate, consume, and remain present online twenty-four hours a day. There are no sacred pauses, no true holidays, no separation between ordinary time and ritual time. The cult is continuous.

The third element is that capitalism is a **guilt-producing** and **debt-generating** religion. Unlike traditional religions, which aimed at the remission of guilt, capitalism continuously generates both guilt and debt. Moreover, this guilty conscience tends toward universalization: everyone must feel perpetually indebted, insufficient, and responsible. These reflections by Benjamin remain highly significant, yet they were formulated a century ago. We must therefore ask ourselves whether capitalism in the twenty-first century still functions as a religion and, if so, under what form.

14.3 Managerial Ideology as the Religion of Globalization

One possible answer emerges through the analysis of the modern **ideology of business**. This managerial ideology increasingly appears as the primary religion of globalization. Its temples are the great **business schools** of the world, institutions that cultivate and disseminate this worldview on a global scale.

Their success depends precisely on the fact that this ideology presents itself not as a religion, but as a neutral **technique**. By appearing technical, objective, and universal, it conceals its ideological character.

Managerial tools are presented as universally valid and equally applicable everywhere: in Boston, Nairobi, Rome, or Bombay. A computer, an algorithm, or a managerial proce-

dure supposedly functions identically regardless of context. Yet beneath this technical neutrality lies a precise **worldview**, a conception of the individual and of social relationships.

At the center of this worldview stand two fundamental dogmas:

- **meritocracy**,
- **incentive**.

For this reason, the managerial ideology of our age deserves much deeper scrutiny. Considerable attention is often devoted to environmental sustainability or to economic ethics, but far less attention is paid to **managerial ethics**, despite the fact that managerial logic increasingly structures every sphere of human life:

- schools,
- politics,
- healthcare,
- justice,
- and digital platforms.

14.3.1 The Absorption of Critique

One of the strengths of contemporary capitalism lies in its ability to absorb and neutralize its own critics. It does not simply fight its enemies; it incorporates them. Capitalism consumes criticism, transforms opponents into collaborators, and recruits them into its own structures.

For example, many critiques concerning the digital world, communication, or the flattening of beauty into efficiency have themselves been reabsorbed into forms of **marketing**, **networking**, and **communication strategies**.

At the same time, capitalism also consumes those who are regarded as its prophets and representatives: **managers**, **executives**, and **CEOs**. Even they become functional components within the same self-perpetuating system.

14.3.2 Burnout and Emotional Fragility

We can observe that within the walls of these apparently perfect corporations, significant cracks are beginning to emerge. One of the most evident concerns is the growing **relational** and **emotional fragility** affecting both employees and managers, especially within large global companies.

Many corporations now consider **burnout** almost as a normal stage in the development of a managerial career. It is increasingly treated as inevitable, given the structure of managerial work itself: the way labor is organized, incentivized, and culturally interpreted. The result is a repetitive cycle. After the first burnout, others follow, because once individuals recover, they are reintegrated into the same **toxic dynamics** and the same **pathological culture** that originally generated the malaise.

14.4 The Stolen Gift and Corporate Devotion

At the root of this condition lies a profound paradox. One of the golden rules of contemporary managerial culture is the prohibition against mixing the languages and emotions of **private life** with those of **corporate life**. Words such as:

- **gift,**
- **gratitude,**
- **friendship,**
- **loyalty**

are considered inappropriate within the workplace because they are regarded as inefficient, irrational, and potentially dangerous.

Yet the paradox appears precisely when corporations attempt to motivate and recruit workers. In those moments, companies systematically employ words and symbolic registers that belong traditionally to the spheres of:

- family,
- friendship,
- religion,
- and ethics.

Companies speak of:

- **passion,**
- **vocation,**
- **sacrifice,**
- **community,**
- **recognition,**

- **respect,**
- **loyalty,**
- **merit,**
- and **excellence.**

These concepts activate within individuals, especially in young people, the same emotional and symbolic dynamics learned within family and religious life. Corporations reproduce the same rituals, the same emotional intensity, and the same demand for dedication, but without the dimension of **gratuitousness** that traditionally accompanied those relationships.

In earlier stages of capitalism, workers and managers were certainly asked for much, but not for **everything**. Other existential spheres remained intact:

- family,
- religion,
- political participation,
- and community life.

These were spaces where meaning and identity could unfold independently from work. By contrast, contemporary capitalism increasingly demands the **whole person**. Companies ask not only for labor, but also for:

- time,
- emotions,
- passion,
- priorities,
- and identity itself.

The boundary between work and private life progressively dissolves. Yet this total demand cannot be justified merely through the language of **contract** and **salary**. Economic exchange alone is insufficient to motivate such profound dedication.

For this reason, corporations borrow a **religious vocabulary** centered around sacrifice, vocation, devotion, and self-gift. The concept of *Beruf*, which simultaneously means profession and vocation, becomes crucial here.

Modern companies understand that in order to obtain maximum performance, they must mobilize not only technical skills, but also the **soul** of workers. They require devotion and existential participation.

However, here emerges the central paradox. If corporations truly recognized the full value of this self-giving, they would also have to recognize the **bond** created by it. Such a bond would exceed the purely contractual dimension and would become less manageable by managerial logic.

As a consequence, the worker's gift is never truly acknowledged as a gift. Instead, it is reduced and absorbed back into the framework of the **contract**. This is what may be called the phenomenon of the **stolen gift**: the company benefits from the worker's existential devotion while refusing to recognize its gratuitous and symbolic dimension.

14.4.1 The Narcissistic Contract

In the early years, this system of promises and expectations between the company and the young worker generally functions effectively. What is called the **narcissistic contract** sustains this relationship: the young employee sees reflected in the company an image of their ideal self, while the company sees in the young worker the ideal image of dedication, ambition, and productivity.

For a time, this reciprocal identification appears rewarding. However, over the years, the emotional investments that workers make without true recognition begin to accumulate. These unacknowledged investments gradually become **emotional credits**, until eventually the individual realizes that they will never be repaid.

At this point, the crisis emerges. The gratification of the initial phase turns into:

- disappointment,
- frustration,
- insecurity,
- loss of self-esteem,
- and a sense of existential failure.

The narcissistic contract breaks. The identification between worker and corporation collapses, and together with it also falls the image of the ideal employee that had previously sustained the relationship.

At a certain moment, the worker realizes that the exchange was not worth the sacrifice, and that their life has often been consumed and exhausted within labor.

For the corporation, however, the process continues uninterrupted. The system simply replaces older workers with new young recruits, generating an endless cycle of consumption of youth. This dynamic resembles, in some respects, both military structures and ancient pagan cults, revealing once again the religious and sacrificial dimension of contemporary capitalism.

14.5 Meritocracy as the Ethical Legitimation of Inequality

We may now examine more closely one of the foundational myths of neo-managerial ideology: **meritocracy**.

Meritocracy functions today as the **ethical legitimation of inequality**. Human beings are naturally unequal, not primarily in terms of wealth, but in terms of talents, abilities, and opportunities, all of which depend upon what Heidegger called **Geworfenheit**, thrownness.

The twentieth century attempted to oppose this condition. Through:

- politics,
- rights,
- welfare systems,
- public education,
- and universal healthcare,

Europe sought to reduce inequalities and to create conditions that would partially compensate for the unequal circumstances into which people are born.

This project produced what may be described as temporary islands of equality within a broader historical ocean of inequality. Women gained access to education and work, children were removed from labor and allowed to study, and elderly people obtained the right to retire with dignity through the welfare state.

Yet while Europe was enjoying this historical phase during the second half of the twentieth century, a counterrevolution against equality was simultaneously developing within:

- finance,
- multinational corporations,
- business schools,
- and global consulting firms.

For capitalism to establish itself as a universal cult, it required a new moral and symbolic legitimization. No ideology can become dominant without obtaining at least partial ethical consensus from society.

This transformation therefore consisted in turning **natural inequality**, which was previously regarded as unjust and undesirable, into a positive moral value. This value is what we now call **meritocracy**.

Inequality ceased to appear as a vice to overcome and instead became a virtue to celebrate. Meritocracy presents itself as a form of justice because it claims to reward individuals according to their merit.

14.5.1 Meritocracy as the Aristocracy of Our Age

However, meritocracy is fundamentally a **myth** and an **ideology**, even though it disguises itself as a neutral technique. Like every historical form of power, it seeks to justify privilege by associating it with some superior quality.

Every oligarchy aspires to present itself as an **aristocracy**, that is, as the rule of the best. Meritocracy is therefore the aristocracy of our age. Compared to medieval aristocracies, the mechanisms of legitimacy have changed: no longer **blood** and **land**, but **merit** and **performance**.

However, the meanings associated with the word **merit** are extremely diverse and unstable. They vary according to the object being evaluated, the degree, the purpose, and the criteria of judgment, not only between different individuals, but also among social groups within the same society.

For this reason, speaking about merit means entering a highly problematic and slippery terrain. Contemporary capitalism, however, tends to ignore this complexity and treats merit as if it were something simple, objective, and immediately understandable.

14.5.2 From Talent to Measurable Performance

One of the first operations performed by meritocratic ideology consists in reducing **talent** to **merit**. Yet this reduction is already arbitrary, because talent itself is not deserved. Talent belongs to what Heidegger called **Geworfenheit**, thrownness: it is something given rather than earned.

Before reducing talent to merit, however, corporations perform an even more decisive operation. They reduce the many possible human merits to a very small number of merits selected by companies and owners themselves. Managers and corporations decide what counts as merit, what deserves recognition, and what should be rewarded.

Once the plurality of human qualities is reduced to a few measurable criteria, these selected merits, which are usually quantifiable and comparable, become the basis for the distribution of power. In this sense, meritocracy literally becomes the **power of merit**. The problem is that this process flattens and levels the immense plurality of human qualities into a narrow and simplified set of measurable performances.

Within companies there exist many forms of qualitative and relational merit that remain invisible because they are difficult to quantify. These qualities are neither rewarded nor encouraged and are gradually discouraged or destroyed. Among the neglected virtues are **humility**, **gentleness**, **compassion**, **mercy**, and **gratuitousness**.

These are not secondary dimensions. They are precisely the anthropological qualities that historically allowed communities to remain united not merely through interest, but through solidarity and reciprocal care.

As we have already seen, the concept of **community** derives from *cum munus*, the circulation of the gift. Human beings do not gather together solely for efficiency and profit, but also for the exchange of gratuitous relations.

Yet contemporary meritocracy recognizes almost exclusively what can be measured, compared, quantified, and ranked. As a consequence, many specifically human talents disappear from visibility and are progressively eliminated.

Moreover, human life is never determined only by merit. There are also **luck**, **chance**, **opportunity**, social conditions, and gifts received from others.

This raises a fundamental question: how much of what we possess truly depends on our merit, and how much instead depends upon providence, circumstances, or the gifts we have received?

14.5.3 Demerit, Guilt, and Exclusion

Meritocratic ideologies therefore reveal another hidden structure. Before being theories of merit, they are theories of **demerit**, **guilt**, **punishment**, and **expiation**.

Although they present themselves as forms of humanism, they often become mechanisms for producing guilty individuals and legitimizing exclusion.

Underlying this system lies the implicit idea that the poor are somehow responsible for their own condition, while the rich deserve their wealth as the rightful consequence of merit.

In this way, inequality becomes morally justified. The suffering of others ceases to call for solidarity and instead appears as the natural outcome of failure or guilt. Indifference itself becomes ethically acceptable.

14.5.4 Education and Equality

Finally, this perspective also invites reflection upon the meaning of education and equality. Article 34 of the Italian Constitution states that capable and deserving individuals, even if lacking economic means, have the right to attain the highest levels of education.

Yet this formulation itself may be questioned. A truly just society should perhaps focus not primarily on rewarding those who are already the most capable, but on supporting those who are the least advantaged.

Otherwise, a social system that rewards only pre-existing capability simply increases the distance between individuals, leaving behind those whose difficulties often derive not from lack of merit, but from their circumstances of life.

15

Lecture of 05/05/2026

15.1 Sacrifice as the Dark Side of Merit

In the last lecture, we began to examine how capitalism performs a form of **semantic manipulation**, that is, how it acts upon the major symbols and meanings that shape our lived experience.

In particular, we discussed how companies define and reinterpret the concept of **merit**. Today, however, we must consider what may be called the **dark side of merit: sacrifice**. Sacrifice is one of the great words inherited from religion, yet it is also one of the central concepts employed by the world of labor and economics. Contemporary companies are profoundly transforming the meaning of this word.

15.1.1 Sacrifice, Exchange, and Grace

In archaic pagan societies, sacrifice consisted in offering to divinity the best portion of the harvest, animals, or goods. These offerings generally belonged to the priestly class, which lived through the wealth generated by sacrifice.

Within sacrifice there is therefore already an implicit **economic logic**. Human beings believe that through sacrifice they may influence or somehow control the will of the divine for their own benefit.

Biblical prophets, however, criticized this sacrificial logic. Unlike pagan priests, they distrusted sacrifices because offerings made to God resembled too closely the offerings dedicated to idols within pagan cults.

The prophets opposed the idea that salvation could be bought through sacrifice. Instead, they proclaimed a salvation founded upon **grace**.

Here emerges a fundamental distinction:

- **Sacrifice** belongs to the economic register of exchange.
- **Grace** belongs to the horizon of gratuity.

The word *gratis*, originally *gratiis*, literally means “through grace”, that is, **without price**.

Sacrifice possesses value only insofar as it has an economic weight. The more perfect the sacrifice, the more it becomes useful for God and useless for humans.

For this reason, the perfect sacrifice in many archaic religions was the **holocaust**. The term derives from:

- *holos* = all,
- *kaustos* = burned.

The sacrificial victim had to be completely burned so that nothing remained for human beings and everything was entirely delivered to divinity.

Thus sacrifice becomes a kind of **currency** regulating the relationship between humans and the divine. On one side, believers acquire merit and expiate guilt through sacrifice; on the other side, religious institutions gain power, wealth, and control over consciences by administering this exchange.

Christianity, in its origins, struggled precisely against this sacrificial and economic logic. It attempted to affirm a religion based entirely upon gratuity and grace rather than exchange and merit.

Yet every time Christianity weakened this struggle, the ancient idolatrous temptation returned. Human beings continuously tend to fall back into the logic of:

- merit,
- guilt,
- debt,
- and compensation.

For this reason, remaining within the horizon of gratuity requires constant effort. Otherwise, relationships are once again transformed into economic exchanges governed by sacrifice and calculation.

15.2 Corporate Sacrifice and the New Sacred

With the advent of modernity, **sacrifice** appears at first sight to disappear. In reality, however, sacrifice does not vanish at all. On the contrary, it becomes one of the central words within the lexicon of the new sacred inaugurated by global corporations and contemporary capitalism.

To understand this new corporate sacred universe, one may first observe its visible manifestations. Modern corporations increasingly imitate structures and symbols traditionally

belonging to religion. The presence of **coaches** resembles the role once played by spiritual guides, while expressions such as **mission**, **vocation**, **loyalty**, and **merit** are constantly borrowed from religious language.

Another revealing aspect of this new religion concerns its relationship with **old age** and **youth**. On one side, there is a progressive demonization of the elderly. Old age is no longer perceived as a bearer of **memory**, **wisdom**, and **tradition**, but rather as something already consumed, outdated, and therefore useless within a system entirely oriented toward novelty and speed.

Mirroring this rejection of the old, contemporary capitalism develops a voracious cult of youth. Idolatric systems worship youth precisely in order to consume it sacrificially.

Workers within large corporations are therefore required to sacrifice **time**, **family life**, **social relations**, **health**, and even future existential projects.

Certainly, work has always involved effort, fatigue, and sacrifice. However, within twentieth-century industrial capitalism, sacrifice remained relatively transparent. It was clear who was making the sacrifice and who was benefiting from it. Labor movements and unions had partially succeeded in limiting exploitation through political and juridical struggles. When sacrifice exceeded acceptable limits, the legal system identified it as **exploitation** and attempted to punish or regulate it.

Human beings were aware that behind industrial labor stood distant powers benefiting economically from the sacrifice of workers. These injustices were visible, recognized, and politically contested.

15.2.1 From Exploitation to Voluntary Gift

Contemporary capitalism, however, performs a new semantic operation. The excess of sacrifice is no longer presented as exploitation, but as a **voluntary gift**.

Workers are now expected not only to sacrifice themselves, but also to experience this sacrifice positively, as a meaningful act of self-realization and devotion. The sacrifice demanded by corporations is transformed into an act of **grace**, **loyalty**, and **worship** directed toward the invisible gods of the system.

Employees sacrifice themselves hoping for **recognition**, **success**, **promotion**, and **career advancement**.

Conversely, those who refuse these sacrifices, those who wish to preserve boundaries between work and private life or who reject overtime labor in exchange for money, remain outside the circle of the “chosen”. These individuals are often induced to feel **guilty**, **inadequate**, or **unsuccessful**.

Just as in ancient sacrificial religions, the debt can never truly be extinguished. The more one offers, the more is demanded.

Within contemporary corporations, the more **time**, **energy**, and **life** workers give, the

more the system expects from them, until eventually the individual becomes exhausted. At that point, the corporation does not question the structure that produced the exhaustion. Instead, it provides **coaches**, **motivational programs**, and **psychological support** whose purpose is not to transform the system, but to restore the individual so that they may return to functioning efficiently within it.

15.2.2 Sacrifice as Debt

The true stroke of genius of contemporary capitalism has been transforming **sacrifice** from a **gift** into a **debt**. Just as in ancient idolatries, the idol never sacrifices itself, but only receives sacrifices from believers. Likewise, the corporation always places itself on the side of the creditor and never on the side of reciprocal obligation toward workers.

For this reason, when market opportunities or profit conditions change, corporations feel no duty of gratitude or recognition toward the sacrifices made by workers. Companies relocate to tax havens, dissolve themselves, or dismiss thousands of employees without pity or mercy. In the best cases, an entire life of sacrifice is repaid with a financial compensation worth only a few thousand euros.

It is significant that in ancient sacrificial cults the offering always had to involve something **living**. Animals, children, virgins, or sacred plants were sacrificed to the gods, never inanimate objects. The new gods of capitalism continue to demand living sacrifices. They demand **life itself**, especially the life of the young, and they return money in exchange.

Often, the first sacrificial victims are the managers themselves. As we have already seen, they function simultaneously as priests and victims of the system.

15.3 Present, Gift, and Gratitude

This reflection also allows us to distinguish between two apparently similar concepts: the **present** and the **gift**.

The Italian word *regalo* carries within itself the root *rex*, king. Historically, presents were offered to kings and powerful figures in order to obtain favor, protection, or privileges. The gift, in this sense, always expects something in return. It remains tied to an economic and hierarchical logic.

The **gift** (*dono*), by contrast, does not demand reciprocity. Its essential dimension is not material but symbolic. A gift may consist in an object, but its deepest value lies in gratuitousness.

For this reason, hierarchies fear authentic gifts. A truly free gift cannot be completely controlled, measured, or incorporated into systems of calculation. Every hierarchical

structure therefore attempts to neutralize the dangerous dimension of gratuity by transforming gifts into regulated exchanges.

15.3.1 Gratuity as the Taboo of Capitalism

Unlike sacrifice, which belongs both to religion and to capitalism, **gratuity** belongs only to religion. Gratuity represents one of the great taboos of capitalism.

If gratuitous gifts were allowed to circulate freely, they would destabilize the logic of exchange upon which capitalism is founded. In this sense, gratuity acts almost like a poison within the capitalist system. Interestingly, the English word *gift* means “dono”, while in German *Gift* means “poison”.

A free circulation of gifts would therefore infect the system and force capitalism into a radical transformation, perhaps even into its symbolic death.

15.4 Taboo, Hierarchy, and the Market

This leads to a broader reflection upon the notion of **taboo**. Human communities have always needed instruments capable of regulating violence and preventing self-destruction. Taboos historically served this function.

A taboo possesses a profoundly ambiguous nature. On one side, it is something forbidden, dangerous, untouchable, and frightening. On the other side, precisely because it is prohibited, it also exerts a powerful attraction.

The object of the taboo cannot simply disappear. If it vanished completely, the distinction between forbidden and permitted would also disappear. By marking a boundary, taboo creates and protects the symbolic order of the community itself.

In this sense, capitalism treats **gratuity** as its primary taboo. Gratuitousness represents a dangerous possibility because it introduces into economic relations something:

- unmeasurable,
- uncontrollable,
- non-calculable,
- and free.

And precisely because gratuity escapes the logic of exchange, it threatens the very foundations of capitalist rationality.

15.4.1 The Death of Gift and the Strengthening of Hierarchy

Traditional pre-market communities were historically founded upon two distinct and original principles: **hierarchy** and **gift**. Hierarchy regulated power and authority, while gift governed reciprocity within families, clans, and communities.

Only within the sacred space of the temple did hierarchy and gift intersect directly. Outside of religious institutions, the two dimensions generally remained separated.

Markets themselves emerge historically through the elimination of the gift. In order for commercial exchange and contracts to arise, the logic of gratuity had to disappear. Market exchange defines itself precisely through the absence of gift and through the exclusion of gratuitousness.

At the same time, however, the disappearance of gift did not abolish hierarchy. On the contrary, capitalist economies intensified hierarchical structures. Firms, armies, and religious institutions remain among the primary places where hierarchy continues to dominate even within formally democratic societies.

The death of gift therefore strengthened hierarchy.

Even when corporations present themselves as flat organizations or open collaborative environments, this horizontality often remains only apparent.

15.5 The Homeopathic Gift

In accordance with the logic of taboos, **gratuity** within market societies must not be entirely eliminated, but carefully controlled. It must remain visible, displayed, and supervised, without ever being allowed to circulate freely.

The realm of gratuity begins precisely where:

- the market,
- the contract,
- and economic incentives

come to an end.

Crossing the threshold of the workplace therefore requires abandoning the symbolic registers associated with gift, friendship, and freedom. Once inside the company, behavior must conform to:

- rationality,
- utility,
- efficiency,

- rules,
- prescriptions,
- and prohibitions.

Yet, similarly to ancient ritual societies, corporations also establish specific moments in which gratuity may temporarily appear. During conventions, charity events, volunteer initiatives, or philanthropic campaigns, the language of gift and solidarity is publicly celebrated.

However, these gestures do not represent true gratuity. They are controlled and domesticated forms of gift whose function is precisely to neutralize the dangerous potential of authentic gratuitousness.

Corporate philanthropy often consists in donating only minimal portions of profit while maintaining unchanged the structures that generate inequality. In this sense, these symbolic acts function almost like ritual substitutes or **voodoo dolls**: imitations of genuine gift meant to control and weaken its transformative force.

This mechanism may be described as a form of **homeopathic gift**. Small and controlled doses of gratuity are introduced into the system in order to immunize it against the truly subversive power of authentic gift.

The metaphor of homeopathy is important here. Homeopathy is based on the principle that something may be cured through a weakened form of the very element that threatens it.

The Romans themselves, for example, placed large painted eyes on the prows of ships in order to ward off envy and the evil eye. The Latin word *invidia* derives from *in-video*, meaning “to look inside”.

Similarly, capitalist systems symbolically incorporate weakened forms of gratuity in order to protect themselves from the disruptive possibility of real gratuitous relations.

Thus, the system permits only controlled, measurable, and harmless forms of gift, while authentic gratuity remains the true taboo that must never be allowed to spread freely.

15.5.1 Immunization Against Authentic Gratuity

Among the many idolatrous traces that strongly re-emerge within contemporary capitalism, the mechanism of the **homeopathic gift** occupies a central role. Large capitalist institutions attempt to immunize themselves against what they perceive as the dangerous force of the **true gift**, because authentic gratuity possesses a profoundly subversive power capable of destabilizing hierarchical systems if allowed to circulate freely.

This immunization takes place through the introduction into the system of miniature and weakened forms of gift that imitate the authentic one without ever truly becoming

it. Gadgets, discounts, corporate donations, philanthropic initiatives, incentive rewards, and symbolic acts of generosity all function as controlled substitutes for real gratuity. Through these homeopathic gifts, the system protects itself from being radically questioned. Thus, instead of addressing the structural causes of environmental destruction, corporations promise to plant trees in order to compensate for pollution. Instead of questioning inequality and wealth concentration, tiny percentages of profits are donated to philanthropic causes. Instead of creating workplaces where workers may genuinely express freedom and gratuitous cooperation, companies organize volunteer initiatives or charity events that remain entirely controlled within managerial structures.

The same mechanism also appears on the side of consumption. Discounts, sales, free samples, and promotional “gifts” are not authentic gifts, because they are always directed toward obtaining something in return. In this sense, one may say that a **gift** is truly free, while a **present** remains tied to economic exchange and expectation.

If corporations were truly to accept the logic of gratuity, they would have to confront individuals who are unpredictable, uncontrollable, and genuinely free. Workers motivated by authentic inner generosity would move beyond predefined roles, procedures, and incentives, bringing into organizations much more vitality, but also much more uncertainty, confusion, and disorder.

Yet management fears precisely this excess of life because it escapes calculation and hierarchical control. For this reason, capitalist governance constantly attempts to transform every authentic gift into a contract, refusing to recognize gratuity as such and thereby symbolically stealing it.

In this way, the taboo of gratuity is continuously reinforced.

15.6 The Survival of Community Through Gratuity

Ultimately, firms and markets defend themselves against authentic gift because true gratuity naturally calls for:

- equality,
- reciprocity,
- fraternity,
- and vulnerability.

A hierarchy shaped by authentic gift would become fraternal rather than vertical. Power itself would become fragile and exposed.

For this reason, strong human bonds, gratitude, fragility, and vulnerability become dangerous dimensions for capitalist systems and their immunizing culture. They are treated almost as forbidden or unpronounceable words.

And yet, despite all prohibitions, communities continue to survive precisely because many individuals continue every day to violate the taboo of gratuity. Human beings continue to give freely even when systems discourage them from doing so.

It is precisely within this fragile excess, within this surplus of gratuitousness that escapes economic calculation, that the authentic community bond still survives.

The *munus* of a community is therefore not merely the exchange of roles, goods, or services among isolated individuals. A true community exists because human beings continue to offer one another something that is free, unmeasurable, and gratuitous.

16

Lecture of 11/05/2026

16.1 From Community to Consumption

At the beginning of this course, we asked ourselves a fundamental question: **what is being, and what does it mean to be human?**

Perhaps we had already encountered this question in the past, although without possessing the conceptual tools necessary to approach it consciously. More often, we simply took it for granted.

Subsequently, we tried to understand how **networks** and **platforms** alter our perception of **identity**, **alterity** and **community**.

We approached these themes from a problematic and unprecedented perspective, attempting to understand not only technological change itself, but also the anthropological transformation produced by digital existence.

In the most recent lectures, we have instead focused on the economic, cultural, and cultic roots of these phenomena, especially within the context of **Western capitalism**. In simplified terms, we distinguished between:

- a **Mediterranean capitalism**, historically linked to Catholicism and more oriented toward mutuality and communal bonds,
- and an **Anglo-Saxon capitalism**, historically connected to Protestantism and centered more strongly upon individualism.

These two different religious sensibilities generated different ways of:

- organizing power,
- investing resources,
- conceiving institutions,
- and structuring social relationships.

Today, however, **techno-capitalism**, understood as the fusion of technology, market, and network, tends progressively to erase these distinctions until the difference between the two models almost disappears.

Our phenomenological approach proceeds, as always, through attention to words and their etymological roots. The term *concept* itself derives from *cum capio*, meaning “to take together”. A concept therefore gathers multiple elements into a unified meaning.

In our analysis, however, we proceed in the opposite direction: we take a concept and separate its internal elements in order to understand it more deeply.

For this reason, we selected several keywords that are emblematic of the passage from the religious sphere to the economic sphere. Among these:

- **merit**,
- **sacrifice**,
- **gratuity**,
- and **community**.

Although these words acquire different meanings when used within corporate and economic contexts, they continue to evoke the same emotional and symbolic reactions inherited from their original religious dimension.

Another concept deeply transformed and instrumentalized by capitalism is precisely that of **community**.

Today, we must therefore examine the relationship between community and capitalism through the phenomenon of **consumption**.

16.1.1 Consumption as the Monetization of Life

Consumption represents one of the places where the traces of the sacred remain most visible within contemporary economy. Even the geography of our cities reflects this transformation. Large commercial complexes and hypermarkets increasingly occupy spaces once dedicated to churches or spiritual gathering places.

Yet the transformation is not merely external. Alongside the alteration of physical landscapes, there is also an inner anthropological transformation produced by the capitalist compulsion to merchandise and monetize every dimension of existence.

Everything becomes an economic object ready to be exchanged, and this include achievements, successes, happiness, suffering, illness, misfortune, and even death itself.

In this landscape, even identity becomes something to display and sell.

16.2 From Labor to Consumption

As we have already seen, Anglo-Saxon capitalism historically developed alongside a Protestant ethic that interpreted the accumulation of wealth as a possible sign of divine blessing.

However, in the 21st century, **labor** no longer occupies the center of the economic system. If we reflect upon the word itself, we discover how deeply work has historically been connected with suffering and effort. The Italian *lavoro*, the French *travailler*, the Spanish *trabajar*, and the Italian *travagliare* all derive from the Latin *tripalium*, an ancient instrument of torture.

The semantic field surrounding labor is therefore inseparable from fatigue, suffering, effort, and production. Even the word *travaglio* refers both to labor and to the suffering of childbirth.

Yet contemporary capitalism progressively removes labor from visibility. The central figure of the economic system is no longer the worker or the producer, but rather the **consumer**.

The entrepreneur, once praised as a builder and producer, gives way to a new sacred figure: the individual capable of consuming without limits. Wealth itself becomes detached from production. Speculative finance represents one of the clearest examples of this transformation, where money generates more money without any direct relation to production or labor.

Thus, labor disappears beneath the surface of the economic imagination, while financial accumulation and consumption become the new sacred ideals.

16.2.1 Labor, Community, and the Constitution

This transformation has profound consequences for the life of communities.

Working and producing are inherently collective activities. They require cooperation, mutual dependence, shared effort, and social bonds. Consumption, by contrast, may remain entirely individual and solitary. It can occur outside any real communal relationship.

This explains why labor occupied such a central position within modern democratic societies. Article 1 of the Italian Constitution states:

“L’Italia è una Repubblica democratica fondata sul lavoro.”

Labor was conceived as the first foundation of both society and community.

As we have already seen, the word **community** derives from *cum-munus*. Community therefore contains a double structure.

On one side, there is the sphere of **gratuity**. Here, *munus* means gift, and community means placing one’s talents and capacities at the disposal of others freely. Alongside this

dimension exists another indispensable register: the professional and economic sphere, where abilities become specialized roles and are consequently remunerated.

One sphere functions through gratuity, the other through money. A healthy community requires both dimensions to coexist in equilibrium.

However, when capitalism shifts the center of gravity from labor to consumption, the communal and relational dimensions progressively disappear from social life.

Consumption increasingly becomes an isolated activity detached from genuine social interaction.

16.2.2 From Market Encounter to Online Consumption

Traditionally, markets were not merely places where goods circulated. They were spaces of encounter where people exchanged words, judgments, negotiations, interpretations, and conversations.

It is significant that even the Greek alphabet emerged historically through commercial contact with the Phoenicians.

These dimensions are also symbolically connected with **Hermes**, the god from whom the word *hermeneutics* derives. Hermes was not only the messenger of the gods, but also the protector of merchants, travelers, and thieves: figures who move, cross boundaries, seek meaning, establish exchanges, and connect distant worlds.

Today, however, markets emptied of people become little more than giant digital showcases.

The perfect act of consumption becomes online purchasing: the desired object arrives directly at home without encounters, negotiations, dialogue, or waiting.

Capitalism progressively invites us into a condition of total accommodation where every form of effort, delay, fatigue, and waiting must disappear.

The object of desire must be delivered before we even fully experience the time necessary to desire it.

16.2.3 Desire, Gambling, and Narcissistic Objects

Let us briefly reflect upon the words *desiderare* and *considerare*.

The word *desiderare* derives from *sidera*, meaning “stars”. Ancient populations did not sharply distinguish astronomy from astrology. By observing the stars, human beings believed they could glimpse a destiny or a plan established by the divine.

To *considerare* therefore originally meant to observe carefully these celestial signs and align oneself with an already given order.

By contrast, *desiderare* introduces a rupture. The prefix *de-* suggests a distancing or removal. To desire means, in some sense, to detach oneself from the destiny already written in the stars and instead project oneself toward another possibility.

This reflection helps us understand why contemporary forms of gambling represent one of the supreme icons of modern capitalism.

Older forms of gambling, such as horse betting or football pools, still preserved certain communal and social dimensions. They involved shared rituals, encounters, conversations, and collective participation.

Today, however, gambling increasingly takes place through an isolated relationship between the individual and the machine. Examples include slot machines, lottery terminals, and digital betting systems.

These practices are still called “games” (*giochi d’azzardo*), yet they have progressively lost the relational structure proper to genuine play.

A real game presupposes:

- shared rules,
- interaction,
- reciprocity,
- and the presence of others.

Contemporary gambling instead becomes what may be called a **narcissistic** or **autistic game**. The relationship is no longer established with other human beings, but exclusively with an object.

This recalls the idea of the **narcissistic object** previously discussed in relation to digital devices. Such objects do not foster relationships but isolate individuals within self-referential bubbles.

In compulsive gambling, the individual becomes entirely absorbed by the object itself. The machine presents itself almost as a totemic figure. It is luminous, colorful, and endlessly demanding.

The gambler is progressively consumed by the very object that promises pleasure and salvation.

16.3 Consumption as Idolatry

The transition from labor to consumption is therefore accompanied by a systematic devaluation of everything connected to:

- effort,
- fatigue,
- sweat,

- and sacrifice.

Consumption becomes attractive precisely because it appears free from pain, resistance, and limitation.

The great social demand of the 20th century was “work for all”. In the 21st century, however, the dominant paradigm becomes “more consumption for all”.

The logic is no longer:

more work, more dignity

but rather:

more consumption, less effort, more blessing.

For this reason, our age cannot properly be defined as a religious age, because it lacks the spiritual bonds characteristic of religion. Yet it is not truly atheist either, because the place once occupied by God has simply been filled by new idols.

Our age is therefore better understood as an age of **idolatry**.

Idolatrous systems are economies founded upon pure consumption. The idol itself does not labor. Labor acquires value only insofar as it allows the devotee to consume and sacrifice offerings to the idol.

The more idolatrous a culture becomes, the more it despises labor and glorifies consumption.

Finance itself, promising wealth detached from production and effort, becomes one of the highest expressions of this logic. It represents the dream of perpetual consumption without labor.

Today, therefore, privilege is not defined only by the capacity to possess goods economically, but increasingly by the possession of free time necessary to consume experiences and pleasures in an unproductive way.

Labor consequently loses the dignity it possessed, for example, within the first article of the Italian Constitution.

Work no longer appears as an instrument for affirming human dignity. Instead, it increasingly becomes something that diminishes identity and social prestige.

Consumption, by contrast, becomes a status symbol and a sign of blessing, overturning the original Protestant ethic that had placed labor at the center of human value.

16.4 Capitalism and the Consumption of Community

The transition from labor as a shared and collective activity to consumption as an increasingly individual dimension has progressively transformed the structure of social life.

One of the main tendencies of the 20th century consisted precisely in making consumption more and more personalized, shaped around the profile, desires, and preferences of the individual consumer.

However, just like the figure of the manager entered into crisis, the figure of the isolated consumer is also revealing a profound fragility.

For this reason, one of the new frontiers of 21st century capitalism is precisely the rediscovery of **community**.

Today capitalism no longer merely consumes objects: it consumes communities themselves.

This process operates by dismantling communal and humanitarian bonds, reducing everything back to isolated individuals and affirming the absolute sovereignty of the individual subject.

At the same time, capitalism removes the dimension of gratuity from communal life and reintroduces those same functions in the form of paid goods and services.

16.4.1 The Marketization of Care

The transformation of the family represents one of the clearest examples.

Traditionally, families were complex relational structures founded not only upon mutuality, but above all upon care, gratuity, and stable bonds.

As these structures become increasingly fragmented and atomized, activities that once belonged naturally to communal life become paid services: childcare, elderly assistance, emotional support.

The caregiver progressively becomes a seller of care.

Capitalism therefore reinvents itself by attempting to organize forms of consumption capable of reproducing a communal dimension, yet without true gratuity.

As long as society remained within an economy of scarcity, capitalism primarily needed goods capable of satisfying material desires. However, once large parts of Western society surpassed the threshold of basic material satisfaction, the market discovered a new frontier: communal relationships themselves.

Like every religion, capitalism understood that durable systems require communities in order to survive and expand.

Yet unlike traditional religions, which gather people together around transcendent values and shared meanings, capitalism creates forms of aggregation among fundamentally separated individuals.

The word *religion* itself derives from *re-ligare*, meaning “to bind together”. Contemporary capitalism instead creates what may be described as a religion without gods.

16.4.2 Market Communities and Consumer Totems

Digital platforms increasingly host these new market communities where individuals gather not around shared values, but around the consumption of the same products, brands, or identities.

Certain commodities become the new totems around which collective identities emerge. Brands such as Harley-Davidson represent paradigmatic examples: communities form around the object itself, and individuals willingly sacrifice their time, money, energy and identity in devotion to the product and the symbolic universe surrounding it.

The same logic also applies to digital identities. Following influencers, subscribing to platforms, or participating in online fandoms often requires sacrifices of attention, emotional energy, and economic resources.

Yet the profits generated by these collective forms of worship do not return to the community itself, but to the owners of the platforms and brands, who frequently maintain no authentic bond with the symbolic world they monetize.

In this sense, contemporary capitalism increasingly resembles a form of **idolatry of pure consumption**, filling a world emptied of gods and transcendence with fetishes and commodities.

16.5 Narrative Marketing and Post-Scarcity

At the same time, capitalism progressively approaches the sphere of community, especially through digital platforms and social media. However, it does so from a deeply problematic perspective.

The market of the future becomes:

- digital,
- social,
- and narrative.

Narrative marketing and storytelling recover one of the essential dimensions of traditional communities: **narrative capital**.

Human civilizations have always been constructed through stories that are transmitted, received, and shared. Religions, ideologies, political visions, and collective identities all depend upon narratives capable of generating belief and participation.

A faith, an interpretation, or an idea spreads above all through storytelling.

Contemporary digital marketing therefore understands that, in an age of post-scarcity, products alone are no longer sufficient. What must now be sold are stories, identities, lifestyles, and symbolic belonging.

16.5.1 Post-Scarcity and the Society of the Stereotype

The expression **post-scarcity** indicates a historical condition in which goods are no longer rare or difficult to obtain. Markets have progressively expanded to the point that contemporary society lives within an apparent abundance of commodities.

The Latin word *copia* is particularly significant because it contains a double meaning:

- abundance and great quantity,
- but also duplication and repetition of something identical.

This second meaning reflects perfectly the logic of the **society of the stereotype**, founded upon repetition and identity understood not as uniqueness, but as sameness.

16.5.2 Storytelling, Enchantment, and Consumption

Within this new form of digital marketing, influencers no longer persuade consumers by presenting the technical qualities or practical usefulness of products. The commodity is no longer sold primarily through its characteristics.

Instead, consumers are captivated through **stories**.

Even the word *incantare* reveals an important ambiguity. On one hand, it means to enchant, fascinate, and mesmerize. On the other hand, in Italian, something becomes *incantato* when it gets stuck and endlessly repeats the same sequence, as when a broken record repeats the same sound continuously.

This ambiguity perfectly describes the condition produced by contemporary digital storytelling:

- we become enchanted,
- but at the same time immobilized,
- trapped within repetitive cycles of scrolling and consumption.

Modern advertising increasingly imitates the structure of the great narratives traditionally transmitted by families, religions, myths, legends.

The purpose of this new narrative marketing is no longer simply to respond to human needs. In the age of post-scarcity, capitalism must instead activate desires, aspirations, dreams and symbolic imagination.

It is no longer enough to satisfy necessities; the market must now shape fantasies and emotional worlds.

For this reason, techno-capitalism increasingly resorts to the evocative power of myth. Ancient symbolic structures are reshaped, manipulated, simplified, and trivialized in order to adapt them to the codes of the market.

Yet there remains a fundamental difference between traditional narratives and contemporary corporate storytelling.

The stories transmitted by families, communities, and religions were rooted in **gratuity**. Their purpose was not to sell something, but to hand down knowledge of the past, promises, meaning and liberation.

These stories were told uniquely for someone, within concrete relationships and communal bonds.

By contrast, multinational corporations mobilize narratives in order to make consumers emotionally vulnerable and therefore more inclined toward purchasing.

The emotional activation pursued by storytelling marketing remains economically oriented.

For this reason, these narratives ultimately appear weaker and poorer than the stories of faith or communal life, because they lack the dimension of gratuity that originally gave narratives their symbolic force.

Influencers themselves become instruments within this process. They function as plasticized and commercialized versions of ancient mythological figures, recycling symbolic languages originally received freely and transforming them into profitable commodities. Traditional stories enchanted human beings precisely because they did not seek to dominate or chain them.

This ambiguity is already contained within the Latin word *fascinum*, which simultaneously evokes fascination and binding.

Narratives produced by the market increasingly belong to this second dimension: they captivate individuals in order to immobilize them within the circuits of consumption.

17

Lecture of 12/05/2026

17.1 Care, Celebration, and Gift

In this lecture, our reflection unfolds along two fundamental axes: the axis of **care** and the axis of **celebration** (*festa*). Alongside them also emerges the dimension of the **gift**, understood as *dono*, not as the poisoned and interested *present* that we previously analyzed.

Care and celebration are two fundamental words not only of human life, but also of economics and of spiritual experience. There is no authentic celebration without care, and no genuine care without some dimension of celebration.

At the same time, contemporary capitalism attempts to transform celebration into mere **entertainment**. Celebration, originally a relational and gratuitous good, becomes a purchasable commodity. Thus, we move from *festa* to paid entertainment.

17.2 Care and the Temporality of Gift

Let us begin with the concept of **care**.

We remember Heidegger's reflections on care as one of the fundamental modes through which human beings relate both to others and to the world. Yet there is an important distinction. When we relate to objects, we *take care* of them through manipulation and intervention. When we relate to persons, however, we do not simply "take care" in the same intrusive sense; rather, we *have care* for them.

This distinction is crucial because authentic care respects the **alterity** of the other. The other is not approached as an object to manipulate, but as a presence whose difference must remain intact.

Care therefore reveals the deep connection between spirituality, interiority and relational life.

The language of care is inseparable from the language of religion and spiritual experience.

17.2.1 Care, Time, and Contemplation

To understand this better, we may reconsider the relationship between **temple** (*tempio*) and **time** (*tempo*). The time experienced inside a temple differs radically from ordinary productive time. It is a suspended time, detached from efficiency, productivity, and rational acceleration.

Inside the temple, human beings recover the possibility of contemplation. One has the sensation of no longer being dominated by time, but instead of inhabiting it freely.

This experience recalls Heidegger's notion of the **Lichtung**, simultaneously meaning clearing, illumination, and opening. The *Lichtung* is the small opening within the density of the forest where light is finally able to filter through.

Spiritually speaking, this opening represents the possibility of interrupting the oppressive continuity of rational and productive time.

The experience of care requires precisely this liberation of time.

The gestures, rhythms, and words proper to care are radically different from those governing work, networks, and the public sphere.

When, for example, we return home from work and spend time with children, animals, elderly relatives, or sick persons, we are called to abandon the register of efficiency and enter another temporality.

Care requires slowness. If there is no available time, there can be no authentic care.

For this reason, fragmented and accelerated temporality prevents us from truly savoring relationships and inhabiting free time.

Care also manifests itself through ordinary gestures that may appear insignificant, like setting the table, or watering plants. These gestures communicate meaning even without words.

17.2.2 Care as Gift and Competence

Moreover, care is one of the greatest expressions of the **gift**. There is no authentic care without gratuity.

At the same time, care is not reducible only to generosity or emotional closeness. It also involves competence, professionalism and study.

Authentic care therefore unites technical competence with gratuitous dedication.

17.3 Gift, Duty, and Domestic Care

One of the great misunderstandings of our age, especially within Western civilization, has been the tendency to associate the **gift** with the idea of something merely **gratis**, that is, something "without payment". This misunderstanding derives from the assumption that an increase in gratuity necessarily implies a decrease in economic value, as if gift

and remuneration were part of a zero-sum game: the more gratuitousness there is in an act, the less it should be paid.

Yet the concept of **gift** is profoundly ambivalent. As we have repeatedly observed, ambivalence is perhaps its most essential characteristic. Gift belongs among the highest dimensions of human existence, but at the same time, it may also become an instrument of manipulation and power.

We have already noted the ambiguity contained even within language itself:

- in English, *gift* means present;
- in German, *Gift* means poison.

Historically, however, not all gifts have been considered equal.

The gifts celebrated within the **public sphere** were almost always linked to reciprocity and recognition. Sacrifices offered to gods, pharaohs, kings, nations, churches, or today even influencers, generated prestige, visibility, blessings, honor, and symbolic credit for the one who offered them.

This is connected to the etymology of *regalo*, which recalls both:

- **rex**, the king,
- and the idea of tribute offered upward toward power.

Public gifts therefore always implied some form of symbolic return.

Completely different was the situation of the **domestic sphere**.

Inside the home, gifts of time, care, energy, were equally essential, and often even more important for collective survival. Yet these forms of gift were rarely recognized as such.

Within the domestic sphere, gift assumed another name:

duty and obligation.

This distinction is deeply connected to structures of power and to the interpretation imposed through language itself.

17.3.1 The Non-Recognition of Domestic Gift

Historically, the protagonists of public sacrifice and public recognition were predominantly men. Men occupied the sphere where sacrifice generated honor, visibility.

Women, instead, were generally confined to the private sphere, where care and sacrifice were interpreted not as free gifts, but as natural obligations deriving from their social role, like being a mother, wife.

Thus, the first great form of female subordination consisted precisely in the **non-recognition of their gift**.

Motherhood, caregiving, education of children, care of relationships, maintenance of common spaces: all these activities were indispensable for communal life, yet they were interpreted merely as duties rather than as gifts freely offered.

This reveals once again the enormous power of interpretation and language.

The freedom of giving that men experienced in public life disappeared within the domestic sphere, where women's sacrifices became invisible obligations rather than recognized acts of generosity.

A similar mechanism applied also to **sacrifice** itself.

Public sacrifices offered to Gods, kings generated reciprocity, yielding symbolic prestige, wages, salaries. Domestic sacrifices, instead, generated neither recognition nor reciprocity. They remained enclosed within an interpreted condition of obligation.

Perhaps only from this perspective can we fully understand the enormous significance that women's entry into the labor market acquired during the 20th century.

The importance of salaried work for women was not reducible merely to economic independence. The paycheck itself carried symbolic dimensions that many women had never experienced within domestic life: dignity, reciprocity, honor.

Thus, the salary possessed not only an economic value, but also a symbolic and existential one.

The rules governing public life and the market, based on reciprocity and mutual recognition, historically did not apply equally within relationships between men and women inside the domestic sphere.

17.4 Care Work and Market Logic

Let us now try to understand why **care work** continues, even today, to be systematically underpaid in comparison with many other professions.

It is impossible to understand why nurses, teachers and domestic workers receive salaries hundreds of times lower than managers unless we investigate the historical and symbolic roots of care itself.

For centuries, activities like preparing food, taking care of children were entrusted first to slaves and servants, then to poor women, and finally to mothers, daughters, wives, and sisters. These activities were almost never associated with freedom or prestige.

Care therefore became culturally interpreted as something naturally belonging to subordinate figures.

17.4.1 Time as Money, Time as Gift

At the same time, however, the distinction between men and women cannot be simplified too much. There has always existed an elite of women whose social position resembled

much more closely that of their husbands than that of servants or workers. The problem is therefore not reducible to a simplistic opposition between male and female, but concerns broader structures of power, recognition, and class.

The emergence of a **care market** represented an important historical transformation. Yet this solution becomes problematic when market logic becomes the *only* way through which care is organized.

If all care were delegated entirely to the market, every caregiver would become above all a **care seller**. In such a system, inequalities would inevitably intensify:

- the wealthy would purchase care,
- while poorer individuals would be forced to sell their time and emotional energy simply to survive.

Thus, people poor in income would also become poor in time.

Care professions remain poorly remunerated because care is still symbolically associated with:

sacrifice as duty

and with:

gift as obligation.

Public gratitude and economic recognition toward caregivers therefore remain insufficient, despite the fact that care is one of the indispensable foundations of human life itself.

Moreover, competence in care is rarely considered a true value.

Within the dominant economic imagination, competence tends to coincide with rationality, efficiency, and calculation.

This reflects the masculine structure of **homo economicus**, around which modern economics has historically been constructed.

By contrast, care was relegated to the private sphere and therefore excluded from what economics considered central and productive.

Even today, when women increasingly occupy positions of power within business and politics, this underlying framework often remains unquestioned. Frequently, success simply means adapting oneself to organizational structures already shaped according to this masculine canon.

Within this framework, care survives only as a sort of clandestine presence:

- invisible,
- unrecognized,
- and systematically discouraged.

At the same time, the market attempts to manage care according to its own laws:

efficiency, speed, optimization, competition.

Yet these principles profoundly alter the rhythm proper to care itself.

The temporal logic of business increasingly invades family life, relationships, and emotional bonds.

Burnout, urgency, performance anxiety, and productivity culture slowly penetrate even the intimate sphere.

For this reason, many people today struggle to shift from the register of business to the register of care.

Even simple moments, such as visiting parents or grandparents, become fragmented by haste and digital distraction. We remain trapped within the logic according to which:

time is money

instead of rediscovering the possibility that:

time is gift.

Here emerges one of the deepest oppositions between economy and care.

Within economic logic, value increases when the time required for an activity decreases.

Within care, however, the opposite occurs:

the more time invested, the greater the value of care.

Authentic care requires duration, attention, listening, patience, and presence.

And precisely these dimensions are systematically weakened by the accelerated temporality promoted by contemporary managerial and economic culture.

17.5 Celebration Against Entertainment

Let us now move to the second great axis of this lecture: **celebration** (*festa*).

Celebration requires care, preparation and time.

At the same time, care itself cannot endure without celebration. Human life needs moments removed from ordinary productivity in order to preserve relationships, meaning, and communal bonds.

Contemporary capitalism, however, tends to wage a profound war against celebration.

As we have already seen with communities, capitalism often operates through a process of **creative destruction**: it dismantles traditional communal forms and subsequently

offers paid substitutes in their place.

The same process affects celebration.

Free and communal celebration is progressively replaced by:

entertainment

that is purchasable, consumable, and market-oriented.

Yet entertainment and celebration are radically different experiences.

Entertainment is a product. It may be:

- bought,
- consumed individually,
- experienced in solitude,
- and organized according to market logic.

Celebration, instead, can only exist as a:

co-created and co-experienced reality.

It belongs to the sphere of gratuitousness and shared participation.

For this reason, celebration represents a problematic and uncomfortable dimension for capitalism. It is: excessive, inefficient, wasteful and gratuitous. It escapes meritocracy, incentives, and rationality.

Precisely because of this, capitalism constantly attempts to replace celebration with market forms of amusement and entertainment.

Yet celebration remains a fundamental anthropological need.

Children, elderly people, workers, sick persons, strangers: all human beings require celebration because it interrupts ordinary temporality and creates a shared space of meaning.

17.5.1 Work and Celebration

The expression:

“La festa è amica del lavoro”

contains an important intuition.

Those who truly work understand the meaning of celebration because celebration gives rhythm and meaning to labor itself. Work and celebration elevate one another reciprocally.

For this reason, those excluded from meaningful work often experience festive days not as liberation, but as emptiness. Sunday becomes indistinguishable from Monday because the rhythm connecting labor and celebration has been lost.

17.6 Sunday, Rest, and the Ethics of Limitation

Within the biblical and religious tradition, the value of celebration is immense.

The sacred dimension of celebration is especially condensed within the idea of the **Lord's Day**, *la Domenica*.

The term *Dominica* derives from:

Dominus,

meaning Lord.

In the biblical narrative, even God waits until creation is completed and humanity appears before celebrating. Celebration therefore requires company and reciprocity.

Not even God celebrates alone.

Thus, celebration appears simultaneously as:

- a gift from God to humanity,
- and a reciprocal gift returned by humanity to the creator.

Sacred time therefore interrupts ordinary productive temporality and opens a dimension dedicated to contemplation, rest and shared existence.

This interruption is profoundly hostile to capitalist logic.

The implicit slogan of technocratic capitalism:

"I can do everything that I am capable of doing"

expresses a rejection of limits: both physical, ethical and existential.

Celebration, instead, reminds human beings that they are not masters of the world.

We inhabit the world as guests.

Nature is not merely:

- an object of possession,
- a laboratory for experimentation,
- or a reservoir of consumable resources.

Likewise, animals are not reducible to lifeless objects created exclusively for human exploitation or amusement.

Celebration therefore contains an implicit ethical and spiritual dimension because it interrupts domination and recalls the human being to gratitude, limitation and coexistence.

17.6.1 The Fallow Field and Non-Ownership

Connected to the culture of the **day of rest**, *la Domenica*, there is also the ancient culture of the **fallow field** (*il maggese*).

The term derives from the month of May and refers to the agricultural practice, already present in the Roman world, of leaving the land uncultivated for a period of time in order to restore its fertility. If the earth is exploited continuously without interruption, it becomes exhausted and sterile. The temporary interruption of production therefore allows the soil to regenerate itself naturally.

Yet this principle is not merely an agricultural technique. It also becomes a profound existential and spiritual rule.

Its logic may be summarized as follows:

You may cultivate the land for six days, but not for the seventh.

This principle extends far beyond agriculture.

One may work, produce, but not without interruption and not indefinitely. Only slaves work continuously.

This directly contrasts with the logic of contemporary capitalism, which tends toward permanent productivity, constant availability, and uninterrupted performance.

Within the biblical and communal conception of rest, the seventh day interrupts hierarchy itself.

The foreigner ceases to be merely a foreigner and becomes part of the community through celebration. The animal itself is no longer exclusively an instrument of labor but receives its own time of rest. Even property is partially suspended:

what one possesses is not entirely and exclusively one's own.

Part of the harvest, part of the land, part of the resources must remain available:

- for strangers,
- for the poor,
- for animals,
- and for the world itself.

This introduces a radical idea:

non-ownership.

Human beings are not absolute masters of the earth.

A major cause of contemporary environmental devastation derives precisely from the forgetting of this principle. If humans consider themselves owners of every day and every

resource, the planet inevitably becomes reduced to pure merchandise and consumable material.

The culture of rest therefore contains an ecological and ethical dimension:

the earth is not prey.

For this reason, modern secular societies should rediscover forms of non-predatory coexistence with the world, reintroducing dimensions of gratuitousness and limitation.

An emblematic example is found within the Franciscan tradition, where a portion of the vegetable garden was intentionally left uncultivated for birds and wild animals. Even within cultivation, a space remained inaccessible to possession and utility.

17.7 Corporate Celebration and the Crisis of Symbolic Capital

The conflict between capitalism and celebration is therefore extremely deep.

Large corporations constantly attempt to reproduce the symbolic force of celebration. This is done through corporate events, conventions. All of these practices attempt to recreate a sense of belonging, solidarity, yet traditional communal celebrations emerged historically from weddings, baptisms, liturgies and shared liberation.

They were rooted in gratuity and common life rather than in organizational strategy.

For this reason, celebrations artificially recreated within corporations often appear empty or ineffective. Their problem is not aesthetic but structural:

they are instrumental.

True celebration cannot emerge from managerial calculation because it requires disinterested gratuitousness.

This reveals what may be called a crisis of **symbolic capital**. Symbols emptied of their gratuitous and communal roots become mere commodities and lose their existential force.

17.7.1 Nostalgia and Utopia

Yet within human beings persists a profound nostalgia:

- nostalgia for justice,
- for fraternity,
- for authentic communal bonds,
- and for forms of life not reducible to profit.

This nostalgia is connected to the idea of **utopia**.

The term *utopia* itself contains an important ambiguity:

- if derived from *eu-topos*, it means “good place”;
- if derived from *ou-topos*, it means “no place”.

Within this ambiguity lies a decisive question:

is utopia an impossible place, or a good place toward which humanity may still move?

18

Lecture of 18/05/2026

18.1 The AI Act and the Regulation of Artificial Intelligence

In this lecture we address the **AI Act**, one of the most significant and complex legislative instruments recently adopted by the European Union.

The AI Act is a substantial regulation composed of more than eighty articles. For this reason, our analysis will not focus merely on its technical structure, but also on:

- its historical origins,
- the objectives it pursues,
- the instruments it employs,
- and the sanctions and mechanisms through which it operates.

At the same time, we will attempt to interpret this legislative process through the philosophical and phenomenological tools acquired during the course.

18.1.1 Historical Origins and Democratic Regulation

The history of the AI Act represents a paradigmatic example of the attempt to produce a **democratic law** within a **democratic context**.

The first official proposal dates back to April 2021. The final text was approved in April 2024 and will fully enter into force by August 2026.

This temporal span immediately reveals one of the fundamental difficulties of regulating artificial intelligence:

technology evolves at a speed that law structurally cannot match.

Between the drafting of the proposal and its complete implementation, artificial intelligence technologies have already undergone enormous transformations. Law therefore finds itself forced into a delicate balance:

- on one side, it must remain sufficiently rigorous to guarantee protection and certainty;
- on the other side, it must remain flexible enough to adapt to technological evolution.

The approval process encountered countless difficulties.

First of all, the AI Act constitutes the first comprehensive legislative attempt in the world to regulate such a transversal, multi-phased and rapidly evolving phenomenon.

Through this regulation, Europe strategically positioned itself as an international pioneer in the governance of artificial intelligence, especially in relation to global competitors such as USA, China and Russia.

A common expression summarizes this geopolitical division:

“The United States invents, China produces, and Europe legislates.”

Another ironic expression states that:

“Europe is the cradle of law, and perhaps this is why justice has fallen asleep.”

Behind the irony lies a deeper reflection concerning the slowness and complexity of democratic legal systems compared to the acceleration of technological development.

The AI Act applies whenever artificial intelligence systems are made available to European users, independently from where the companies are physically located. Consequently, even non-European actors wishing to operate within the European market must comply with its provisions.

The negotiation process was extraordinarily long and complex.

It involved:

- institutional actors,
- politicians,
- companies,
- academics,
- technicians,
- and experts in artificial intelligence,

coming from all 27 member states of the European Union.

Some negotiation sessions reportedly lasted more than forty consecutive hours in order to reach agreements on highly controversial issues.

Europe attempted to accelerate the legislative process for two main reasons.

First, there was the political necessity of concluding the text before the electoral semester connected to the European elections, after which priorities and political balances might have changed.

Second, Europe aimed to establish itself as an international point of reference in the regulation of artificial intelligence before other global powers could do so.

18.2 Objectives of the AI Act

The fundamental objective of the AI Act is the creation of a homogeneous legal framework shared by all European member states.

The regulation seeks to ensure that artificial intelligence systems developed and used within Europe remain anthropocentric, safe, respectful of fundamental rights, and coherent with the rule of law.

The concept of **anthropocentric AI** is particularly important because it reflects the European attempt to place the human being, rather than efficiency or profit alone, at the center of technological development.

Another crucial purpose of the AI Act is preventing **market fragmentation**.

Without a common regulation, each member state could have adopted different and potentially conflicting rules, generating:

- legal uncertainty,
- unequal protections,
- and competitive imbalances between states.

The AI Act therefore also functions as an attempt to synchronize the regulatory rhythm of European countries, preventing some states from advancing much faster than others in the deployment of artificial intelligence technologies.

How can these objectives be achieved?

The AI Act seeks to promote a **responsible use** of artificial intelligence technologies by introducing guarantees and protections capable of defending citizens against manipulative, abusive, or distorted uses of AI systems. At the same time, it creates the possibility of bringing legal actions against damages caused through the use of these technologies.

The regulation therefore operates along a double direction.

On one side, it attempts to contain the overwhelming power accumulated by the major technological oligopolies, the so-called **Big Tech** companies. On the other side, however, Europe also intends to encourage: **small companies**, **start-ups**, and **research clusters**, preventing them from relocating toward less regulated and more permissive markets.

The fear is that excessively weak regulation could expose citizens to abuse, while excessively rigid regulation could instead generate a technological and economic hemorrhage, causing the loss of: **investments, resources, and innovation.**

18.2.1 Digital Materiality and Environmental Sustainability

Alongside these already ambitious goals, the AI Act also introduces another crucial dimension:

environmental sustainability.

Yet here emerges a first major critical issue.

The digital world often appears clean, immaterial, and light. In reality, however, it is profoundly material.

Behind artificial intelligence there are: **screens, microprocessors, rare metals, chemical agents, mines, submarine cables, routing stations, data centers**, and an enormous infrastructure consuming vast quantities of energy.

Artificial intelligence systems require:

- massive computational power,
- continuous cooling systems,
- huge electrical consumption,
- and constant extraction of raw materials.

Moreover, these productive chains are often located in economically vulnerable countries characterized by weak or absent labor protections and union structures.

Thus, behind the apparent immateriality of the digital sphere lies a highly physical and environmentally destructive apparatus.

This issue remains somewhat secondary within the AI Act itself, yet it possesses enormous relevance.

The difficulty consists in balancing **economic growth** with **ecological sustainability**. Very often, environmental risks end up being justified through the economic benefits generated by technological development.

An important metaphor:

If we want to produce more bread, it is not enough to build increasingly sophisticated ovens. We also need flour and wheat. If flour disappears, there will be no bread at all.

In the same way, technological development cannot indefinitely consume the environmental conditions upon which it itself depends.

The risk is that sustainability remains merely a rhetorical proclamation, similarly to phenomena already observed under the label of **greenwashing**.

18.3 The Juridical Structure of the Regulation

Let us now move to the juridical structure of the AI Act itself.

The AI Act is a **Regulation** (*Regolamento*).

This distinction is fundamental within European law.

Unlike a Directive, which requires implementation through national legislation, a Regulation applies automatically and uniformly to all member states from the moment it enters into force.

Therefore, the AI Act does not require additional national approval procedures in order to become legally binding.

This distinguishes it also from documents such as the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, which possesses mainly declaratory and guiding value but lacks direct binding force.

The AI Act instead establishes valid, effective and binding rules applicable throughout the European Union.

Because of the enormous complexity of the negotiation process, European institutions resorted to the so-called **trilogue** procedure.

The trilogue is an informal inter-institutional negotiation involving representatives of: **the European Parliament, the European Commission, and the European Council**. Its purpose is to reach a provisional compromise acceptable to both co-legislative bodies of the European Union: the Parliament and the Council.

Although the AI Act will become fully operational in August 2026, this does not mean companies remain entirely free until then.

Firms are already encouraged to voluntarily adhere to the so-called **AI Pact**, through which companies begin aligning themselves in advance with the future obligations established by the regulation.

This transitional phase is important because adapting to the AI Act requires:

- large investments,
- technical restructuring,
- specialized personnel,
- and complex compliance procedures.

For this reason, Europe also attempted to avoid imposing disproportionate burdens upon smaller entrepreneurial realities.

18.4 The Risk-Based Approach

The general philosophy of the AI Act is therefore based on balancing:

innovation

and:

risk prevention.

To achieve this, the regulation adopts the so-called:

risk-based approach.

Artificial intelligence systems are classified according to the degree of risk they pose, distinguishing between: **unacceptable risk**, **high risk**, **limited risk**, and **minimal or negligible risk**.

Who is responsible for evaluating these risks?

Primarily, **technicians** and technical experts.

This is one of the clearest examples of how technicians increasingly become a form of **legislators**, because depending on the definitions and classifications they formulate, radically different legal consequences and regulatory frameworks emerge.

A crucial distinction must therefore be understood.

The AI Act generally does not evaluate the risk contained within the technology itself, but rather the risks deriving from:

the application and use of the technology.

This is an important political and juridical choice.

A different approach, one focused on the intrinsic danger of the technology itself, would probably have produced a stricter and more exhaustive regulatory framework. However, such rigidity might also have significantly slowed or even prevented the development and diffusion of artificial intelligence systems.

18.4.1 Definitions and Prohibited Practices

One of the greatest difficulties encountered during the drafting of the AI Act concerned precisely the establishment of shared **definitions**, especially those contained in **Article 3**.

The problem derives from the fact that the European Union is composed of 27 different member states, each carrying different: **historical traditions**, **legal cultures**, **political sensitivities**, and **interpretative approaches**.

All these differences had to converge into a common legislative agreement.

Particular attention was dedicated to the identification of **prohibited applications**, namely practices considered to generate unacceptable risks for fundamental rights and democratic freedoms.

Among the prohibited practices we find the **biometric categorization of sensitive data**, such as: **political beliefs, religious convictions, ethnic origin**, and similar categories.

The objective is to prevent discriminatory practices connected to automated identification systems.

Here clearly emerges one of the major philosophical risks already discussed during the lectures: the reduction of the human being to a mere set of **data**.

Another prohibited practice is the so-called **untargeted scraping of facial images**. Images publicly available online cannot be indiscriminately collected in order to create facial recognition databases without a precise and legitimate objective.

The paradox highlighted is particularly important: systems originally created to protect security and efficiency may progressively transform themselves into instruments of **mass surveillance**.

18.4.2 Social Scoring and Emotion Recognition

Another significant prohibition concerns the use of AI systems for **emotion recognition** within: **workplaces** and **educational environments**.

Although machines do not directly experience emotions, they are becoming increasingly effective at recognizing and classifying emotional states.

This creates the risk of violating human dignity, personal freedom and psychological autonomy.

Particular importance is also given to the prohibition of **social scoring systems**. These systems evaluate citizens through behavioral and social parameters extracted from online activities and digital interactions.

This mechanism is compared to a sort of **point-based driver's license system**, where inadequate behavior progressively produces penalties and restrictions.

Low social scores could potentially lead to: **restricted access to credit, limitations on movement, social exclusion**, or even more severe sanctions.

In this context, every digital trace becomes relevant:

posts, interactions, online behavior, digital preferences.

All these elements may be interpreted through a narrative and algorithmic framework that contributes to constructing the social profile of the individual.

When combined with: **neuroscience**, **storytelling**, **behavioral psychology**, and **predictive analytics**, these technologies become extremely powerful and potentially dangerous instruments of manipulation.

For this reason, the AI Act also prohibits manipulative systems exploiting: **vulnerabilities**, **age**, **health conditions**, or situations of psychological fragility.

18.5 Predictive Policing and Biometric Surveillance

Among the most controversial issues discussed during the negotiations were the **predictive policing** and **real-time biometric recognition**.

The European Parliament strongly resisted the pressure exercised by the Council and by law enforcement authorities seeking broader possibilities for the use of these technologies. This resistance was supported by: **scholars**, **researchers**, **human rights experts**, and specialists in **digital justice**, who warned against the dangers connected to the normalization of pervasive biometric surveillance systems.

However, the prohibition regarding the use of biometric recognition by law enforcement is not absolute.

A series of exceptions were introduced, allowing the use of these technologies in specific circumstances, particularly:

1. situations involving an **imminent terrorist threat**,
2. criminal investigations aimed at locating perpetrators, suspects, or victims of serious crimes,
3. and the prosecution of particularly serious offences.

Here once again emerges one of the fundamental themes repeatedly discussed throughout the course:

the ambiguity of language.

Expressions such as “*serious crime*” or “*suspect*” appear apparently clear, yet they are highly open to interpretation and possible instrumentalization.

A famous reflection by **Anton Chekhov**:

If in the first act of a play there is a gun hanging on the wall, in the following acts someone will eventually fire it.

The meaning of this metaphor is particularly important in the juridical sphere.

Once an exceptional technological power is introduced into the legal system, there is always the risk that its use progressively expands beyond its original limits.

The same problem concerns the notion of **suspect**. Potentially, everyone may become a suspect.

For this reason, the boundaries of the exception risk progressively becoming broader and broader.

Another extremely controversial topic during the drafting of the AI Act concerned the **predictive policing**.

Predictive policing consists in the use of statistical and algorithmic systems aimed at anticipating criminal behavior through the analysis of: **past criminal records, behavioral patterns, profiles**, and other forms of data aggregation.

One of the major achievements obtained by the European Parliament was preventing these systems from directly targeting specific individuals.

Predictive systems may still be used for preventive purposes, but only under strict limitations.

For example:

- they must operate primarily on anonymous data,
- they cannot be directed toward a specific identified person,
- and their use must remain proportionate and supervised.

Such systems may therefore be employed in contexts such as: **hot zones, large demonstrations, public protests, or strikes**.

Yet even in these situations important risks emerge.

If participation in demonstrations or strikes becomes constantly monitored and identifiable through AI systems, this may significantly restrict **political freedom** and **social participation**.

For this reason, the AI Act introduces reinforced safeguards intended to guarantee: **transparency, accountability, and institutional control**.

The use of these technologies by executive authorities, especially police forces, generally requires **ex ante authorization**, meaning prior authorization before deployment.

In urgent situations, authorization may exceptionally arrive shortly afterward, but strict procedural obligations remain.

Issues connected to: **security, terrorism, and law enforcement** continue to reveal the profound differences existing among European states.

Some countries support more intrusive preventive systems, especially in the fight against terrorism, while others fear the emergence of regimes of **digital surveillance**.

Thus, attempts to build common European policies in sensitive fields such as security and defense often reveal the persistence of strong national ideologies and political tensions.

18.6 High-Risk AI Systems

The AI Act also dedicates particular attention to **high-risk AI systems**.

These include systems employed in highly sensitive sectors such as: **healthcare, transport, justice, and public security.**

Such systems must satisfy extremely high standards regarding: **safety, reliability, transparency, and human oversight.**

Companies are required to ensure that these systems are carefully tested and continuously supervised before and during their use.

18.6.1 Human Oversight and Algorithmic Fallibility

Particular importance is assigned to the principle of **human supervision.**

The objective is to avoid situations in which entirely automated decisions may negatively affect human rights without meaningful human control.

A famous historical example illustrating this necessity: the case of **Stanislav Petrov.**

Petrov was a Soviet military officer responsible for monitoring the nuclear early-warning system during the Cold War. On September 26, 1983, Soviet satellites detected what appeared to be an incoming American nuclear attack. The alarm system identified five missiles heading toward Soviet territory. According to the protocol, Petrov should have immediately informed his superiors, potentially initiating a nuclear counterattack. However, something appeared suspicious to him. An actual American first strike would probably not have involved only five missiles. Instead of blindly trusting the algorithmic signal, Petrov decided to wait. Twenty-three minutes later it became clear that the alarm was false. The system had made an error.

This episode demonstrates the fundamental importance of the **human factor** within decision-making processes.

Unlike machines, human beings experience: **responsibility, doubt, ethical hesitation,** and the existential weight connected to decisions.

For this reason, according to the logic underlying the AI Act, artificial intelligence systems should support human judgment, but should never entirely replace it in sensitive contexts involving human lives and fundamental rights.

The problem, however, is that even human supervision is not always reliable.

A famous example is the tragic case of the **Smiler roller coaster** accident in the United Kingdom.

Two engineers responsible for maintenance operations failed to notice that a carriage had remained blocked on the track. When the roller coaster was reopened to the public, the safety algorithms correctly detected the anomaly and raised an alarm signal. Nevertheless, the engineers manually deactivated the warning system, convinced that the repair had already solved the issue. The consequence was catastrophic. In this case, the machine had correctly identified the danger, while the human beings made the fatal mistake.

This episode reveals one of the deepest problems emerging from the relationship between:

the **human fallibility** and **algorithmic fallibility**.

If algorithms may fail, but human beings may also fail, then an open philosophical and juridical question arises:

Who should ultimately have the final decision-making authority?

For this reason, the AI Act requires not only preventive controls before market deployment, but also **post-market monitoring systems**.

These mechanisms aim to verify, over medium and long-term periods, whether AI systems continue respecting: **fundamental rights**, **safety standards**, and **regulatory obligations**.

Companies operating high-risk AI systems are therefore subject to: **continuous oversight**, **compliance obligations**, and **ongoing supervision**.

18.6.2 Transparency and Political Manipulation

Particular attention is dedicated to systems capable of influencing **electoral processes** or **political behavior**.

We can see several famous examples of **deepfakes**, such as: **the fake images of Donald Trump being arrested** or **the AI-generated image of the Pope wearing Balenciaga**.

Even when clearly false, these contents spread extremely rapidly and may produce: **political consequences**, **economic effects**, **market instability**, and distortions in public opinion.

The AI Act therefore adopts what may be described as a:

proactive risk-prevention approach.

The objective is not simply to punish abuses afterward, but rather to: **prevent**, **contain**, and **mitigate** the dangers associated with unregulated AI deployment.

For AI systems classified as **limited risk**, such as many chatbots, obligations are significantly lighter.

In these cases, regulation mainly focuses on **transparency obligations**.

Users must simply be informed that they are interacting with an artificial intelligence system rather than with a human being.

Systems considered **minimal risk** or practically risk-free, such as: **video game AI**, **recommendation filters**, or similar technologies, enjoy much broader operational freedom.

18.7 General Purpose AI Systems

Another extremely important area of discussion concerned the **General Purpose AI systems (GPAI)**, namely advanced AI models capable of performing a wide variety of tasks such as: **text generation, image creation, translation, reasoning**, and other complex operations.

These systems were classified according to the American criterion based on **FLOPS** (*Floating Operations Per Second*), that is, according to their computational power rather than their economic revenue.

Particularly powerful GPAI systems capable of generating **systemic risks** are classified as **high-impact systems**.

The threshold established by the regulation corresponds approximately to 10^{25} FLOPS, an enormous computational capacity currently possessed only by a very small number of actors, such as: **ChatGPT, Gemini, or DeepSeek**.

Here emerges another interesting juridical paradox.

Law, by its nature, should remain **general** and **abstract**, meaning that it should not be written specifically for individual subjects.

Yet in this case it is quite evident that the regulation effectively addresses only a handful of extremely large technological operators.

High-impact systems are therefore required to comply with particularly rigorous obligations.

Before entering the market, these systems must undergo: **risk assessment procedures, danger evaluation**, and the implementation of:

risk mitigation strategies.

In addition, companies are obliged to report incidents and relevant problems to the **AI Office**, the supervisory body established by the European framework.

For non-high-impact GPAI systems, obligations are less strict and mainly concern: **cybersecurity, technical robustness, transparency of training data**, and the sharing of technical documentation.

The notion of **robustness** indicates the system's capacity to resist: **attacks, malfunctions**, or accidental failures while maintaining operational reliability.

18.7.1 Regulatory Sandboxes

Finally, regarding AI systems developed purely for **research purposes**, the AI Act adopts a more flexible approach.

In this context the regulation introduces the concept of **regulatory sandboxes**.

A sandbox is an experimental environment where companies and researchers may test innovative systems under partially relaxed regulatory conditions.

The idea is to encourage experimentation while simultaneously preparing actors to progressively adapt to the future legal framework.

The logic underlying these sandboxes may be summarized as:

First experiment with the technology, then progressively regulate it.

18.8 Sanctions and Enforcement

Let us now move to the system of sanctions established by the AI Act.

As previously observed, the entry into force of the regulation follows a **progressive timeline**, with different compliance stages distributed over periods ranging approximately from 6, 12, and 24 months.

The objective is to allow companies and institutions enough time to adapt their organizational and technical structures to the new legal framework.

However, failure to comply with the obligations established by the AI Act may lead to **very severe financial sanctions**.

The amount of the fines varies according to:

- the seriousness of the violation,
- and the economic size of the company involved.

This reflects the juridical principle of **proportionality of punishment**, which aims to avoid excessively penalizing smaller entrepreneurial realities and start-ups.

The most severe violations, especially those involving **prohibited AI practices**, may result in sanctions reaching 35 million euros or 7% of the company's annual global turnover. Other forms of non-compliance may instead lead to sanctions up to 15 million euros or 3% of the annual turnover.

Finally, when companies provide: **incorrect, misleading, or incomplete technical documentation**, sanctions may reach 7.5 million euros or 1.5% of the global annual turnover.

At first sight, these numbers appear enormous.

However, a fundamental problem already encountered in other sectors arises, particularly in environmental law.

If violations merely produce **economic sanctions**, large corporations may begin treating fines simply as **operational costs**.

In other words, if the economic advantage obtained through the unlawful practice exceeds the financial penalty imposed afterward, the sanction may fail to function as a real deterrent.

This mechanism recalls what often happens with **environmental crimes**, where ecological destruction risks becoming financially manageable and therefore incorporated into the company's economic calculations.

18.9 Military Exclusion and the Problem of Profit

Another extremely delicate aspect concerns the fact that **military uses of artificial intelligence** remain substantially excluded from the AI Act framework.

This means that AI technologies developed for: **warfare, military operations, or defense purposes** continue to exist within a much more permissive and weakly regulated space.

This exclusion raises profound ethical and political questions.

For example:

How can we meaningfully discuss the protection of human rights if artificial intelligence employed in military contexts remains largely outside these safeguards?

Finally, a broader reflection.

The major corporations financing and developing artificial intelligence systems structurally operate according to **economic logic** and **profit maximization**.

A crucial question therefore emerges:

Can companies whose primary objective is profit genuinely pursue the public interest at the same time?

This final problem reconnects the AI Act discussion with the broader themes repeatedly addressed throughout the course: the relationship between: **technology, capitalism, power, control, and human freedom**.

Appendix 1: The AI Act

The resource is available here:

[https://eur-lex.europa.eu/legal-content/EN/TXT/HTML/?uri=OJ:
L_202401689](https://eur-lex.europa.eu/legal-content/EN/TXT/HTML/?uri=OJ:L_202401689)

Appendix 2: Heidegger Glossary

Key concepts and German terminology

Ability-to-be	Seinkönnen
Abyss	Abgrund
Aletheia	ἀλήθεια
Anxiety and Fear	Angst / Furcht
Anyone, the	das Man
Authenticity	Eigentlichkeit
Availableness	Zuhandenheit
Being (in Being and Time)	Sein
Being (after Being and Time)	Sein
Being-in-the-world	In-der-Welt-sein
Being-with	Mitsein
Care	Sorge
Circumspection	Umsicht
Clearing	Lichtung
Coping	Umgang
Curiosity	Neugier
Dasein	Dasein
Death	Tod
Destiny	Geschick
Disposedness	Befindlichkeit

Ek-sistence	Ek-sistenz
Everydayness	Alltäglichkeit
Existence	Existenz
Existential and Existentiell	Existenzial / Existenziell
Falling	Verfallen
Finitude	Endlichkeit
God or Gods	Gott / Götter
Good	das Gut / ἀγαθόν / bonum
Hermeneutics	Hermeneutik
Horizon	Horizont
Human Being	Mensch
Identity	Identität
Idle Talk	Gerede
Imagination	Einbildung / Einbildungskraft
Inventory / Syn-thetic Com-posit(ion)ing	Ge-Stell
Leap	Springen
Occurrentness	Vorhandenheit
Sense	Sinn
Standing Reserve	Bestand
Subject, Subjectivity	Subjekt / Subjektivität
Technology	Technik
Temporality	Temporalität / Zeitlichkeit
Thrownness	Geworfenheit
Time	Zeit
Topology	Topologie
Transition	Übergang
Uncanniness	Unheimlichkeit
Understanding	Verstehen

Value

Wert

World

Welt